

Flipping a Floodplain: A Case Study of Gentrification in Columbus, Ohio

Dissertation

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By

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Abstract

Building on classic urban sociology (DuBois 1899; Park and Burgess 1925), this dissertation examines gentrification in a context of rising inequality, urban revival, and housing insecurity. While acknowledging the value of both qualitative and quantitative approaches (Brown-Saracino 2017), this mixed methods study bridges the gap by examining gentrification in Columbus, Ohio's Franklinton neighborhood. Chapter 1 introduces the topic of gentrification, highlights Franklinton as the study site, and sets the stage for the rest of the dissertation. Chapter 2 uses quantitative data (demographics, housing, etc.) to showcase the neighborhood's changes since 1970 and examines multiple gentrification indices, arguing that single gentrification indices miss crucial nuances while also showcasing evidence that the neighborhood is plausibly gentrifying. Chapter 3 explores the interplay of public, private, and civic forces in shaping the neighborhood's gentrification. Chapter 4 delves into residents' lived experiences, revealing both positive and negative aspects of gentrification. This dissertation offers a comprehensive picture of Franklinton's gentrification, from the perspectives of decisionmakers and residents and through data analysis. It highlights the role of top-down forces, the complexities of residents' experiences, and the value of using multifaceted quantitative data. This work contributes to our understanding of gentrification and its complexities in a time of rapid urban change.

Dedication

To my family, friends, and Huda.

Acknowledgments

Someone once told me that graduate school was a marathon, and I think that's an apt description of my experience, including an actual marathon I ran in 2023. It has taken 6 years to finish, and I would not have been able to accomplish it without the support of many people in my life and the community in Columbus and at Ohio State. For their support, I would like to thank my committee, Dr. Townsend Price-Spratlen, Dr. Christopher Browning, and Dr. Dana Haynie, for all their mentoring over the last few years. Their invaluable mentorship pushed me to think critically, explore new avenues in my research, and ultimately become a stronger sociologist.

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Publications

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Chapter 1. Introduction

Sociologists have long been captivated by the ever-shifting landscape of cities and neighborhoods, stretching from the foundational works of Marx and Engels, to the groundbreaking Chicago and Atlanta Schools, and all the way to the contemporary field of Critical Urban Sociology. These scholars have meticulously documented the processes that transform neighborhoods, the forces driving these changes, and their profound impacts on society (DuBois 1899; Engels 1872; Harvey 1973; Park and Burgess 1925). The past half-century has seen a surge of urban issues: crime, suburbanization, poverty, white flight, abandonment, gentrification, and more. Globalization, capitalism, and the rise of urban living have reshaped these problems and the power dynamics at play.

In an era of widening income inequality and housing insecurity, cities are increasingly seen as battlegrounds – particularly in the realm of housing, where gentrification thrives (Newman and Wyly 2006; Wyly and Hammel 1999; Zukin 1987). Some view this as an organic process (Blasius, Friedrichs, and Rühl 2016; Clay 1979) while others emphasize the role of urban elites, developers, city governments, and other powerful institutions (Clay 1979; Cox 2020; Harvey 1974; Logan and Molotch 1987; Marcuse 2009; Stone 1989), which increasingly drive gentrification from the top-down (Aalbers 2019; Aalbers and Christophers 2014; Uitermark and Bosker 2014; Wyly 2022). However, there gentrification pressures can coexist and only tell one part of the story.

Understanding gentrification's full impact requires examining the lived experiences of both long-term residents and newcomers (Brown-Saracino 2017; Freeman 2005, 2006).

Previous research on gentrification has often been limited by its reliance on a single methodological approach. Studies focused solely on quantitative data (e.g., property values, demographics) can capture broad trends but miss the lived experiences of residents (Bunten, Preis, and Aron-Dine 2023; Hepburn, Louis, and Desmond 2024). Conversely, qualitative research (e.g., interviews, ethnography) offers rich insights into individual experiences but struggles to generalize findings (Immergluck 2022; Schusler, Krings, and Melstrom 2023). Scholars have highlighted the need to bridge this gap to provide a better understanding of gentrification (Brown-Saracino 2017; Finio 2022; Knieriem 2023).

This dissertation addresses this gap by employing a mixed-methods approach that combines quantitative and qualitative data, which allows for a more comprehensive understanding of gentrification. By using quantitative measures of gentrification, interviews, archival research, and ethnography, this study will explore the complexities of neighborhood change and its impact on residents. This approach is particularly valuable as gentrification cannot be neatly categorized under a single definition, as some scholars have done in the past (Finio 2022; Freeman 2005; Hammel and Wyly 1996; Landis 2016; Vigdor, Massey, and Rivlin 2002). Under some definitions, scholars use a singular variable to describe gentrification, like increased median household income, while others rely on complicated indices. On the other hand, some measure and define gentrification through interviews and lived experience (Brown-Saracino 2017). As such, some have argued that gentrification could be described as a “moving target” (Knieriem 2023: 4).

By combining methods, we can gain a deeper understanding of the quantitative outcomes that residents experience, how powerful decisionmakers influence neighborhood change, and how residents perceive development. This can illuminate whether these consequences are as severe as qualitative studies often suggest, or as lacking credibility as some quantitative research implies (Brown-Saracino 2017; Charmaz 2014).

This research grounds itself in the Franklinton neighborhood of Columbus, Ohio. Franklinton is a neighborhood in the city of Columbus, just west of its downtown, that was the first American settlement in Franklin County and the county seat until 1824. Franklinton was annexed and incorporated by the city of Columbus in 1859, and is often referred to as “the Bottoms,” both for its susceptibility to being flooded from the Scioto and Olentangy Rivers, and for its high concentration of poverty (Zachariah et al. 2019). However, this and every neighborhood’s changes do not occur within a vacuum. Notably, Columbus has seen a simultaneous increase in population and housing costs over the last several decades, as it is the only steadily growing city in Ohio (Ferenchik, Bush, and Kovac 2021). This lack of affordable housing makes Franklinton, and Columbus more broadly, an epicenter for housing insecurity, potentially exacerbating displacement of vulnerable populations, including low-income residents and minorities. These rapid development and changes in Columbus, as shown by the “Columbus Way”, a partnership between public and private institutions (Cox 1991, 2020; Rivkin 2015). This highlights capitalism’s continued influence on urban development (Castells 1977; Harvey 1973; Marcuse 2009).

Additionally, consistent with the growing trend of mixed methods gentrification research (Loukaitou-Sideris, Gonzalez, and Ong 2019), this dissertation aims to bridge the gap between qualitative and quantitative gentrification research by exploring the socio-political-legal-economic forces that drive changes in Franklinton, residents' perceptions of change, and data-driven evidence of these changes. With cities constantly evolving under the influence of capital and modernity, research on gentrification and how it unfolds remains crucial.

Broadly, the research questions that motivate this work are as follows: 1) How has Franklinton quantitatively changed over time, and do gentrification indices indicate gentrification occurred?; 2) What is the power structure of the political economy of development in Franklinton and Columbus, and how do they make decisions?; and 3) What are the lived experiences of Franklinton residents, and how do they make sense of the neighborhood's changes? As such, the following chapters will highlight the work of both qualitative and quantitative gentrification scholars, before detailing the specific methods used in this study. Subsequent sections will review explore the political economy and urban governance literature and its relation to the case study site. Additionally, there will be an exploration of the lived experiences associated with gentrification. Finally, the dissertation concludes by offering a brief overview of each chapter's findings, all of which point to evidence that Franklinton is plausibly gentrifying, and the contributions to the field of gentrification research.

This chapter delves into existing scholarship on gentrification, urbanization, neighborhood change, and quantitative research methods used to identify, measure, and analyze gentrification. Then, it addresses how past research suggests political economy,

urban governance, and social organization can influence city development and can play key roles in gentrification. The last section will highlight the need for further research in new cities, the lack of community resistance to gentrification, and the complexities of race in gentrifying historically white neighborhoods.

Literature and Background

Originally coined by Glass (1964), gentrification has become a prominent and contentious topic within urban studies. With rising housing costs across the country, an increasingly urbanized population, and urban life becoming more common, gentrification research is becoming more important and popular, even amongst the public. Yet, within urban studies, there is great debate on the prevalence of gentrification, how to measure it, and its impacts (Agbai 2021; Finio 2022; Hepburn et al. 2024). Zukin (1987) defines gentrification as “the conversion of socially marginal and working-class areas of the central city to middle-class residential use, reflects a movement, that began in the 1960s, of private -market investment capital into downtown districts of major urban center” (129). Meanwhile, Smith (1987) describes it as “the transformation of inner-city working-class and other neighborhoods to middle-and upper-middle-class residential, recreational, and other uses” (462). Some view this as an organic, linear process (Blasius et al. 2016; Clay 1979), while most modern scholars view it as a manifestation of capital and power, driven by decisionmakers (Moskowitz 2018; Van Gent and Boterman 2019).

Place, power, history, and neighborhood effects all are tied into urban studies and gentrification. Much research on gentrification has focused on some of America’s most populous and influential cities, including Washington D.C., New York City, and San Francisco (Freeman 2006; Valli 2015). Other studies have explored gentrification outside of the core American cities, including Portland, Minneapolis, and Atlanta, which has set

the groundwork for this Midwestern story of gentrification (Hammel and Wyly 1996; Immergluck 2022; Sullivan 2007). This dissertation's focus on Franklinton and the city of Columbus pushes us to think about gentrification outside of the largest, most-iconic American cities and to consider the ways in which gentrification occurs in other places. Franklinton as a case study is unique because it is a predominantly white neighborhood in a medium-sized Midwestern city with over 2 million people in the metropolitan area. Additionally, it is a newly gentrifying neighborhood in an era of widening income inequality in the U.S., rising housing costs, and access to global capital.

Quantitative Measurement of Gentrification

The politics of knowledge production related to gentrification remains hotly contested. Although some qualitative scholars of gentrification privilege the lived experience of people in gentrifying neighborhoods (Zukin 1987), noting the shortcomings of secondary data analysis, quantitative methods hold importance within the study of gentrification (Reades et al. 2019). Rather than take a stand one way or the other, some scholars suggest that we utilize all data that we have available to effectively analyze neighborhood change (Brown-Saracino 2017; Easton et al. 2020; Iyanda and Lu 2022; Johnson et al. 2022).

There are many ways to quantitatively study gentrification. Quantitative measurement of gentrification itself remains up for debate, as gentrification has no central definition (Finio 2022). Researchers have used various data, including coffee shops, businesses, race, class, education, etc. The most notable articles analyze changes in neighborhoods based on class, income, and education based on different time frames and geographies (Freeman 2005; Hammel and Wyly 1996; Landis 2016; Vigdor et al.

2002). Further, there are various quantitative methods to identifying gentrification, including regression, machine learning, and systematic social observation (Dahir, Hwang, and Yu 2024a; Lee and Newman 2021; Reades et al. 2019). This has led some scholars to identify gentrification as a “moving target” that warrants changing our conception of as cities and our economic systems do (Knieriem 2023). As such, an exploratory approach to studying gentrification variables can be incredibly insightful. In this dissertation, I focus on three main gentrification indices alongside descriptive statistics. Additionally, measuring gentrification and displacement using conventional demographic data is difficult; however, using proprietary consumer databases allows this study to determine migration flows into and out of neighborhoods undergoing gentrification.

Political Economy and Urban Governance

While some portray gentrification as an inevitable consequence of "creative class" migration, driven by artists and young professionals seeking lower rents (Clay 1979; Florida 2003; Workman 2011), this perspective overlooks the complex interplay of global capital flows, diverse urban governance structures, and specific policy decisions (Harvey 1973; Immergluck 2022; Levy, Comey, and Padilla 2007; Logan and Molotch 1987; Smith 1987; Stone 1989). These approaches can be described as top-down in contrast with more pluralistic approaches.

Scholarship on the political economy of cities sheds light on the power dynamics that shape gentrification. For instance, Marxist critiques of urban studies highlight how outlined how the creation and evolution of cities is far from an organic process. Spatial and social processes are influenced and reproduced by capitalist forces (Castells 1977; Harvey 1973; Smith 1987). These urban regimes often pursue their own interests,

furthering social and class inequalities through their influence and capital (Harvey 2009). In a more Weberian approach, Logan and Molotch's (1987) influential "growth machine" model highlights how urban elites prioritize development and growth across various sectors, often at the expense of vulnerable communities but not necessarily with the direct intention of exploitation. This top-down view of urban governance engages with Marxist views of development and Critical Urban Sociology, and recent research engages with this perspective (Aalbers 2019; Immergluck 2022; Moskowitz 2018).

On the other hand, pluralistic approaches challenge these top-down views of governance. Giddens' (1979) structuration theory challenges simplistic top-down views of urban governance. It suggests a constant interplay between social structures and individual actions. In other words, structures shape people's actions, but people's actions also shape and reshape those structures. This perspective encourages scholars to consider the agency of residents, community organizations, and social movements in shaping their cities' development. Similarly, Stone's (1989, 1993) work on Atlanta's "regime politics" explores the relationships between elected officials and powerful individuals or groups, taking note of the numeracy of actors outside of elites. Within neighborhoods themselves, regimes and pluralistic perspectives on governance also exist. Neighborhood regimes, largely informal coalitions of private, public, and civic sectors interact to influence development (Fusch 1980; Webb 2013).

While scholars often fail to merge these approaches, I suggest that they both can play a role, especially as neighborhoods and social structures evolve over a long period of time. New Urban Politics provides an example of this, as it describes into the overlapping webs of power that shapes cities, and provides a useful framework for understanding

gentrification and contemporary urban governance (Cox 1991). It challenges traditional views of top-down decision-making, arguing that urban elites like wealthy developers and investors do not solely dictate the course of a city, like Logan and Molotch (1987) suggest. Instead, Cox emphasizes collaboration between these elites and city officials, often through public-private partnerships while also acknowledging the presence of residents and community organizations. Thus, it provides a better framework to theorizing gentrification because it combines pluralistic and regime perspectives while stressing the importance of understanding the specific historical context and power structures within each city. Related to this framework, the Franklinton case study is a prime example under the "Columbus Way," where collaboration guides development projects (Cox 2020; Rivkin 2015). Here, local context helps explain the nuanced ways that gentrification and other urban development issues unfold in different places.

Lived Experience of Gentrification

While the decisions made by the political economy matter significantly in driving gentrification, the lived experience of residents amidst gentrification has also been critical to gentrification research. Urban scholars have long found significant utility in ethnography and interviews for researching community and social phenomenon (Desmond 2012; DuBois 1899; Pattillo 2013; Price-Spratlen 2022; Whyte 1993). This rich qualitative tradition continues and plays an important part in gentrification research. As Brown-Saracino (2017) says, a significant portion of gentrification research is qualitative and relies on interviews and ethnography. These qualitative scholars often focus on one neighborhood or city and recognize the dire consequences of gentrification for long-term residents.

In qualitative research on gentrification, scholars uncover nuanced findings. Residents report experiencing both positive and negative effects, with varying levels of concern about displacement. These experiences often differ based on race, class, and housing tenure. For instance, Freeman (2006) utilizes interviews to understand the perceptions of gentrification among Black residents of New York City. These interviews paint a nuanced picture of gentrification wherein residents displayed cynicism and optimism towards neighborhood changes. Other researchers also interview residents to study gentrification and found similar tensions (Newman and Wyly 2003); however, there are often differences along racial lines (Sullivan 2007). In Bushwick, a neighborhood in New York City, Valli (2015) finds that long-term residents were most likely to identify gentrification as a negative phenomenon. Meanwhile, Brahinsky (2020) uses interviews to identify narratives of gentrification and neighborhood change in San Francisco, finding that there are varying narratives and counternarratives that cut across class and racial lines.

Within Columbus itself, qualitative gentrification research is also extensive across recent generations (Bryant 2005; Carlsten 2019; Fusch 1980; Mergler 1984; Sweeney 2014; Webb 2013; Workman 2011). Scholars have studied Victorian Village, German Village, Shorth North, Italian Village, Old Towne East, and Franklinton—all with vastly different histories, residents, and narratives. Some draw on interviews with community actors, residents, artists, farmers, and various other groups to study narratives of gentrification, perceptions, and its impacts. These scholars find that race, neighborhood tenure, and place inform residents' perceptions of gentrification. In order to write a more credible and comprehensive narrative around Franklinton's gentrification and

development, it is necessary to examine the perceptions of residents, both through ethnography and interviews, and quantitative data. The beneficial use of each will consider many of the ways in which perceptions sometimes tell a different story from the quantitative data. As such, both quantitative and qualitative methodologies for studying gentrification should be used (Barton 2016a; Reades et al. 2019).

Overview of Chapters

This dissertation focuses on three central topics related to gentrification. First, I examine quantitative data related to gentrification, which is notoriously difficult to operationalize and measure, with some focusing on cultural markers (Zukin 1987) and others focusing on measures of income, education, and various other quantitative measures (Brown-Saracino 2017; Finio 2022). To provide a greater depth of understanding of the changes ongoing in Franklinton, I use data from the United States Census Bureau, the Columbus Division of Police, and the Franklinton Development Association in order to provide a full picture.

Within the literature of quantitative measurement of gentrification, there are a variety of indices measuring the phenomenon, with some using or excluding variables including race, class, income, and housing values (Barton 2016a; Immergluck 2009, 2022). The choices to include and exclude variables matter, as they determine whether a neighborhood is at-risk of gentrifying, currently gentrifying, or have been gentrified. As such, I utilize and examine several gentrification indices across time and space to identify whether Franklinton is a gentrifying community. This approach also allows the study to identify which areas of the neighborhood are experiencing the greatest changes. Through this exploratory approach, I find that Franklinton and its census tracts have experienced rapid change and gentrification, sometimes in contradictory ways. Notably, this data is

situated in time and space with the potential for the neighborhood—and the city—to change dramatically within the next few years.

Second, I explore the role of the political economy and urban governance in shaping and gentrifying Franklinton. The political economy, made up of urban elites, pushes for growth within the city. Through the Marxist lens, they trade land and homes as commodities to be profited off of rather than places to live and exist (Logan and Molotch 1987). Meanwhile, the urban regime model (Stone 1989) focuses on plurality and complicated agreements that public and private entities make in order to execute governance and exists at different levels of government, including the neighborhood level (Webb 2013). However, these approaches each have some explanatory power to understanding gentrification in Franklinton. These approaches identify the numerous stakeholders and decisionmakers in the political economy and urban governance while also recognizing the power differentials that exist and often perpetuate inequality (Cox 1991, 2020).

Through interviews, archival research, and ethnography, I draw on three perspectives to understand the principal drivers of gentrification longitudinally in the Franklinton case study. I find that within Franklinton, a neighborhood regime emerged but has since been subsumed by powerful private and public forces that push development in a top-down manner from the city and from private interests. Furthermore, I find that members of the political economy rely heavily on supply-side arguments for housing and downplay the displacement of Franklinton residents. This most closely aligns with the stages that Moskowitz (2018) outlined but heavily relies on rationales from other scholars (Cox 1991; Harvey 2009; Logan and Molotch 1987; Webb 2013).

For the final chapter of the dissertation, I study the lived experience of gentrification in Franklinton. Given that Franklinton has been and is a poor, predominantly white neighborhood and that gentrification research primarily focuses on the role of race in gentrification, the study provides a significant contribution to gentrification literature. Through interviews and ethnography, I find that residents explain life in Franklinton as heavily impoverished and crime ridden. However, residents also describe close relationships with neighbors yet describe the loss of community brought about by gentrification, suggesting that there are both positives and negatives to gentrification often along racial and class lines (Newman and Wyly 2003; Sullivan 2007). Interestingly, residents fail to describe any organized pushback against gentrification, which appears to be related to the fact that the neighborhood is predominantly white, and most new residents are also white (Hwang and Sampson 2014). This lack of racial division may result in complacency in white residents, as they may be less likely to see the potential downsides of gentrification, which provides evidence for the existence of racial capitalism and racial hegemony in reproducing economic oppression (Rucks-Ahidiana 2022). At the same time, the social disorganization and distrust in the neighborhood plays a role in preventing organized resistance to gentrification.

Finally, the dissertation concludes with a summary of findings, describing the multi-faceted and nuanced findings and the utility of studying gentrification through a mixed methods lens, using Franklinton as a case study. Notably, the gentrification of Franklinton is situated in time and space, in a certain political moment, in an increasingly urbanized, capitalist country and globe (Brenner, Marcuse, and Mayer 2012; Castells 1977; Cox 1991; Harvey 1973). This dissertation examines the gentrification of

Franklinton through quantitative data, the lens of development politics, and residents' experiences. The research employs quantitative measures to assess gentrification's footprint, acknowledging differing perspectives on its definition. The analysis explores the complex interplay between long-term residents facing displacement, newcomers navigating a changing area, and the forces of public and private investment driving gentrification's improvement and displacement. While residents are acutely aware of these transformations, they lack organized resistance, which may be related to long-standing racial tensions and social disorganization. The concluding sections discuss the study's theoretical and practical contributions, outlining avenues for further exploration.

Chapter 2. A Quantitative Spatial Exploration of Gentrification

Abstract

Gentrification remains difficult to measure because gentrification itself lacks a cohesive definition. While some focus on cultural markers (Zukin 1987), others focus on quantitative methods (Brown-Saracino 2017). Even within quantitative gentrification literature, a variety of indices are used to measure the phenomenon, which can lead to varying neighborhoods indicating that they are at-risk of gentrifying, currently gentrifying, or have been gentrified. While some focus on race and class, others look at median household income, and housing values (Barton 2016a; Immergluck 2009, 2022). To better understand gentrification in the Franklinton neighborhood of Columbus, Ohio, the current study conducts various quantitative analyses of gentrification over time via descriptive statistics, gentrification indices, and migration flows between other neighborhoods, showing how the neighborhood has changed over time and identifying gentrification in Franklinton.

Introduction

Under modern economic restructuring, the financialization of housing, and a booming real estate market, cities are pressed to address a plethora of challenges, including housing affordability, homelessness, and gentrification. To address these issues, academics, organizations, and government agencies utilize gentrification measures to identify where gentrification occurs and the pace at which the process moves. However, quantitative definitions of gentrification vary widely, leading to differences in results, with massive implications for addressing gentrification and the affordable housing crisis.

Within the booming midwestern city of Columbus, Ohio (Cox 2020), Franklinton is a neighborhood in change, perhaps the most visibly in the city. Massive apartment complexes have sprouted up with an adult playground in the works (Wiley 2023). Other neighborhoods, like Victorian Village and German Village, have already experienced gentrification decades ago, but in Franklinton, this is up for debate (Mergler 1984). News articles have claimed that within Franklinton, there is “gentrification without the negative”, while others have discussed displacement as a result of increasing development in the area (Carlsten 2019; The Atlantic 2014).

To better understand change in Franklinton, I conduct a variety of quantitative analyses of gentrification over time via descriptive statistics, gentrification indices, mapping, and migration data. To understand the changes of the community, I analyze data on household income, racial/ethnic composition, poverty, crime, and rents, among various other descriptives (Finio 2022), demonstrating the neighborhood’s changes over time. I also analyze three different measures of gentrification, suggesting that gentrification is plausibly occurring (Brown-Saracino 2017; Freeman 2005; Landis 2016;

Vigdor et al. 2002). Spatially, I use geographic information systems (GIS) to create maps and demonstrate changes in the neighborhood over time, particularly as it relates to where residents of Franklinton move and originate from. Altogether, I triangulate these findings to provide a complete picture of Franklinton's changes over time.

This work contributes to quantitative research on gentrification, showing that there are many ways to measure and describe gentrification. Further, this work highlights that there can be simultaneous and sometimes contradictory findings within quantitative work. As I show, focusing on one definition of gentrification or variable fails to address the complexity of change in a gentrifying neighborhood, with significant implications for governments, neighborhood organizations, and housing developers. This is not to say that quantitative measures of gentrification are useless—far from it. Instead, the study suggests that various measures of gentrification and other methods of conducting research should be utilized in conjunction with qualitative methods to better understand neighborhood change and gentrification. Despite these drawbacks of quantitative work, it still matters since it can show where and to what degree class change occurs (Reades et al. 2019).

Additionally, this work serves as a case study of gentrification in a predominantly white, inner-city neighborhood. This study and its findings could be used in addressing concerns related to gentrification, especially for city and county officials, non-profit agencies, and affordable housing developers within Central Ohio. Lastly, this study could be used by natives of Franklinton to give leverage against some of the claims that Franklinton is experiencing gentrification “without the negative”.

Literature and Background

What is gentrification?

First introduced by Glass (1964), gentrification was used to describe the (re)introduction of the gentry class into London. Over time, the gentry displaced lower-income members of the community they lived in, and this is thought of as an unfortunate outcome of displacement and succession (Freeman 2005; Shaw 2008). However, gentrification has come to include a multitude of meanings over the years, including being an intentional process of the land-owning class to charge higher rents and drive up profit margins via exchange values (Harvey 1973, 1974; Pattillo 2013; Smith 1987, 2005). Other definitions focus primarily on race (Rucks-Ahidiana 2022), class (Clay 1979; Harvey 1974), culture (Zukin 1987, 2016), quantitative measures (Easton et al. 2020), and moral issues related to displacement (Marcuse 2015). Interdisciplinary scholars from sociology, geography, urban planning, public health, and the arts widely acknowledge this lack of agreement over operationalizing gentrification and measuring it (Agbai 2021; Barton 2016a; Brown-Saracino 2017; Finio 2022; Reades et al. 2019; Shaw 2008). However, gentrification can generally be defined as a process of neighborhood change where higher income residents and real estate investment reshape the demographics and built environment of a lower-income neighborhood (Richardson, Mitchell, and Franco 2019). Nevertheless, it is important to explore the variety of measures utilized in gentrification scholarship.

Previous Gentrification Measures

While there is a more general definition of gentrification, the way we operationalize and study the phenomenon matter, for they could have far-reaching implications on research and urban policy. To target gentrification, one must be able to

measure it, or at least be able to operationalize it, and exploring these methods highlights just how different quantitative measurement can be.

One of the first quantitative studies of gentrification was conducted by Spain (1980), who measured the revitalization of inner-city neighborhoods and the number of white people replacing black people in the central city. The author also compared the educational attainment and income of black residents displaced with that of the white gentrifiers to determine whether gentrification occurred, identifying gentrification as a racial and class phenomenon, finding mixed support for black-to-white succession in the 1970s. However, this was not an actual index of gentrification with a cutoff suggesting whether gentrification occurred or not, and it only focused on Black-White gentrification. One of the first quantitative measures of gentrification was proposed by Hammel and Wyly (1996). They gathered census data and conducted a field survey of neighborhoods in Minneapolis-St. Paul and created nine variables to define gentrification. Just as the choice of definition matters, so do temporal and spatial choices. Hammel and Wyly utilized census tracts and used decades between 1960 and 1990 to understand gentrification. In addition, they conducted fieldwork to identify where housing and neighborhood improvements took place, which is a key indicator of gentrification. Their model of gentrification somewhat accurately predicted whether a tract was gentrifying and received heavy reinvestment. While fieldwork and their model are quite unique, it is difficult to replicate nationwide with publicly available data and requires significant fieldwork.

Building on Hammel and Wyly, Bostic and Martin (2003) identified gentrification when neighborhoods changed from less than 50% of the median household income of a

metropolitan statistical area to above 50%, with their cutoff acting as the beginning and end of a decade. They also included various measures used by Hammel and Wyly to study Black gentrification. While this is a simple measure that can be captured with census data, it fails to acknowledge smaller changes and the spectrum of gentrification and reinvestment that can occur. The authors found that Black homeowners acted as a gentrifying force in the 1970s. Since these initial measures of gentrification were created, the study of the phenomenon has only grown more complex.

As quantitative methods and data science have progressed, scholars have begun to use more complex methods to study gentrification. In a systematic review of 179 quantitative gentrification articles, scholars created measures and used different variables to study gentrification, including age, race, taxes, income, vacancy, rent, occupation, crime, and prevalence of coffee shops (Finio 2022). Meanwhile, some authors use machine learning and big data to measure gentrification (Reades et al. 2019). Through machine learning, the authors conducted an analysis of change in London neighborhoods to predict whether neighborhoods are likely to improve or decline in the future. Beyond machine learning, some scholars have even begun using Google Street View and computational methods to study gentrification by calculating the presence of litter and trash and 311 requests for trash cleanup (Dahir, Hwang, and Yu 2024b).

As shown, there are a multitude of ways to identify gentrification using quantitative variables and capture different ways of conceptualizing gentrification. Since the 1980s, gentrification research has dramatically expanded, as has the ways that quantitative measurement of gentrification is conducted (Finio 2022). The differences are astounding and ever-growing. The gentrification and methods that Spain (1980) and

Reades et al. (2019) conduct capture entirely different time periods and phenomenon of American cities. While uncertainties with how best to study gentrification with quantitative studies remain at odds internally, it is even more in conflict with qualitative work.

Methodological Divide

Within sociology and the social sciences, there already is a large methodological divide between quantitative and qualitative scholars, yet this is especially present in gentrification research. Dating back to Zukin (1987), there has been an “empirical stalemate” within sociology, as gentrification scholars fail to agree on the specifics of gentrification and how to best study it. As urban life becomes increasingly complex, so does the study of gentrification, especially along qualitative and quantitative lines.

According to Brown-Saracino (2017), this methodological divide within gentrification is vast, with some viewing it as less dire and less common (Freeman 2006; Vigdor et al. 2002), while others believe it is widespread and fundamentally changing urban life (Newman and Wyly 2003, 2006; Zukin 2016). Because scholars ask different questions and use different methods, they produce different answers. Brown-Saracino suggests that quantitative scholars most often believe that gentrification is less dire, citing their metrics that suggest the small frequency of occurrence. On the other hand, qualitative scholars, who are more likely to be within communities and privilege lived experience, have found that the effects of gentrification are widespread and continue to be relevant (Greenberg 2008; Shaw and Hagemans 2015).

Frequently, quantitative scholars criticize qualitative scholars, suggesting that they are privileged and add little in terms of theory and methodology to the work (Reades

et al. 2019). These scholars claim that qualitative work needs to predict gentrification, displacement, and needs analytical rigor, which is lacking in qualitative research. Other quantitative scholars, like Hwang (2016), argue that 1) scholars should study neighborhood processes more broadly, 2) the role of race and displacement in gentrification requires further study, and 3) gentrification needs better measures. However, these quantitative measures of gentrification often downplay the scale of gentrification and displacement (Hepburn et al. 2024), failing to account for displaced people that do not show up in secondary data analysis or slip into homelessness (Atkinson 2000a; Wyly et al. 2010).

While there have been pushes to come to a consensus, others disagree and propose defining gentrification as a moving target, citing the ever-changing economic and social landscape of cities (Knieriem 2023). In the spirit of critical theory and critical urban theory (Harvey 2009; Levy, Comey, and Padilla 2006; Marcuse 2009), I stand with this approach, and I use a mixed methods to reconcile this methodological divide via a case study of gentrification (Brown-Saracino 2017; Slater 2006, 2009).

Case Studies of Gentrification

Sociological research often occurs at the national level, yet the quantitative case study is a particularly useful method for understanding our cities and neighborhoods. The earliest American sociologists utilized this method, creating tables, graphs, and maps, to demonstrate the state of neighborhoods and cities (DuBois 1899). Like natural sciences and animal ecology, many sociologists believe we can study cities using similar methods (Frazier 1937; McKenzie 1924; Park and Burgess 1925). Using this mindset, McKenzie studied Columbus, Ohio and the Franklinton neighborhood, also known as “the Bottoms”

(McKenzie 1921a, 1921b, 1922). In doing so, he created maps and tables to describe the race, poverty, and crime prevalence that existed in different neighborhoods in addition to studying their histories and social organization. While these findings might not necessarily have been generalizable to cities nationwide, they matter for the people living in these cities and neighborhoods, as the findings can be used to make sense of their neighborhood's changes.

Building on the case study, gentrification scholars have employed case studies to assess mitigating the displacement of long-term residents (Levy, Comey, and Padilla 2006; Levy et al. 2007). Other scholars have also conducted mixed methods case studies of gentrification for specific neighborhood contexts, like immigrant enclaves (Murdie and Teixeira 2011). On the other hand, scholars have also used case studies to challenges using a central definition of gentrification, finding that using different gentrification metrics in Boston yielded dramatic differences (Preis et al. 2021). For this study of Boston, depending on the method, between 25 and 119 tracts across the Boston census tracts were identified as gentrifying, with only seven tracts that all four models considered gentrifying. With such contrasting results, the utility of a singular method of gentrification must be called into question, as using these definitions nationwide could lead to dramatically different results, which is why various metrics should be used.

These case studies can be extended to Columbus and Franklinton, too. Previous gentrification research within Columbus and Franklinton has primarily been studied through qualitative methods (Carlsten 2019; Cox 2020; Fusch 1980; Hassen 2005; Scully 2019; Sweeney 2014; Webb 2013; Workman 2011). Some quantitative research has been conducted, but this has does not include Franklinton, and the timeframe is limited to the

1960s thru 1980s. For instance, Mergler (1984) conducted a case study of gentrification, finding that Victorian Village and German Village experienced gentrification and rehabilitation. Since little contemporary quantitative gentrification scholarship exists on Columbus, it is important to explore this, especially in a neighborhood like Franklinton.

Current Study

Quantitative gentrification research is incredibly complex, using different datasets, variables, indices, years, and geographic areas. The current study builds off previous work on gentrification to provide a locally situated research study to understand how one neighborhood has changed over time. Since gentrification is a neighborhood-level process, it is useful to focus on Franklinton quantitatively. To accomplish this, this study quantitatively examines gentrification in Franklinton using various measures, including descriptive statistics, gentrification indices, migration patterns, maps, and other data visualizations. To guide this work, the current study asks: 1) How has Franklinton changed over time? 2) Do gentrification indices indicate gentrification within Franklinton? 3) Where do former residents of Franklinton move to? And 4) Where did new residents of Franklinton originate from?

Based on interviews, ethnography, and previous literature on gentrification, I expect that descriptive statistics will provide some evidence for gentrification, including increases in education and household income, while some variables will suggest the neighborhood is still in decline, especially across space. Regarding gentrification indices, I expect that some indices will suggest gentrification is occurring while others will suggest that it is not, and this will vary by census tract. For migration patterns, I expect that former residents of Franklinton are likely to move to Hilltop, Grove City, and exurbs outside the city, like Circleville or Galloway. Inside the city, there are fewer and fewer

areas that are affordable to people of lower socioeconomic status, and given that the population of Franklinton is largely white, I expect them to move to other predominately white neighborhoods in the city (or outside) rather than lower income areas with more black residents like Linden, Mt. Vernon, etc. Likewise, given what previous research says about gentrification, I expect that new residents of Franklinton are more likely to come from more affluent areas of Columbus, like Grandview, the University District, Clintonville, Dublin, etc. These areas have younger, educated, and upwardly mobile people that might be interested in living a more urban lifestyle that they can afford in an “up-and-coming” neighborhood like Franklinton.

Methods

Descriptive Statistics

Franklinton, at least as of 2010, consists of three census tracts. As of 2020, there are five census tracts that make up Franklinton. However, in order to conduct temporal analyses, I use data that has been normalized to 2010 boundaries. As such, I create tables to explore demographic changes over time in Franklinton across its three tracts. I name these tracts East Franklinton, West Franklinton, and North of Broad. A map of these has been created in Figure 1. While residents of Franklinton refer to East and West Franklinton colloquially, North of Broad itself is not used in their vernacular and is typically lumped in with West Franklinton. Nevertheless, I use this census tract because it is the format that the data were provided in (Sperling 2012). For these descriptives, I explore includes population, race, age, housing, income, poverty, education, and crime data and what they mean in the context of gentrification. These data, with the exception of crime come from the US Census Bureau Decennial Census, the American Community

Survey 5-Year Estimates, and Social Explorer Data Census Data on 2010 Geographies (Explorer n.d.).

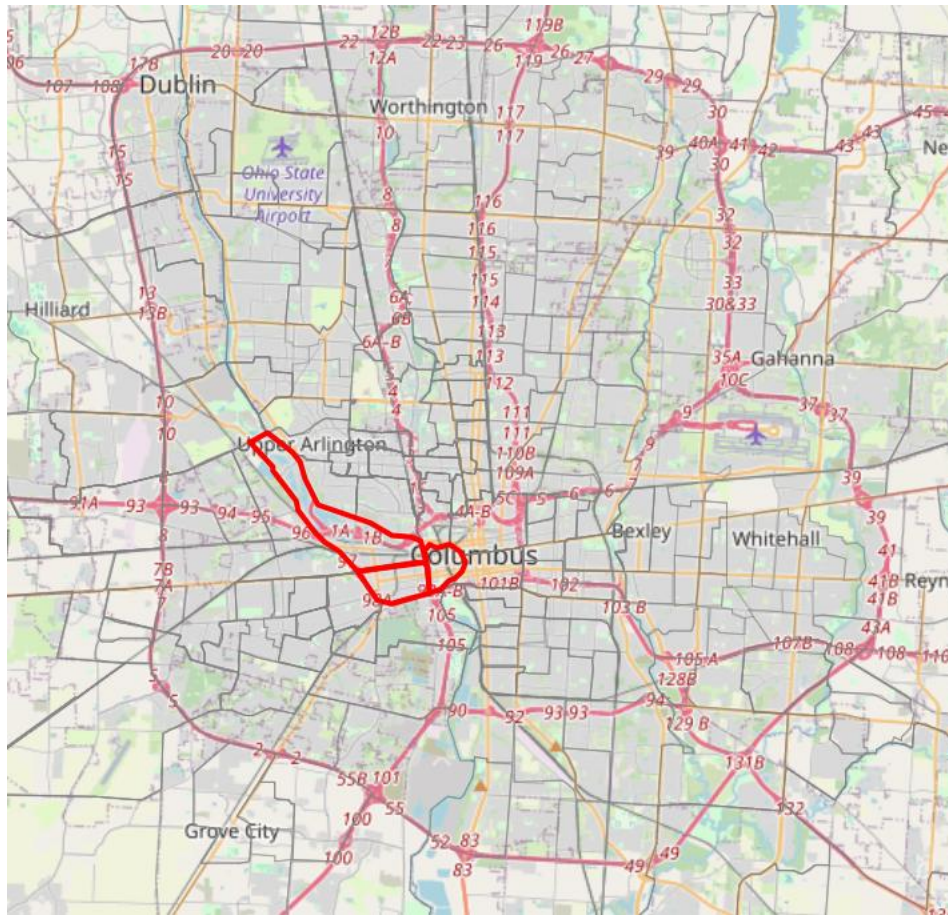


Figure 1. Map of Franklin County Census Tracts

For crime, The Columbus Division of Police provided crime and victimization data from 2010 through 2019. These data were provided by instance and included crime type, crime class, and year. Each instance was then geocoded using latitude and longitude, placed within each census tract, and counted per year. These data were then classified as property crime or violent crime (or n/a), which are defined by the Federal Bureau of Investigation's Uniform Crime Report. Violent crime is classified as murder and manslaughter, rape, robbery, and aggravated assault (Federal Bureau of Investigation

2019b). Property crime is classified as burglary, larceny-theft, motor vehicle theft, and arson (Federal Bureau of Investigation 2019a). Violent crime and property data were then normalized per 100,000 people.

Gentrification Indices

There are various methods and ways of identifying and measuring gentrification, almost too many to count (Finio 2022). Despite this, scholars continue to try and measure gentrification, with new methods nearly every year (Bunten et al. 2023; Easton et al. 2020; Hawkins et al. 2022). Instead of creating my own measure of gentrification, which I do not believe would be useful given the plethora of measures that already exist, I test several measures already developed by gentrification scholars. In order to identify whether gentrification has occurred in Franklinton, I use American Community Survey Data from 1990-2019 to calculate whether gentrification has occurred using three different indices over several timeframes across the three census tracts.

Each measure identifies gentrification across the three census tracts in Franklinton and across two timeframes. The first gentrification measure I calculate is the Vigdor, Massey, and Rivlin (2002) method, who developed one of the earliest methods for identifying gentrification. Their model, based on data from Boston, primarily focused on the growth of the educated population. According to their criteria, a census tract would be labeled as gentrifying if the population aged 25 and over with bachelor's degrees increased by at least 50% more than the citywide average growth of this demographic between two timeframes, 2000 to 2010 and 2010 to 2019. To measure these changes, I used 2000 Census data applied to 2010 boundaries. While this definition of gentrification is simplistic and likely conservative, it avoids unnecessary complexity.

The second gentrification measures I calculated was the Freeman (2005) method. Following Freeman's method (2005), a potentially gentrifiable census tract is defined as one within the central city that has a lower median household income than the rest of the metro area. Additionally, Freeman argued that such a neighborhood would have a proportion of housing built in the last 20 years that falls below the median proportion for the metropolitan statistical area (MSA). To measure the age of structures, I used data from the "Year Structure Built" variable of the American Community Survey (ACS) 5-Year Estimates from 2019. This dataset provides the number of structures built each decade or since 2014 and excludes non-residential buildings. I calculated the proportion of housing units built within a 20-year span by adding the number of structures built from 1980 to 1989 to those built from 1990 to 1999, then dividing this sum by the total number of housing units in 2000. This method may undercount demolished structures, but it is the most reliable data available from the Census.

A tract deemed potentially gentrifiable would be considered gentrifying 10 years after the initial year. According to Freeman's (2005) methodology, a neighborhood would be classified as gentrifying as of 2010 if it exhibited: 1) a greater increase in educational attainment (specifically, the proportion of residents with a 4-year degree or more) than the metropolitan area and 2) an increase in real housing prices. After identifying whether gentrification occurred from 2000 to 2010, I followed the same methods for 2010-2019.

The third measure of gentrification used comes from Landis (2016). Unlike the other two definitions of gentrification that use 10-year timeframes, the Landis (2016) definition uses a 20-year timeframe. Just as spatial considerations are crucial in

understanding gentrification, so is the temporal dimension, as it captures different social phenomena and migration trends in neighborhoods. This is a benefit of using the Landis definition, also known as the 3-D method (Lucy and Phillips 2006).

Following the Landis (2016) definition of gentrification, the first analysis utilized data from 1990 and 2010 to assess substantial neighborhood socioeconomic change (SNSEC) using income deciles by census tract. Landis categorized substantial neighborhood decline and upgrading, where a decrease of two or more deciles in median household income between 1990 and 2010 constitutes neighborhood decline, while an increase of two or more deciles constitutes neighborhood upgrading. Potentially gentrifiable census tracts were identified as those within the first four income deciles for the metropolitan statistical area in 1990. Although neighborhood upgrading could occur without gentrification, potentially gentrifiable census tracts were considered gentrifying if they experienced substantial neighborhood upgrading by 2010. Additionally, to qualify as gentrifying, neighborhoods must be within 10 kilometers of the Central Business District.

Data Limitations

There are several reasons that I did not use some of the 2020-2021 data. Although data from 2020 and onwards would be more useful to tell a complete story of gentrification and neighborhood change in Franklinton, there were significant data limitations in using post-2019 data. For one, the Census implemented new confidentiality protections, also known as disclosure avoidance and differential privacy (Bureau 2021). This new policy works by adding artificial noise to data in small geographies, like block groups and census tracts. While the Census has a strong interest in maintaining privacy of citizens, this also meant that a significant portion of post-2019 data was completely

unavailable in a small area like East Franklinton. Furthermore, researchers have found that this new policy makes data incomparable and inaccurate by undercounting populations in mixed-race and mixed-partisan precincts, calling on the need to balance accuracy with privacy (Kenny et al. 2021; Scariano and Youngs 2022). Variables in Franklinton like Median Household Income by Race, Median Home Value, and Poverty by Race were made unavailable by this policy post-2019, making the comparison of data impossible over time.

Additionally, the Census instituted new census tract boundaries in 2020 in Franklinton. The West Franklinton Census Tract (50) was split into 50.01 and 50.02 while the North of Broad Census Tract (42) was split into 42.01 and 42.02. These new census tracts fit perfectly into the old 2010 census tracts. To get around some of the changes in census tracts, I utilized target-density weighting provided by the Longitudinal Tract Data Base (LTDB) (Logan, Xu, and Stults 2014; Schroeder 2007) to recreate 2021 data in 2010 boundaries. However, I was limited in this endeavor by the variables that were based on medians and the new differential privacy policy. For historical data, I utilized Social Explorer's Census on 2000 on 2010 geographies, which used areal and population interpolation-weights (Explorer n.d.) For 1970, 1980, and 1990 data on 2010 boundaries, Social Explorer utilized areal-weighted interpolation. This, too, was based on Logan et al.'s (2014) methodology. These helped me get around tract changes, but 2021 and 2022 data were not available in 2010 boundaries at the time of this study. These new tract boundaries fit more with the way citizens of Franklinton view neighborhood boundaries, but all of the historical census data was not available in 2020 census tract boundaries, showing the ongoing arbitrariness of census geography choices (Sperling

2012). Finally, the COVID-19 pandemic greatly affected the Census' ability to accurately collect data, thus using 2020 and 2021 data might obscure some of the changes and trends already occurring in the neighborhood. In 2020, the Census suspended in-person interviews, which negatively affected response rates and delayed the availability of 2020 census data. 2021 data was not affected to the same extent, but the differential privacy agreements were already in place (Bureau 2023; Rogers and Hartley 2022). As a result of these data complications, I focus the majority of my analyses on data from 2000 to 2019, beginning with the total population of the neighborhood tracts.

Migration Patterns

Data Axle, formerly known as Infogroup and ReferenceUSA, has a consumer database that contains data on approximately 315 million consumers and gathers data from real estate and taxes assessments, voter registrations, utilities, and various other sources (Data Axle n.d.). This consumer database comes from non-representative data (Acolin, Decter-Frain, and Hall 2022), yet Data Axle claims to have data on nearly every household in the United States (Infogroup 2019), but some academics urge caution in using this consumer data (Pasek et al. 2014). Based on the University of Nebraska-Omaha's audit, this data is considered very reliable (Infogroup 2018). Over time, this dataset has become more accurate and closer to American Community Survey 5-year estimates, but there tend to be undercounts and overcounts based on variables like age, income, etc. (Acolin et al. 2022). Despite its potential flaws, this proprietary dataset has a wide range of utility, and has been increasingly used by academics, including for understanding gentrification (Chapple and Song 2024; Song and Chapple 2024).

Taking Data Axle Consumer Residential Database data, I collected all Ohio data from 2007-2022. After loading in each Ohio dataset and combining them, I selected the counties within the Metropolitan Statistical Area of Columbus, Ohio. This includes the following counties: Delaware, Fairfield, Franklin, Hocking, Licking, Madison, Morrow, Perry, Pickaway, and Union. This data included interesting variables on census tract, owner/renter status, and household income. To track households, I used the Family Identification Number, provided by Data Axle. Across the 16-year timespan, this made for approximately 3,491,338 unique households to potentially analyze. To find households that lived within Franklinton at some point, I took the approximately 3.5 million unique households and only selected those that lived in a Franklinton Census Tract at some point, which was approximately 41,361 households. Of these households, 12,089 moved within the time frame. The majority of these households only moved once within the time frame, as shown in Figure 2. This is shown annually by type of move in Figure 3.

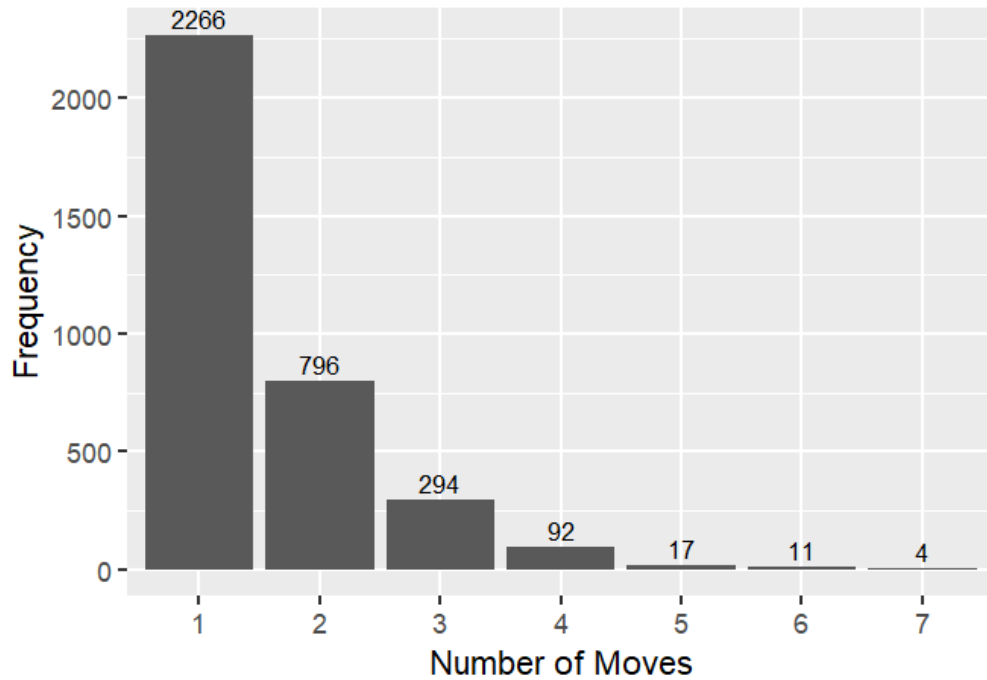


Figure 2. Number of Moves per Household

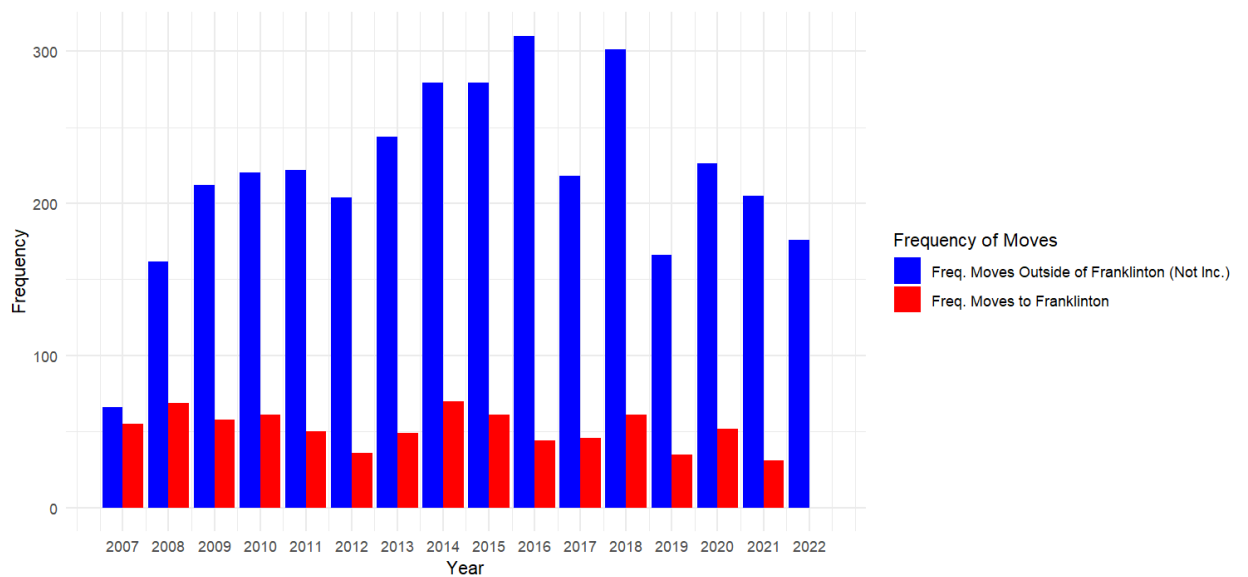


Figure 3. Frequency of Moves into and Out of Franklinton (2007-2022)

Results

Descriptive Statistics of Gentrification

Gentrification's lack of central definition presents a problem for urban scholars, especially when using quantitative measures (Brown-Saracino 2017). Whether a neighborhood is considered gentrifying has important implications for other neighborhoods outcomes (Barton 2016a). As scholars, analytical decisions matter and can dramatically alter results. Without a central, agreed upon definition, it remains key study how a host of variables have changed over time. To address this problem, scholars have suggested several approaches, including using mixed methods and analyzing multiple variables (Brown-Saracino 2017; Finio 2022). The utility of many neighborhood change variables lies the ability to tell an in-depth story of neighborhood change, including variables traditionally associated with gentrification and those without (Finio 2022). These various figures add nuance to our idea neighborhood change and whether gentrification has or is occurring. Variables used to study gentrification vary widely: race, age of residents, share of artists, number of coffee shops, housing tenure, crime, and poverty just to name several (Finio 2022). In keeping with the analytical tradition of gentrification scholars, I created various descriptive statistics tables on population, race, age, housing, socioeconomic status, education, and crime. I then discuss and explore these changes and what they mean within the context of gentrification, with some providing evidence of gentrification while others do not.

Following the exploration of descriptive statistics, I explored three indices of gentrification using Census and American Community Survey data, including the Vigdor method (2002), the Freeman (2005) method, and the Landis (2016) method. These data rely heavily on household income measures, and because of inflation, I normalized these

to 2022 inflation-adjusted dollars using the Consumer Price Index (CPI) Inflation Calculator (Bureau of Labor Statistics 2023; Johnson et al. 2022). Like the descriptive statistics, some indices of gentrification provide evidence of gentrification while others do not.

Following the discussion of these indicators, I analyze migration patterns in and out of Franklinton using Data Axle Historical Consumer Data (2007-2022), demonstrating that there are unique migration patterns within the Columbus Metropolitan Statistical Area and within Franklinton. There appear to be migration flows into and out of Franklinton that provide evidence of gentrification. Altogether, this study's various data sources and exploration provides evidence for both historical neighborhoods decline within Franklinton followed by gentrification, particularly within East Franklinton.

Total Population

Along spatially harmonized census tracts, Table 1 shows the population changes from 1970, 1980, 1990, 2000, 2010, 2019, and 2021 in the three census tracts, including total population. When combining this data with Table 1, the trend is clear: all Franklinton census tracts experienced large population decline (15,304 in 1970 to 10,666 in 2021, a 30.31% decline over all three tracts). This is most salient in East Franklinton, which has experienced the greatest decline (3284 in 1970 to 490 in 2021, an 85.08% decrease in population in 51 years). In West Franklinton, the population has decreased from 6570.76 in 1970 to 5320 in 2021, a 19.04% decrease. North of Broad has experienced the least dramatic population decline in Franklinton. In 1970, North of Broad's population decreased from 5449.21 people to 4856 in 2021, a 10.89% decrease over 51 years. Altogether, the population has decreased dramatically over time, partially

due to the flooding, flood plain designation, and poverty. Previous research suggests that gentrification and upzoning, depending on the time frame studied, can result in population loss, particularly for people of color (Davis 2021; Richardson et al. 2019).

Area of Franklinton	Total Population						
	1970	1980	1990	2000	2010	2019	2021
East Franklinton	3284.54	2861.28	2606.61	1432	859	428	490
North of Broad	5449.21	3815.13	4458.29	4229	6018	5429	4856
West Franklinton	6570.76	5755.63	4805.30	6628	5884	5022	5320
Total Franklinton	15,304.51	12,432.04	11,870.20	12,289	12,761	10,879	10,666

Table 1. Population of Franklinton (1970-2021)

Race

Within the gentrification literature, race is often a pertinent factor and is associated with white gentrifiers moving into historically Black neighborhoods (Fallon 2021; Freeman 2005; Jackson 2015; Richardson et al. 2019; Schaffer and Smith 1986). However, Franklinton is a historically white neighborhood, thus racial demographics may be less pertinent or place a different role in the story of gentrification in the neighborhood. Nevertheless, it remains important to discuss racial changes in the neighborhood as shown in Table 2.

East Franklinton, the closest census tract to downtown, has become more racially diverse over time. In East Franklinton, White Population Density has decreased from 1970 onwards, going from 85.07% of the population in 1970 to 55.10% in 2021.

Similarly, Black Population Density has increased in East Franklinton, increasing from 11.12% in 1970 to 32.45% in 2021. However, this statistic is somewhat misleading, as the actual Black population has decreased from 724 in 2000 to 159 in 2021. Lastly, Latino Population Density has increased from 1.61% in 2000 to 5.51% in 2021. Altogether, the gentrification of East Franklinton has increased racial diversity, but its decline in population complicates this finding.

West Franklinton has followed similar trends in becoming more racially diverse over time. In 1970, West Franklinton's White Population Density was a staggering 89.06% of the population, but this decreased to 65.51% in 2021. Meanwhile, the Black Population Density of the neighborhood increased from 8.05% in 1970 to 18.53% in 2021. Unlike East Franklinton, the Black Population of West Franklinton increased from 617 in 2000 to 986 in 2021. Lastly, the Latino Population Density increased from 1.25% in 2000 to 5.81% in 2021, and its Latino Population grew from 83 in 2000 to 309 in 2021. Like East Franklinton, West Franklinton's racial diversity has increased over time, yet it is without the complication of large population decrease.

North of Broad's racial changes can be characterized differently. Over time, Black population density in the tract has decreased from 13.09% in 1970 to 7.83% in 2021. However, the Latino Population Density has increased from 2.15% in 2000 to 15.47% in 2021. North of Broad's racial diversity, has thus remained the most stable, moving from 83.55% in 1970 to 72.49% in 2021, which makes it the least racially diverse out of all of the Franklinton census tracts but having the highest Latino Population Density.

These results are at odds with other gentrification literature and further demonstrate the importance of Franklinton as a case study and the need to analyze racial descriptive statistics in gentrifying neighborhoods (Fallon 2021). Over time, the census tracts in Franklinton have become more racially diverse, yet North of Broad's racial diversity has occurred while experiencing decreasing Black Population Density. However, these findings are complicated because of population decrease, especially for Black residents. This is in-line with recent research on explaining how white spaces continue to remain primarily white even though it may appear as though they are becoming more diverse (Kye and Halpern-Manners 2023).

Area of Franklinton	White Population Density							Black Population Density							Latino Population Density			
	1970	1980	1990	2000	2010	2019	2021	1970	1980	1990	2000	2010	2019	2021	2000	2010	2019	2021
East Franklinton	85.07	86.76	75.52	42.46	36.44	51.64	55.10	11.12	12.62	20.59	50.56	57.16	46.26	32.45	1.61	0.00	2.10	5.51
North of Broad	83.55	87.61	85.76	81.96	83.02	84.14	72.49	13.09	11.78	9.27	9.41	9.42	7.33	7.83	2.15	4.99	4.49	15.47
West Franklinton	89.06	91.31	86.85	86.57	82.58	67.28	65.51	8.05	8.15	10.79	9.31	16.59	22.02	18.53	1.25	2.41	3.78	5.81
Total Franklinton	86.24	89.13	83.95	79.84	79.68	75.08	68.21	10.50	10.29	12.37	14.15	15.94	15.64	14.30	1.60	3.46	4.07	10.19

Table 2. Racial Makeup of Franklinton (2000-2019)

Area of Franklinton	Age 25 to 34				Percent 25 to 34				Median Age			
	2000	2010	2019	2021	2000	2010	2019	2021	2000	2010	2019	2021
East Franklinton	198	147	21	95	13.83	17.11	4.91	19.39	31	32.4	41.9	36.3
North of Broad	1148	1738	1805	1164	27.15	28.88	33.25	23.97	31	27.1	30.4	
West Franklinton	1038	1089	865	628	15.66	18.51	17.22	11.80	29	31.5	31.5	
Total Franklinton	2384	2974	2691	1887	19.40	23.31	24.74	17.69				

Table 3. Franklinton Population by Age (2000-2021)

Age

Gentrifiers are often thought of as young, white, and upwardly mobile people, often members of the creative class (Florida 2003; Moos 2016). With a new “adult playground” in East Franklinton, gentrification can be seen as “youthification”, or the increase of young people in an area (Moos 2016; Weiker 2023d). This young group is often made up of artists and other “supercreative” groups that are seeking out cheaper rents in “hip” neighborhoods (Goldberg-Miller and Heimlich 2017; Goldberg-Miller, Heimlich, and Kemper 2020; Sweeney 2014). To identify trends in age, I analyze Percent Aged 25-34 and Median Age from 2000 to 2021 (Table 3).

In East Franklinton, Percent Aged 25-34 has increased from 13.83% in 2000 to 19.39% in 2021. Meanwhile, the Median Age has increased from 31 in 2000 to 36.3 in 2021. This partially has to do with the lack of family housing, like duplexes and apartment buildings, and the amount of single people moving into East Franklinton. West Franklinton has experienced a decline in its younger population aged 25 to 34, which went from 15.66% in 2000 to 11.80% in 2021. However, its median age went from 29 in 2000 to 31.5 in 2021. This likely has to do with the number of children and elderly living in West Franklinton. North of Broad, compared to the other neighborhoods, has the highest percentage of people Aged 25-34, though this has decreased from 27.15% in 2000 to 23.97% in 2021. However, the Median Age in 2019 was 30.4 years.

The descriptive statistics on age suggest that East Franklinton has had an increase in a younger population, which is in line with previous gentrification literature (Moos 2016). However, West Franklinton’s population has actually gotten somewhat older. North of Broad, on the other hand, has had a relatively stable young population. These

results show the complexity and diversity of changes in age across the census tracts while also pointing towards gentrification.

Housing

Finio (2022) identified various housing-related variables that have been used in previous gentrification research, including household size, rent price, home value, and vacancy rate. Gentrification of these housing variables vary in directionality. For instance, the presence of gentrification is typically associated with decreased vacancy rates, increased property values, increased rents, and a decrease in household size (Atkinson 2004). In Franklinton census tracts, these variables contrast over time and space, which are shown in Table 4.

In East Franklinton, the Median Gross Rent has increased significantly over time despite inflation, increasing from \$266.50 in 2000 to \$828 in 2021. Similarly, the Median Home Value increased from \$43,585.47 in 2000 to \$83,482 in 2018. 2019 and 2021 data on Median Home Value was not available in East Franklinton due to Census differential privacy restrictions (Kenny et al. 2021; Scariano and Youngs 2022). Meanwhile, the vacancy rate has increased from 24.39% in 2000 to 38.15% in 2021. The Percentage of Renters in has also increased from 91.27% in 2000 to 93.11% in 2021. Altogether, housing values increased in East Franklinton even as vacancy rates increased.

West Franklinton saw rents grow despite increased vacancy, though not as dramatically as East Franklinton. In 2000, the Median Rent was \$749.52 and grew to \$882.55 in 2019. Meanwhile, the Median Home Value between 2000 and 2019 actually decreased from \$79,862.90 to \$69,626. However, in 2020 the US Census Bureau split West Franklinton into two census tracts. Between 2019 and 2021, these two census tracts

experienced dramatic growth in Median Home Value. In 2021, the Median Home Value in the 50.01 Census Tract rose to \$127,400.00, and the 50.02 Census Tract surged to \$220,900.00. At the same time, the vacancy rate of West Franklinton has steadily increased from 15.28% in 2000 to 21.16% in 2021. The Percentage of Renters has remained relatively stable as well, going from 68.29% in 2000 to 66.25% in 2021.

North of Broad experienced a different trend, which has been shown by other variables. Rents in North of Broad have been significantly higher than East Franklinton or West Franklinton since 1970. In 2000, the Median Rent was \$1190.90, and it slightly rose to \$1340.49 in 2019. Like West Franklinton, North of Broad's census tract was bisected and divided into two census tracts in 2020, thus there is no available Median Rent or Median Home Value data in 2021 for the original census tract. However, the Median Home Value increased from \$97,148.08 in 2000 to \$222,656.00 in 2019. In 2021, North of Broad's bisected census tract data tells two stories. While the 43.01 census tract's Median Home Value was \$344,100.00, the 43.02 census tract was substantially lower at \$93,300. The 43.02 census tract is more in-line with the actual neighborhood boundaries, suggesting that the 43.02 tract has not experienced the same level of economic growth and investment as the 43.01 tract in recent years. Aside from housing values, North of Broad's Vacancy Rate has decreased from 19.13% in 2000 to 18.21% in 2021, and the Percentage of Renters has grown from 72.43% in 2000 to 83.65% in 2021.

Finding a singular, linear quantitative story within Franklinton's housing variables remains difficult as some of the variables do not move in the expected direction resulting from gentrification. Franklinton is experiencing dramatic increases in home values

despite population decline and increased vacancy. As shown, rent has slightly increased in West Franklinton while Median Home Values have risen dramatically all over the neighborhood. Residents have taken notice of this, as property values have increased over 200% in many parts of the neighborhood (Meibers 2023; Weiker 2023c). According to the county auditor, “the percentage increase may not tell the whole story for a neighborhood, but typically a larger increase suggests more investment and growth in an area” (Meibers 2023). Judging by these variables, the neighborhood is certainly in flux, and its fate remains to be seen. While housing values have certainly increased, income has not entirely grown with it.

Economic Characteristics

It is important to study both class-based and race-based change when analyzing gentrification (Fallon 2021). Thus, I include Median Household Income by Race in Table 5 and Poverty Data by Race in Table 6. These data show that Franklinton’s household income has risen over time, but this varies by race. Similarly, the poverty rate has also decreased over time, but the story is complicated by race and space. Again, the data limitations brought on by the Census Bureau’s changing tract boundaries and differential privacy policy made comparing the 2021 data impossible. Nevertheless, the available data tell an interesting story about poverty and income.

Median Household Income has risen all across Franklinton, but this has varied dramatically by tract. In 2000, the Median Household Income in East Franklinton was \$13,750.77 and rose minimally to \$15,091.55 in 2019. However, in 2021, the Median Household Income jumped to \$39,219.00, doubling over the course of two years. Meanwhile, West Franklinton’s Median Household Income has increased from

\$26,097.53 in 2000 to \$30,301 in 2019. Like with other variables, North of Broad experienced the greatest increases. North of Broad's Median Household Income grew from \$41,622.57 in 2000 to \$75,829.69 in 2019.

Broken down by race, it is obvious that there are vast disparities in household income. In East Franklinton, White Median Household Income increased from \$20,773.57 in 2000 to \$28,620.56 in 2019. West Franklinton's White Median Household Income has actually decreased from \$38,048.56 in 2000 to \$31,933.29 in 2019. Finally, North of Broad's White Median Household Income increased from \$64,570.20 in 2000 to \$75,801.77 in 2019.

As for Black Median Household Income, only North of Broad experienced an increase in Median Household Income. East Franklinton's Black Median Household Income declined from \$14,489.41 in 2000 to \$11,836.91 in 2019. Similarly, West Franklinton's Black Median Household Income decreased from \$23,394.64 to \$19,575.91 in 2019. North of Broad, on the other hand, experienced an increase from \$19,004.50 in 2000 to \$36,743.78 in 2019.

In conclusion, data on Median Household Income has shown that East Franklinton and West Franklinton have remained relatively low, sometimes decreasing. Black Median Household Income has decreased across Franklinton, with the exception of North of Broad. North of Broad, across each variable, has experienced increases of Median Household Income. Without more recent data, it is difficult to identify trends, but 2021 Median Household Income data from East Franklinton points towards a rapid increase.

In order to fully understand the economic changes ongoing in Franklinton, it is also important to analyze the changes in poverty over time. The East Franklinton poverty rate has fluctuated over time but has overall decreased, decreasing from 51.78% in 1970 to 46.46% in 2019. It reached a high of 74.51% in 2010, perhaps due to the housing market crash. Its White Poverty rate almost halved from 55.56% in 2000 to 28.05% in 2019, yet the Black Poverty Rate increased from 61.29% in 2000 to 64.14% in 2019. West Franklinton followed similar trends. In 1970, the poverty rate was 49.16% but has since decreased to a low of 31.2% in 2000, a high of 53.18% in 2010, and most recently 40.92% in 2019. The White Poverty Rate increased from 31.90% in 2000 to 33.56% in 2019. On the other hand, the Black Poverty Rate increased much more, moving from 52.75% in 2000 to 68.44% in 2019. North of Broad, on the other hand, had a poverty rate of 41.22% in 1970 and has steadily decreased to 21.79% in 2019. North of Broad's White Poverty Rate has remained relatively steady, going from 20.73% in 2000 to 19.68% in 2019. Its Black Poverty Rate declined from 46.84% in 2000 to 24.87% in 2019, highlighting a far greater decline in black poverty compared to the other Franklinton tracts.

Altogether, poverty has decreased across Franklinton since the 1970s, but this varies dramatically by space and race. While White Poverty has decreased in North of Broad and East Franklinton, it has grown in West Franklinton. Meanwhile, Black Poverty has grown in East and West Franklinton, and only decreased in North of Broad. Previous research suggests that gentrification is associated with the suburbanization of poverty and the movement of low-income households further out to the urban periphery via the displacement of low-income residents (Hochstenbach and Musterd 2018). Additionally,

previous research suggests that gentrification furthers racial stratification (Hwang and Ding 2020). Thus, the changes in poverty from Franklinton fit within previous gentrification research. Another key aspect to consider in the context of gentrification is education.

Education

Within gentrification research, education plays a prominent role in identifying changes in the class makeup of a neighborhood and is among one of the most commonly utilized variables in studying gentrification (Finio 2022). In Glass' original work in London, education and occupation were part of her conceptualization of class (Glass 1964). When a neighborhood experiences an increase in education attainment, this indicates that a neighborhood is experiencing an influx of educated individuals, typically of a higher socioeconomic class. In previous work, various methods of identifying education's role in gentrification have been studied. According to some, an increase in educational attainment of a neighborhood greater than the increase in the median of the metropolitan area is one indication that gentrification occurred (Ding, Hwang, and Divringi 2016; Freeman 2005). Others (Hwang and Lin 2016) have used education as part of an index of socioeconomic status or in a model as an interaction variable (McKinnish, Walsh, and Kirk White 2010).

Across all of Franklinton, rates of educational attainment rose between 2000 and 2019. In 2000, the percent of the population with less than a high school degree was 44.99% and decreased to 18.98% in 2019, and this trend occurred in all of the census tracts, but occurred most dramatically in East Franklinton, which decreased from 48.85% in 2000 to 24.10% in 2019. Similarly, High School Graduation and/or GED attainment,

Four-Year Degree Attainment, and Graduate School or More Attainment all rose in each census tract in Franklinton between 2000 and 2019, providing strong evidence for greater educational attainment in the neighborhood.

Previous gentrification research has suggested that education plays an integral role to the phenomenon, in that gentrification is associated with increased educational attainment, though it is nuanced (Pearman 2019). Other research has found that this increased educational attainment is often not due to an improvement in schools or test scores but due to an influx of educated residents (Keels, Burdick–Will, and Keene 2013). From 2022 to 2023, West High School in Hilltop, the public high school that serves Franklinton, experienced a decrease in enrollment of 113 students, a decrease of 14.4% (All Columbus Data 2023). This, too is in line with previous research that finds gentrification is associated with decreasing enrollment in public schools (Pearman 2020). While the majority of the changes discussed so far in Franklinton appear to be negative for long-term residents, changes in crime may be changing for the better.

Area of Franklinton	Median Gross Rent				Percent Vacancy				Percent Renters				Median Home Value (inflated)		
	2000	2010	2019	2021	2000	2010	2019	2021	2000	2010	2019	2021	2000	2010	2019
East Franklinton	266.50	315.29	352.15	828	24.39	20.78	25.60	38.15	91.27	97.09	85.05	93.11	43,585.47	48,692	83,482 (2018)
North of Broad	1190.90	1200.19	1340.49	NA	19.13	9.26	16.50	18.21	72.43	80.99	79.76	83.65	97,148.08	86,425	222,656
West Franklinton	749.52	790.18	882.55	NA	15.28	26.16	25.96	21.16	68.29	70.75	79.73	66.25	79,862.90	84,806	69,626
Total Franklinton					18.00	17.03	20.95	21.27	59.52	65.88	60.84	75.55			

Table 4. Franklinton Population by Housing Characteristics (2000-2021)

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Area of Franklinton	Median HH Income				White Median HH Income (inflated)				Black Median HH Income (inflated)			
	2000	2010	2019	2021	2000	2010	2019	2021	2000	2010	2019	2021
East Franklinton	13,750.77	9291.40	15,091.55	39,219.00	20,773.57	21,585	28,620.56		14,489.41	8680.275	11,836.91	
North of Broad	41,622.57	42,141.50	75,829.69		64,570.2	51,965	75,801.77		19,004.5	35,918.69	36,743.78	
West Franklinton	26,097.53	25,054.73	30,301.50		38,048.56	25,840	31,933.29		23,394.64	15,023.75	19,575.91	

Table 5. Franklinton Population by Household Income (2000-2021)

Area of Franklinton	Percent Poverty						Percent White Poverty			Percent Black Poverty		
	1970	1980	1990	2000	2010	2019	2000	2010	2019	2000	2010	2019
East Franklinton	51.78	50.03	51.51	56.63	74.51	46.26	55.56	41.21	28.05	61.29	92.87	64.14
North of Broad	41.22	26.23	32.13	23.93	29.93	21.79	20.73	28.34	19.68	46.84	7.94	24.87
West Franklinton	49.16	40.29	39.92	31.20	53.18	40.92	31.90	52.75	33.56	52.75	57.99	68.44
Total Franklinton	48.27	38.76	38.67	31.66	43.65	31.58	29.23	40.40	25.65	55.40	52.46	57.76

Table 6. Franklinton Poverty Data (2000-2019)

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Area of Franklinton	Percent Less than HS			Percent HS or GED			Percent Four-Year Degree			Percent Graduate School or More		
	2000	2010	2019	2000	2010	2019	2000	2010	2019	2000	2010	2019
East Franklinton	48.85	35.01	24.10	27.64	38.78	39.76	4.73	0.00	8.73	0.00	0.00	3.92
North of Broad	27.87	25.34	10.17	16.14	13.59	17.87	21.05	36.00	40.24	17.94	10.43	16.80
West Franklinton	55.62	48.96	30.61	27.25	28.06	34.50	3.57	3.86	8.16	0.65	1.08	2.75
Total Franklinton	44.99	36.88	18.98	23.34	21.97	25.50	9.92	18.74	25.99	6.73	5.41	10.60

Table 7. Franklinton Population by Education (2000-2019)

Crime

Scholars have established the negative between gentrification and reductions in crime, but the reasoning behind these issues remain up for debate (Barton 2016b; MacDonald and Stokes 2020; McDonald 1986; O'Sullivan 2005). One possible explanation is that middle-class and high-income gentrifiers commit less crime than low-income residents. Further, when these low-income residents are displaced, there are fewer of them to commit crime. There are a host of other hypotheses involving collective efficacy, crime type, and coffee shops (Barton 2016b; Papachristos et al. 2011; Steinmetz-Wood et al. 2017). Nevertheless, changes in crime rates remain an important part of understanding gentrification.

The finalized crime data are shown in Table 8 from 2011-2019. Notably, the violent crime rates and property crime rates peaked at 1011.56 violent crimes and 71,676.30 property crimes per 100,000 people in 2014 in East Franklinton. However, these data might be slightly misleading as East Franklinton continued experiencing population decline, and the census tract had a small population of 692 in 2014. At no point from 2011 to 2019 has East Franklinton had a population over 1000 people. Following 2014, the Columbus Division of Police reported no violent crimes in East Franklinton and a dramatic reduction in property crime and the property crime rate. In 2014, the city of Columbus demolished Sunshine Terrace, a public housing complex with approximately 180 units for chronically homeless men, which may be the reason for this trend.

After the demolition of Sunshine Terrace, West Franklinton and North of Broad experienced increases in violent crime and violent crime rates, yet property crime and rates remained relatively stable, which is in line with previous research (Barton 2016b;

McDonald 1986). Violent crime in West Franklinton jumped from 4 violent crimes in 2014 to 18 in 2015 and remained subsequently high thereafter. North of Broad also experienced increased violent crime, but it increased gradually from 1 violent crime in 2015 to 14 in 2018. These crime data are shown in Figures 4, 5, 6, and 7. These findings point to the fact that gentrification and displacement of low-income individuals in East Franklinton pushed violent crime to other parts of the neighborhood.

Year	Violent Crime Rate (per 100K)			Property Crime Rate (per 100K)		
	East Franklinton	West Franklinton	North of Broad	East Franklinton	West Franklinton	North of Broad
2011	110.5	41.36	49.43	14585	10256	6113
2012	0	19.64	16.9	20867	8523	5206
2013	373.13	196.08	0	43407	8322	4674
2014	1011.56	87.55	19.65	71676	7988	5402
2015	169.49	398.41	19.62	13728	8410	4786
2016	0	426.89	55.19	16153	7769	5040
2017	0	524.81	155.7	18099	9947	5936
2018	0	415.97	262.12	17149	7591	4325
2019	0	219.04	92.1	18224	5416	4052

Table 8. Crime Data in Franklinton (2011-2019)

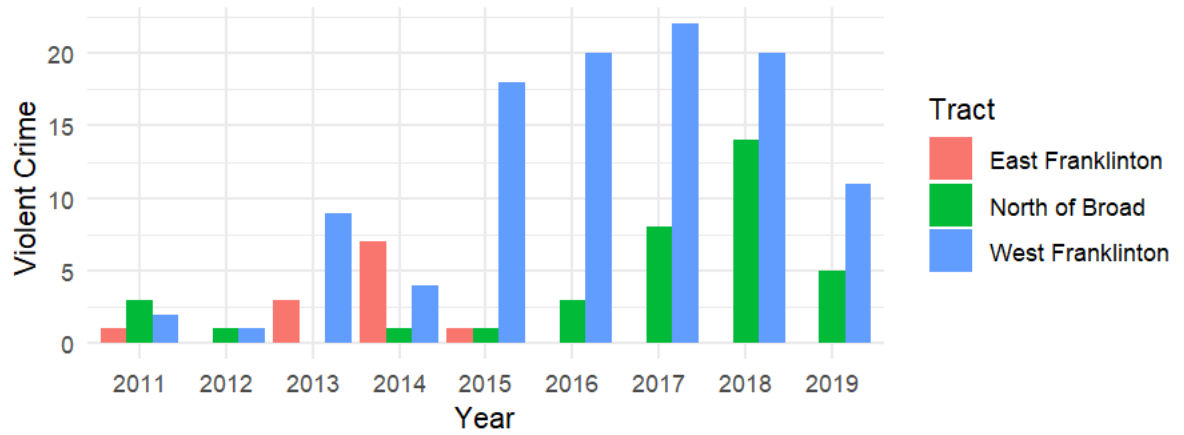


Figure 4. Violent Crime by Year

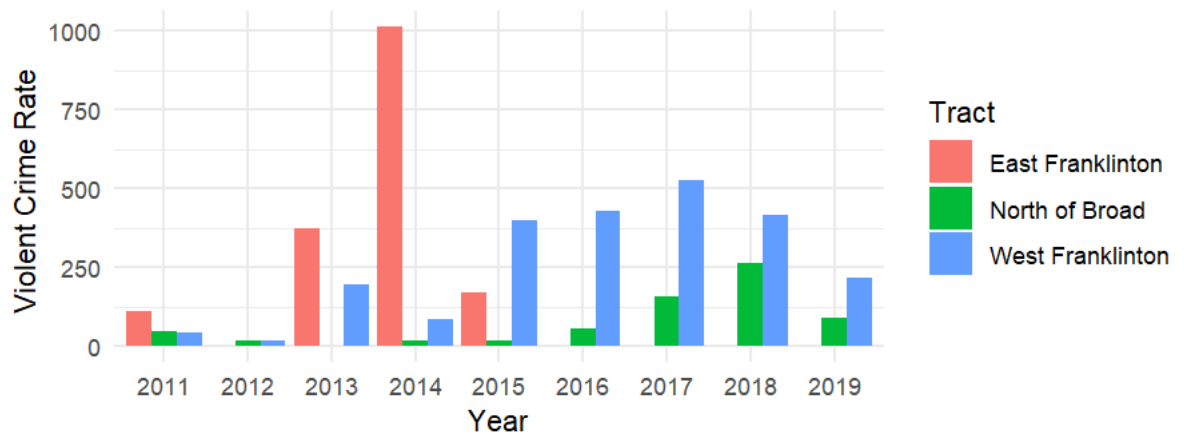


Figure 5. Violent Crime Rate by Year

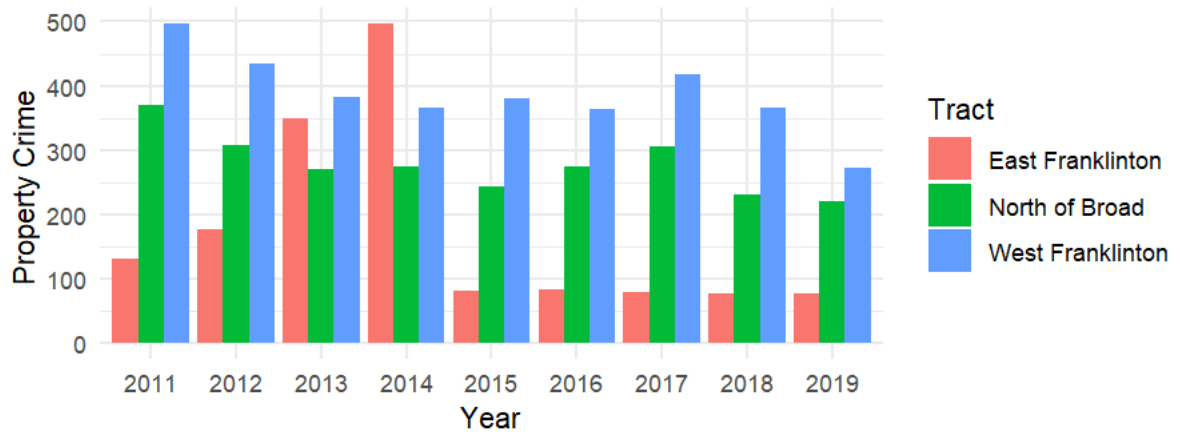


Figure 6. Property Crime by Year

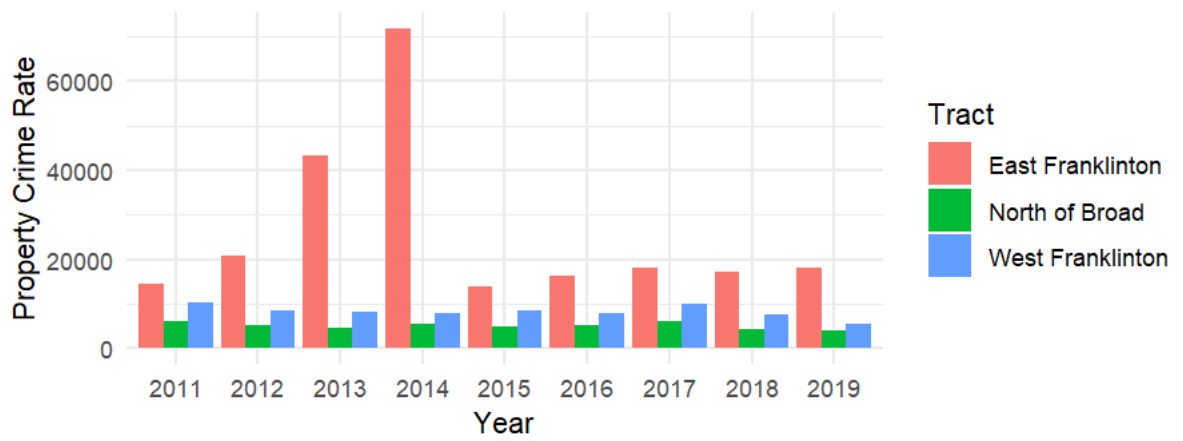


Figure 7. Property Crime Rate by Year

Indices of Gentrification

Vigdor Definition (2000 to 2010)

The descriptive statistics shown above highlight the plethora of changes, both in the past and ongoing in Franklinton. However, they fail to label the changes in Franklinton as “gentrification” or not. Ideally, but probably not practically, scholars have attempted to describe, measure, and study gentrification through various quantitative methods. Using three different methods across different time frames, I analyze whether Franklinton census tracts could be considered gentrifying (Table 9). Vigdor, Massey, and Rivlin (2002) created one first methods of identifying gentrification, a model of gentrification using data in Boston that relied mainly on the growth of educated people. Between the ten-year span, if the 25 and over population with bachelor’s degrees increases at least 50% more than city average growth in 25 and over population with bachelor’s degrees, a tract would be labeled gentrifying. To measure these changes, I used 2000 Census data on 2010 boundaries, which although simplistic and likely conservative, this definition of gentrification benefits from not being overly complex.

In 2000, 31.82% of 25 and older population of the Metropolitan Statistical Area of Columbus had a bachelor's degree or more. At the same time, 4.73% of East Franklinton’s and 4.22% of West Franklinton’s populations had a bachelor’s degree or more, dramatically less than the MSA. However, 38.99% of North of Broad’s population had a bachelor's degree, making North of Broad not eligible to be described as possible to gentrify in 2000. In 2010, the MSA’s bachelor's degree or more population increased to 35.84%. In East Franklinton, this decreased to 0%, making it not gentrifying. The West

Franklinton bachelor's degree or more population increased to 4.02%, an increase of 0.73%. Since this was less than 150% of the growth in the MSA (6.03%), West Franklinton also did not gentrify. Thus, according to the Vigdor definition none of the Franklinton census tracts gentrified between 2000 and 2010.

Vigdor Definition (2010 to 2019)

Following the same methods, I analyzed the changes between Franklinton's census tracts in 2010 versus 2019. The 2020 and 2021 data were not available in 2010 boundaries at the time of the study, and the Census differential privacy policy has also affected viewing the data in East Franklinton post-2019. Nevertheless, the data in 2019 shows dramatic differences compared to 2010. In 2010, the MSA's 25 and older population with a bachelor's degree was 35.84% and rose to 40.05% in 2019, a difference of 4.21%. The cutoff according to Vigdor et al. (2002) of 50% above the MSA increase would be 6.32% and as such, East Franklinton and North of Broad exceeded this growth, 12.65% and 10.61%, respectively. East Franklinton rose from 0% in 2010, and North of Broad rose from 46.43% in 2010 to 57.04% in 2019. However, because North of Broad was already above the MSA average at 46.43%, it cannot be considered gentrifiable. West Franklinton's 25 and older population with a bachelor's degree also increased, going from 4.95% in 2010 to 10.91% in 2019. However, this modest increase did not surpass the 50% above the threshold above MSA's increase of 6.32%.

However, if 2021 data was used, these changes would appear even more dramatic. In 2021, East Franklinton's percentage of the population with a bachelor's degree or more rose to 37.30%. With the new census tract boundaries, the differences between the two

new North of Broad census tracts highlight how different the areas are. In 2021, the southern North of Broad census tract (43.02) only had 6.86% of its population with a bachelor's degree while the 43.01 census tract had a staggering 82.21%. As such, the changes of census geographies affect how we understand changes in gentrification and matter.

Although all three census tracts in Franklinton experienced growth in their 25 and older population with a bachelor's degree or more, only East Franklinton was below the average of the MSA in 2010 and increased more than the MSA by 2019. Thus, only East Franklinton experienced gentrification according to Vigdor et al.'s definition (2002). If 2021 data was used, it would not appear to affect these results, but it would indicate how smaller area geographies could tell very different stories among the census tracts in Franklinton.

Freeman Definition (2000 to 2010)

Following Freeman (2005), I analyzed whether Franklinton would be considered a potentially gentrifying neighborhood. The first criteria Freeman outlined was that a neighborhood be located in the central city. Since Franklinton is just across the river from Downtown Columbus and is approximately a 0.1-mile distance, Franklinton fits the criteria of being in the central city. The other Franklinton census tracts, North of Broad and West Franklinton, are approximately a 0.8-mile distance, thus making them both still within the central city. Second, Freeman (2005) stated that potentially gentrifying the census tracts have a lower median household income than compared to the rest of the metropolitan area. In 2000, the Franklin County had a median household income of

\$75,387 (inflated to 2022 dollars). Meanwhile, the median household income of East Franklinton, West Franklinton and North of Broad were \$13,750.77; \$26,097.53, and \$41,622.57 respectively. Lastly, Freeman argued that within a potentially gentrifying neighborhood, the proportion of the housing built within the last 20 years would fall below the median proportion of housing built within the last 20 years of the MSA.

As noted before, I used a similar strategy to gauge the year built indicator. I used data from “Year Structure Built” from the American Community Survey 5-Year Estimates from 2019, which gives data on the number of structures that were built in each decade or since 2014. This data does not include data on structures that are not renter or owner-occupied housing, like businesses. I took the number of structures built from 1980 to 1989 and added it to the number of structures built from 1990 to 1999 and divided it by the number of housing units in 2000 to get the proportion of housing units built within a 20-year time span. Certainly, this will undercount structures that have been demolished, but it is the best data available from the Census. According to this definition, the proportion of housing built in Franklin County from 1980 to 2000 was 32.64% of the total housing stock while the proportion of housing built from 1980 to 2000 in East Franklinton, West Franklinton, and North of Broad were 3.50%, 4.84%, and 43.99%, respectively. Thus, East and West Franklinton could be considered gentrifiable by Freeman’s methodology in 2000. North of Broad, which includes part of Marble Cliff and Grandview South, saw more structures built compared to the median of the county.

Whether a neighborhood is gentrifying as of 2010, following Freeman’s (2005) methodology would mean that there is 1) a change in educational attainment (4-year

degree or more) greater than the metropolitan area and 2) an increase in real housing prices. From 2000 to 2010, Franklin County's population (25 and older) that attained a bachelor's degree increased from 31.82% to 35.84%, an increase of 4.02%. Within the East Franklinton census tract, the population with a bachelor's degree or more actually decreased from 4.73 to 0%, making it non-gentrifying. West Franklinton, on the other hand, did experience an increase in education (4.22% to 4.95%), yet it remained lower than the increase in the county. All three census tracts, however, experienced increases in median gross rent and median home value. By Freeman's definition, none of the three census tracts in Franklinton underwent gentrification from 2000 to 2010. When looking at the other descriptive statistics from 2000 to 2010, it appears that aside from North of Broad, East and West Franklinton appears to be areas that suffered decline.

Freeman Definition (2010 to 2019)

Following the same methodology, I examined the same census tracts in Franklinton except between 2010 and 2019. Due to the COVID-19 pandemic, changes in census tract boundaries, and the changes in the Census disclosure avoidance, comparing 2020 data to 2010 data is currently not possible, thus I choose to use 2019 data. However, this choice complicates the findings of the data, which will be discussed (Kenny et al. 2021; Sperling 2012).

Again, all three census tracts are located in the central city. In 2010, the median household income in Franklin County was \$49,087 (\$66,108 in 2022 inflation-adjusted dollars). Meanwhile, the median household income of East Franklinton, West Franklinton and North of Broad were \$9,291.40; \$25,054.73, and \$42,141.50 respectively

(in 2022 inflation-adjusted dollars). To measure years structures were built in 2010, I followed the same process as earlier. The proportion of housing built in Franklin County from 1990 to 2010 was 29.37% of the total housing stock. The proportion of housing built from 1990 to 2010 in East Franklinton, West Franklinton, and North of Broad were 4.22%, 8.74%, and 47.84%, respectively. Again, East and West Franklinton could be considered gentrifiable by Freeman's methodology in 2010, but North of Broad could not because of its high rate of housing built recently.

Whether a neighborhood is gentrifying as of 2019, follows the same methodology as above: 1) a change in educational attainment (4-year degree or more) greater than the metropolitan area and 2) an increase in real housing prices. From 2010 to 2019, Franklin County's population (25 and older) that attained a bachelor's degree increased from 35.84% to 40.05%, an increase of 4.21%. The East Franklinton census tract saw a dramatic increase of the population with a bachelor's degree or more, going from 0% in 2010 to 12.65% in 2019, thus it gentrified. West Franklinton also experienced an increase in education (4.95% to 10.91%) with an increase of 5.96%, which also made it gentrified. All three census tracts also experienced increases in median gross rent, but median home value remained more complicated. The median home value increased in the East Franklinton and North of Broad census tracts, but it actually decreased in the West Franklinton census tract when looking at 2019 data. However, if one observed the 2021 median home value data, the West Franklinton census tract(s) would be included as gentrifying. For the sake of keeping with the proper Freeman definition, only East Franklinton would be considered gentrifying, but upon further examination one could

certainly consider West Franklinton as gentrifying too, especially in recent years considering the notable increase in home values.

Landis Definition (1990 to 2010)

Unlike the other two definitions of gentrification that use 10-year timeframes, the Landis (2016) definition uses a 20-year timeframe. Like space matters in our understanding of gentrification, so does time. It captures different social phenomenon and trends in migration in neighborhoods. As such, I see this as a benefit of using the Landis definition, known as the 3-D method or “double-decile-difference” method (Lucy and Phillips 2006). Following the Landis (2016) definition of gentrification, the first analysis of gentrification used data from 1990 and 2010 to analyze substantial neighborhood socioeconomic change (SNSEC) using income deciles by census tract. Landis initially categorized substantial neighborhood decline and upgrading, where a two or more decile decrease between 1990 and 2010 in median household income constitutes neighborhood decline. Whereas a two or more decile increase in median household income constitutes neighborhood upgrading. Landis (2016) identified potentially gentrifiable census tracts as being within the first four income deciles for the metropolitan statistical area in 1990. Although, neighborhood upgrading can occur without gentrification, as potentially gentrifiable Census tracts were then considered gentrifying if they experienced substantial neighborhood upgrading by 2010. Additionally, to qualify for gentrification, neighborhoods must be within 10 kilometers of the Central Business District. All of Franklinton falls within this boundary of the CBD.

There are several benefits to using this approach to study gentrification. For one, it avoids interpreting small changes in neighborhoods. Second, it measures gentrification over a longer period. Because neighborhoods are constantly changing, it can be useful to study how they transition over a longer period, rather than an arbitrary distinction of a ten-year timeframe. However, the Landis Method is not without its drawbacks. For one, it identifies neighborhoods as census tracts, which are often arbitrary boundaries drawn around neighborhoods. Also, this method relies on relativity to other neighborhoods, as the entire metropolitan area could have grown wealthier, but this would not be reflected in decile rankings. Nevertheless, this approach remains useful to the study.

In 1990, the median household income for Franklin County was \$69,495 (in 2022 inflation-adjusted dollars). Yet, in 2010, the median household income for Franklin County was \$66,108 (in 2022 inflation-adjusted dollars). This should not be surprising considering the impact of the Great Recession, and this falls in line with Landis' research, which found that neighborhood decline was the dominant form of neighborhood socioeconomic change between 1990 and 2010.

After making income deciles for 1990 for the Franklin County area using the `ntile` function in R, the Franklinton census tracts were all in or below the fourth decile of the metropolitan area. East and West Franklinton were all within the first decile, meaning their median household income was between the percentile of 0% and 10%. North of Broad, however, was in the fourth decile, meaning it fell between the percentile of 30 and 40%. Thus, all the census tracts in Franklinton were potentially gentrifiable in 1990 according to the Landis (2016) method. By 2010, and East and West Franklinton

remained in the first decile of median household income for the county. In addition, North of Broad declined to the third decile with a median household income of \$42,141 (in 2022 inflation-adjusted dollars). As such, the three Franklinton census tracts did not gentrify according to the Landis (2016) method, nor did they undergo substantial neighborhood socioeconomic change. This falls in line with the other definitions used, which found that Franklinton census tracts did not gentrify between 1990 and 2010.

Landis Definition (2000 to 2019)

Following the same methodology above of comparing a 20-year timeframe, I expand this method to the 2000 to 2019 timeframe. To set the context again, in 2000, the median household income of Franklin County was \$42,734 (\$75,387 in 2022 inflation-adjusted dollars) and grew to \$61,305 by 2019 (\$70,261 in 2022 inflation-adjusted dollars). In creating the median household income deciles in 2000, both East and West Franklinton remained in the first income decile while North of Broad was in the fourth income decile, making them all potentially gentrifiable. By 2019, East and West Franklinton were again still in the first income decile, making them not gentrified according to the Landis method (2016). They also did not experience substantial neighborhood socioeconomic change. However, in 2019, North of Broad's median household income rose to \$75,830 (in 2022 inflation-adjusted dollars). North of Broad's decile rank increased from the fourth decile to the seventh decile, meaning it fell between the 60% and 70% percentile of all census tracts in Franklin County. This means that North of Broad, between 2000 and 2019, experienced substantial neighborhood

socioeconomic change in the form of substantial neighborhood upgrading, and it experienced gentrification.

Area of Franklinton	Vigdor (2000-2010)	Freeman (2000-2010)	Landis (1990-2010)	Vigdor (2010-2019)	Freeman (2010-2019)	Landis (2000-2019)
East Franklinton	No	No	No	Yes	Yes	No
North of Broad	No	No	No	No	No	Yes
West Franklinton	No	No	No	No	No	No

Table 9. Gentrification Indices in Franklinton

Migration Patterns

When looking at the Total Frequency of Census Tract destinations after moving out of a Franklinton Census Tract, the top two most common destinations were other census tracts within Franklinton itself (Figure 8). In total, there were 5229 household moves out of a Franklinton Census Tract between 2008 and 2022. The most frequent destination was North of Broad, with 905 households moving to the census tract. The second most frequent destination was West Franklinton, with 719 households moving to the census tract. The third most common destination was East Franklinton, which had many fewer households, only 115, moving to it.

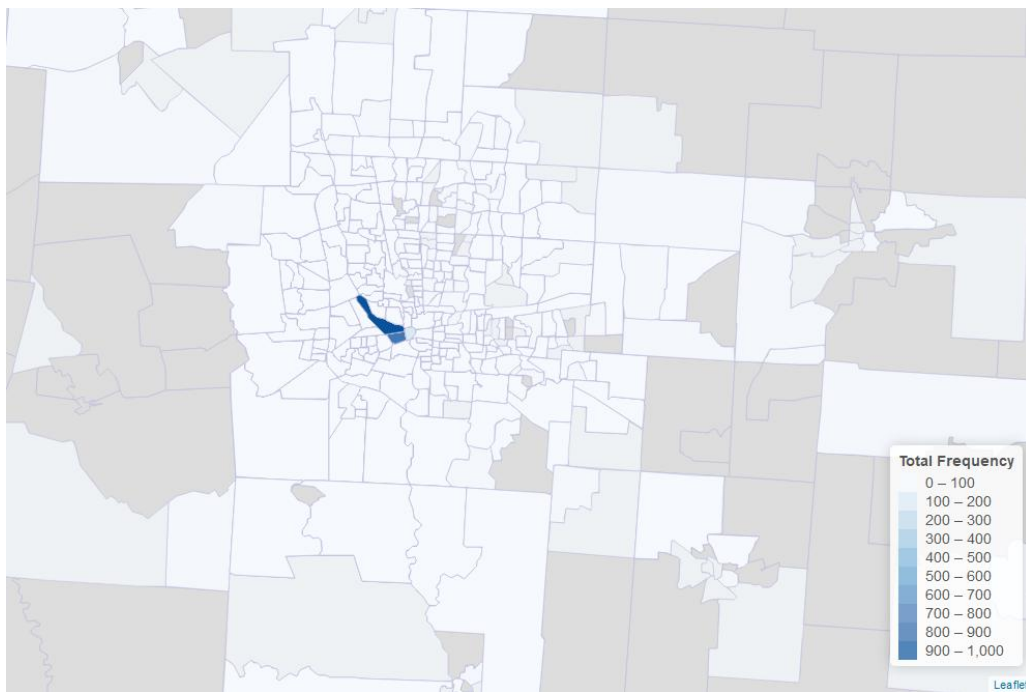


Figure 8. Map of Destination Tracts (Franklinton Included)

When not including Franklinton Census Tracts as a destination, the trend is slightly different. There were 3490 households that moved out of a Franklinton Census Tract and did not remain within the neighborhood, which is shown in Figure 9. Broken

down by year, this reached a height of 310 households in 2016 (Figure 3). Without including intra-neighborhood moves, the top two destination census tracts are in the Hilltop neighborhood, which is just outside of Franklinton, to the West. For these two census tracts, each had 87 households move into them.

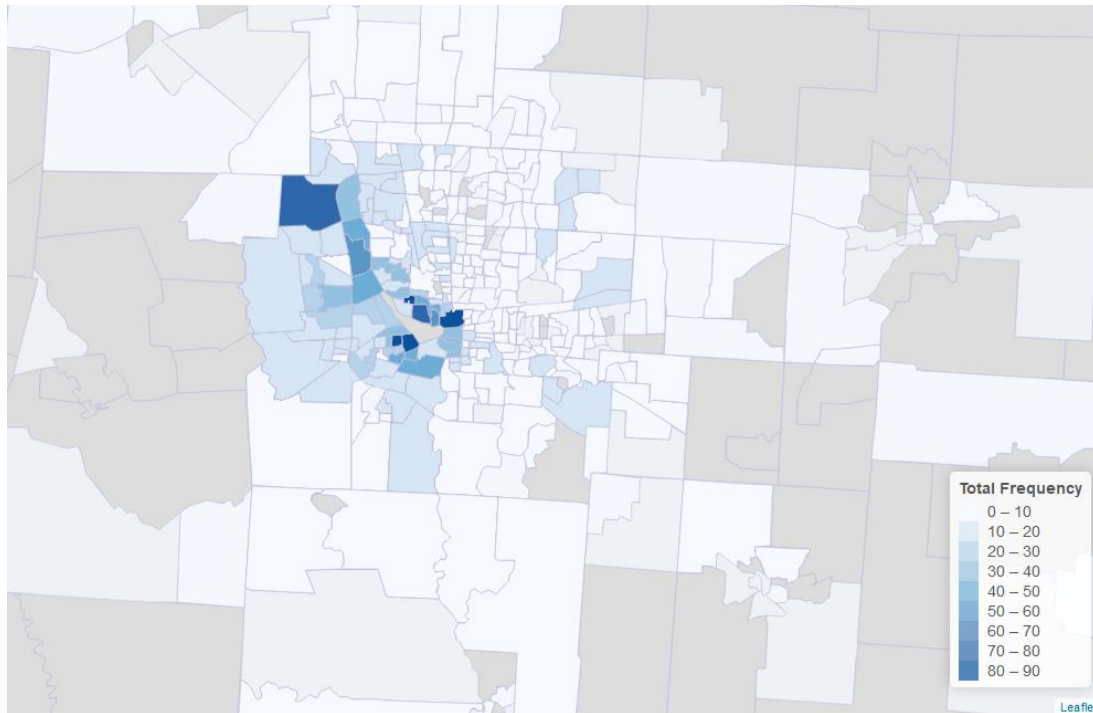


Figure 9. Map of Destination Tracts After Leaving Franklinton

These migration patterns are in line based on what residents said during interviews. The next two most common census tract destinations included tracts located in the Downtown Columbus and the Grandview Heights, Ohio area, an inner-city suburb. For those moving outside of Franklinton, there may be two migration pathways. For those that are affluent and upwardly mobile, they appear to be moving to downtown and the Grandview area, where there are an increasing number of upscale rentals available.

For those that are unable to afford Franklinton any longer, they appear to be moving to Hilltop and other parts of South and Southwest Columbus/Franklin County. Notably, few households appear to relocate to the East Side of Columbus. Despite the East Side's affordability, it has a higher Black population density, unlike Franklinton and the West Side. Surprisingly, not as many residents moved as far outside the city as I expected given some of the interactions and interviews with residents. Few moved into Grove City, which I had been told during interviews was a popular destination. In fact, many moved to the Hilliard area and other Western suburbs. Lastly, very few moved to rural areas within the Columbus MSA, which I was somewhat surprised by given its affordability. Yet this may also make sense because rural areas of Ohio continue to lose population as the city of Columbus continues to grow.

While I have discussed the areas of the Columbus MSA that residents of Franklinton move to, I have yet to discuss where new residents of Franklinton originated from in the Columbus MSA. Spatially, this is shown in Figure 10. From 2008-2022, there were 1246 households that moved into Franklinton from the Columbus MSA, which reached a height of 70 households in 2014 (Figure 3). The most common predecessor tract before moving to Franklinton was 39049001902, with 34 household moving to Franklinton. This census tract is in Grandview Heights/Upper Arlington Area, suggesting these households likely had higher incomes and education. The second most common predecessor tract was 39049004700, which is a part of the Hilltop neighborhood that is incredibly poor and disadvantaged. The third most common predecessor tract was 39049003000 and is a part of Downtown Columbus and Short North, which also suggests that these households were more affluent and educated. Altogether, the most common

predecessor tracts appear to be both from the affluent and poorer tracts surrounding Franklinton. For upwardly mobile, and affluent young people living in the inner city, Franklinton is a hip neighborhood in the inner city with lower rents than surrounding areas, which may lead them to move to Franklinton. At the same time, given the increased likelihood of mobility of poor residents, it seems possible that new poor residents of Franklinton move between Hilltop and Franklinton repeatedly. To further examine these data, I created interactive leaflet maps within the supplementary data files.

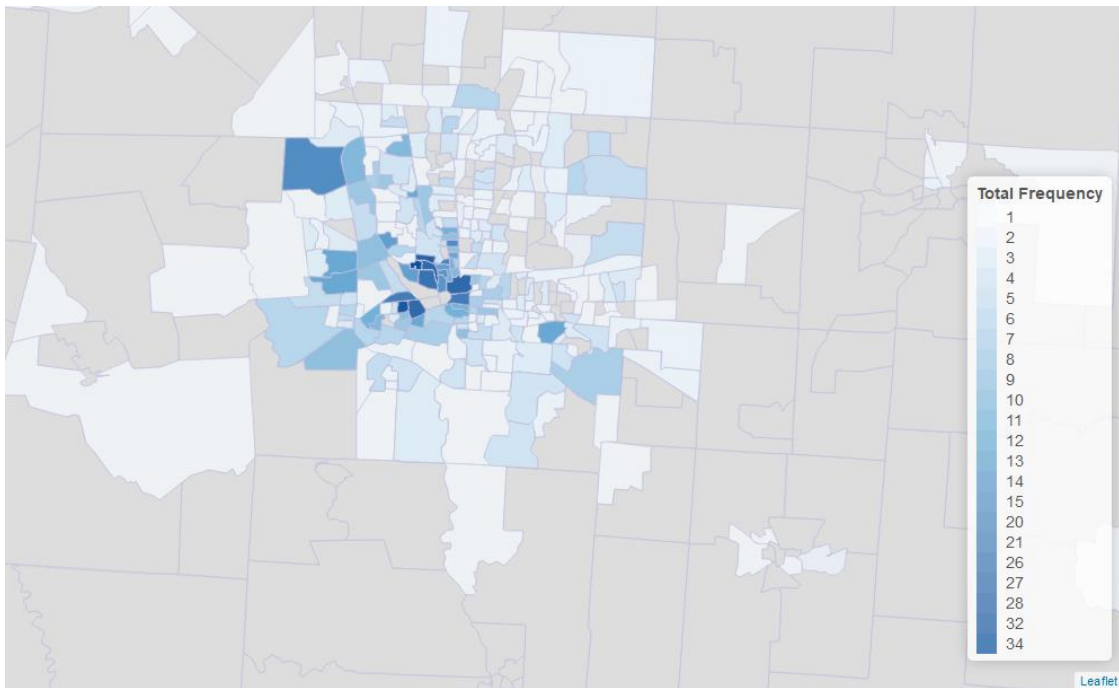


Figure 10. Map of Origin Tracts Before Moving to Franklinton

To explore this possibility of frequent neighborhood movement among the poor, I analyzed the household income data (in 2022-inflation-adjusted dollars) of families that moved by type of move from 2007-2022. Regardless of year, the household income data was non-normally distributed and was skewed right. Out of all families that moved, the

data was also still skewed right, but it was skewed more than the overall data for the Columbus MSA. In tens of thousands, the mean household income of all the Columbus MSA was 81.49, and the median was 60.98. Meanwhile, out of all households that moved, the mean household income was 63.52, and the median was 40.76. For families that moved out of a Franklinton census tract, the mean household income was 59.15, and median was 35.86. Interestingly, the mean household income of families that moved outside of Franklinton entirely was 78.69, and the Median is 54.38. This shows that many people that left Franklinton entirely were better off financially than those that moved within the neighborhood. For households that were about to move to Franklinton, the mean household income was 52.02, and the median is 35.32.

For families that moved out of Franklinton, their median incomes in the destination neighborhoods in Hilltop/SW side were lower than households that moved into areas in downtown, UA, and Grandview. For instance, households that left Franklinton and moved into the 39049004900 tract in Hilltop had a median household income of \$23,111 compared to those that moved into the 39049001902 tract in Grandview, who had a median household income of \$33,804. A similar trend emerges for origin tracts and households before moving to Franklinton. Households in the 39049001901 tract in Grandview that moved to Franklinton the following year had a median HH income of \$42,800 compared to the households in 39049004900 in Hilltop, who had a median household income of \$20,390.

To better understand the data, I broke the household income into quartiles based on the entirety of the Data Axle Columbus MSA data, as shown in Figure 11 and Figure 12. The cutoffs were as follows: (Q1, 0-25%: 0-29.27), (Q2, 25-50%: 29.28-60.98), (Q3,

50-75%: 60.99- 110.74), (Q4, 75-100%: 110.75-725.94). Broken down by income quartiles, it appears that people that move in and out of Franklinton tend to be on the poorer end of the economic spectrum. However, there are some slight differences, based on location and type of move. For instance, people that move completely out of Franklinton have higher income quantiles than those that leave for another tract within Franklinton itself, suggesting that there are people that make lateral moves within the neighborhood and that those that are better off appear to move out of the neighborhood entirely. For households that move into Franklinton from outside the neighborhood, they also often have lower incomes, possibly due to the neighborhood's affordability. There is the potential for many caveats and intricacies in this data, as the data could be capturing people that move into East Franklinton but then leave again, like transient upper-income young people.

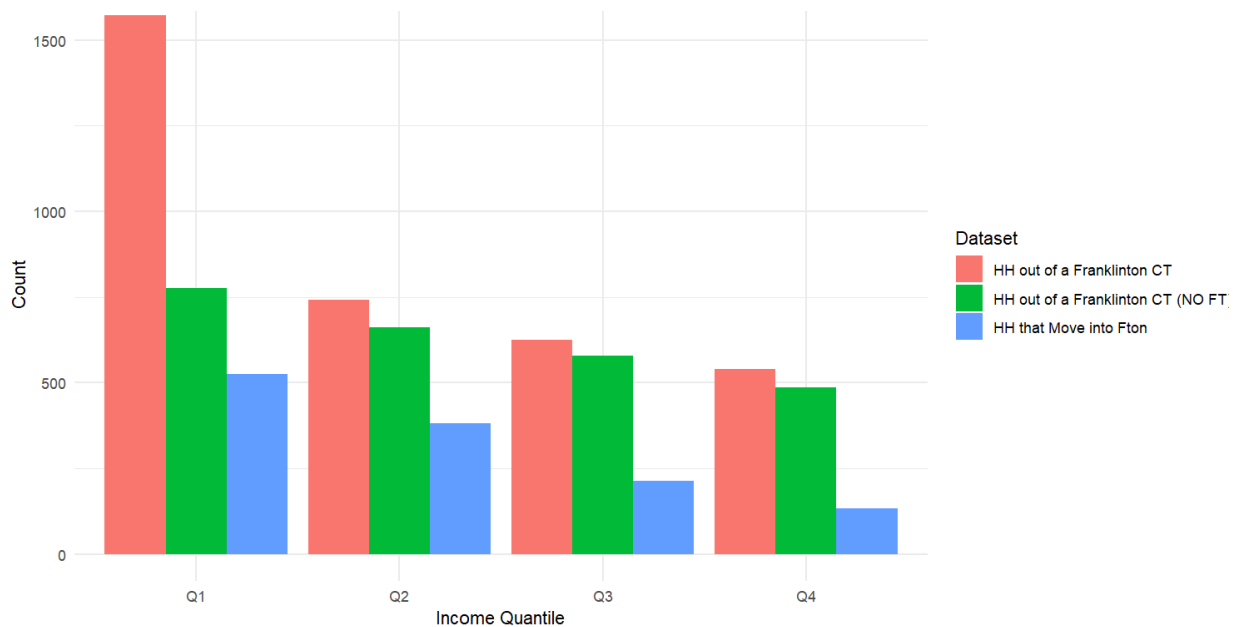


Figure 11. Income Quantile Frequency by Type of Move

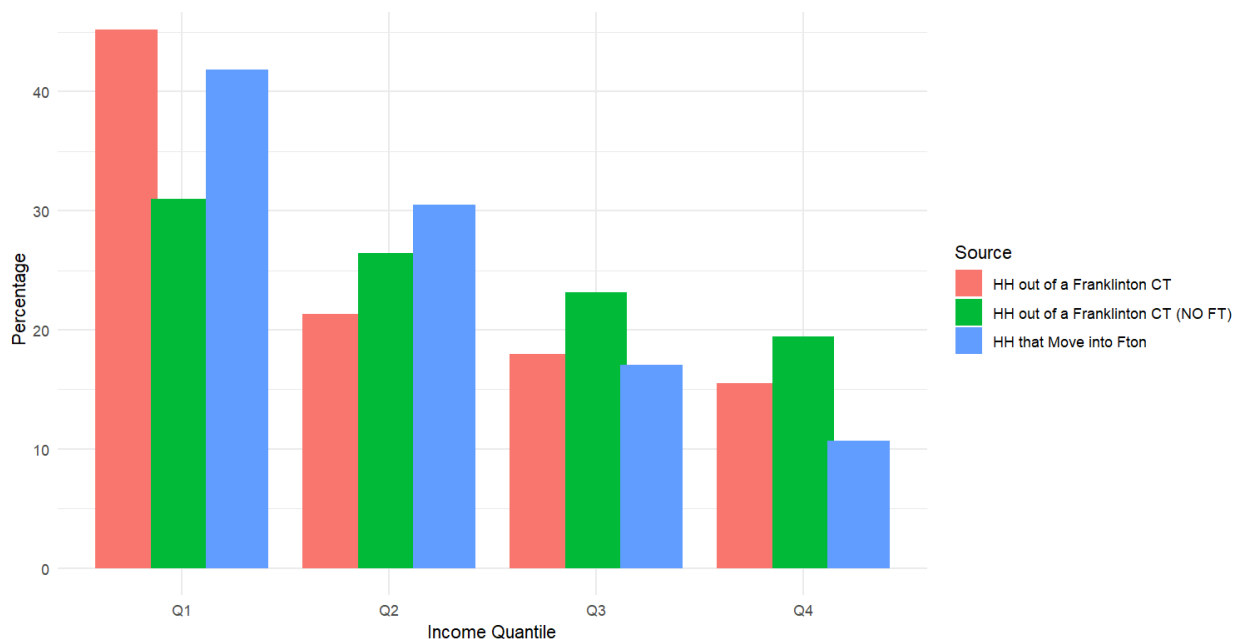


Figure 12. Income Quantile Frequency Percentages by Type of Move

Altogether, several interesting findings emerged from analyzing the Data Axle Historical Consumer Database. For one, there are several pockets of destination and origin tracts of movers in Franklinton. Outside of Franklinton itself, Hilltop, Grandview, Upper Arlington, and Downtown are hotspots for destinations and origins. Notably, the Dublin/Amlin area also has a large population of movers. Meanwhile, the most common areas for households moving out a Franklinton census tract are other Franklinton tracts, most commonly North of Broad and West Franklinton, suggesting that there has been migration from East Franklinton, which is in line with the demolition of public housing, rising cost-of-living, and the increase in crime rates in West Franklinton and North of Broad. Previous research supports these findings, as displaced people are likely to move into neighborhoods with similar disadvantage (Desmond and Shollenberger 2015).

Furthermore, none of these destination or origin tracts contain high Black population density, pointing to evidence that neighborhoods gentrify more quickly when there are fewer Black residents (Hwang and Sampson 2014). Yet, old Franklinton residents also do not move to Black neighborhoods, further reproducing racial segregation across the city.

Based on income, it appears that households that move into and out of Franklinton have lower household incomes, pointing to the transiency of both lower income and younger, upwardly mobile people. However, households that moved to and from the Hilltop/Southwest Columbus census tracts had lower incomes compared to those that moved to and from Grandview, Upper Arlington, and Downtown Columbus. As such, there appeared to be two groups of migrants into and out of Franklinton. One group includes lower-income households and moves between Hilltop, Franklinton, and Southwest Columbus, while the other has slightly higher incomes, and can move to nicer neighborhoods, like Grandview, Downtown, and Upper Arlington, thus reproducing the housing insecurity along class and racial lines. As Franklinton and Columbus continue to grow and develop, Data Axle data will be incredibly useful in continuing to tell the story of gentrification and migration.

Summary of Quantitative Results

The Franklinton neighborhood, by many accounts, has been in decline since at least the 1970s, especially in East Franklinton. This has been shown in the descriptive statistics data, including total population, race, age, housing characteristics, income, poverty, education, and crime. In terms of total population, all Franklinton census tracts have continued to experience population decline, particularly East Franklinton, which decreased from 3284 in 1970 to a mere 490 in 2021. Franklinton's racial changes vary by census tract. Although East Franklinton appears to be more racially diverse over time, it

has lost a substantial portion of its Black population. In West Franklinton, the Black population and Black population density have both increased. Some of East Franklinton's Black population could have moved into West Franklinton. Meanwhile, the Black population of North of Broad has decreased while the Latino population has grown substantially.

Like race, age also varies by census tract in Franklinton. The Percent Aged 25-34 has grown the most in East Franklinton, while this measure has decreased both in West Franklinton and North of Broad. However, the lowest median age of the census tracts is in North of Broad with a median age of 30.4 years. Across several housing variables, East Franklinton again appeared to be experiencing the greatest amount of change, especially in terms of rent, which rose from a median of \$266.60 in 2000 to \$828 in 2021. At the same time, vacancy rates rose dramatically across East Franklinton. Additionally, property taxes have risen over 200% in certain parts of the neighborhood (Meibers 2023). Economically, median household income increased in all of Franklinton, but especially for White households. However, East and West Franklinton, as of 2019, were still within the first decile of incomes in Franklin County. Racial differences were also obvious as only North of Broad experienced an increase in Black Median Household Income. Similarly, poverty rates varied by space and race. Each tract has incredibly high poverty rates, no more so than East Franklinton, with a poverty rate of almost 50%. In East Franklinton, White Poverty Rates halved between 2000 and 2019, while Black Poverty slightly increased.

In terms of education, educational attainment rose across all of Franklinton. Percent Less than High School decreased across all census tracts from 44.99% to 18.98%,

while Percent High School or GED, Percent Four-Year Degree, and Percent Graduate School or More increased along all census tracts. Changes in education were particularly prominent between 2010 and 2019, as shown by East Franklinton, which went from 0% to 8.73% in Four-Year Degrees and from 0% Graduate School or More to 3.92%.

Between 2010 and 2019, violent crime dropped dramatically in East Franklinton, to near zero, potentially because of the destruction of public housing and the men's shelter in East Franklinton. Thereafter, it rose in West Franklinton and North of Broad. Property crime, too, dropped in East Franklinton, but property crime remained stable. Because East Franklinton has experienced some of the most prominent changes, it should not come as a surprise that crime has dramatically decreased there (Barton 2016b). However, it is noteworthy that crime seemed to shift further West as a result of gentrification.

Altogether, no single measure or category of variable accurately describes the changes Franklinton and its residents have experienced. These measures vary over time and space, often in contradictory ways. Like the descriptive statistics, the three methods of identifying gentrification, too, varied by time and space. According to the Vigdor et al. (2002) method, between 2000 and 2010, none of the Franklinton census tracts experienced gentrification, yet between 2010 and 2019, East Franklinton experienced gentrification. Likewise, the Freeman (2005) method yielded similar results. Between 2000 and 2010, no Franklinton census tract experienced gentrification, yet between 2010 and 2019, East Franklinton underwent gentrification. Finally, the Landis (2016) method yielded different results. The Landis (2016) method found that none of the census tracts in Franklinton underwent gentrification between 1990 and 2010. Additionally, they did not experience any substantial neighborhood socioeconomic change, whether it be

upgrading or decline. However, the Landis method indicates that between 2000 and 2019, North of Broad experienced substantial neighborhood upgrading. As I hypothesized, different measures of gentrification would indicate varying results in the identification of gentrification of Franklinton's census tracts across time.

In addition to descriptive statistics and gentrification indices, migration data gathered from proprietary consumer databases illustrate movement within and outside of Franklinton, showing that there has been substantial relocation of residents to North of Broad, West Franklinton, and Hilltop. Furthermore, origin neighborhoods for new Franklinton residents often come from Hilltop, Grandview, Downtown, and Upper Arlington. In conjunction with the other data sources, this suggests that residents of Franklinton have moved or have been pushed further West by pressures like rising housing costs. At the same time, new residents come from more well-off areas of the city, which is in-line with previous gentrification research (Chelcea, Popescu, and Cristea 2015; Smith 1987; Zukin 1987). As Franklinton continues to develop and this development pushes further west, more research is needed to understand the impacts.

Conclusions

The nationwide affordable housing crisis stretches far and wide, with gentrification being among the processes intensifying this crisis. As governments, academics, and organizations try to address these issues, they rely on gentrification measures to identify where the problem occurs, yet various definitions and conceptions of gentrification exist (Brown-Saracino 2017; Freeman 2005; Landis 2016; Reades et al. 2019; Vigdor et al. 2002). Thus, an exploratory analysis of descriptive statistics, gentrification measures, and migration data can be useful to examine the scope of gentrification. Using the Franklinton neighborhood of Columbus, Ohio, the current study

addresses these concerns, contributes to the literature on quantitative measurement of gentrification, and provides necessary information for concerned parties within Columbus and Ohio for addressing Franklinton's gentrification.

As shown in the descriptive statistics, various indices of gentrification, and consumer residential data, there is no singular way to describe the neighborhood changes in Franklinton and its census tracts. Descriptively, the neighborhood has experienced substantial decline, followed by rapid increases in household income, decreased Black population, and decreases in crime. At the same time, some gentrification indices suggest gentrification has happened in East Franklinton, other methods identify North of Broad (Brown-Saracino 2017; Freeman 2005; Landis 2016; Vigdor et al. 2002). If various discrepancies occur even within one small neighborhood in Columbus, Ohio with three census tracts, questions must be raised on larger national models that rely on differing definitions of gentrification, for they too could yield vastly different results (Preis et al. 2021). Meanwhile within Franklinton, migration data suggests that there has been substantial migration of Franklinton residents to North of Broad, West Franklinton, and Hilltop, areas with lower median household income, less development, and further from the urban core. New residents of Franklinton also appear to originate from neighboring tracts located in Hilltop, Upper Arlington, Grandview, and Downtown Columbus, with the latter full of upwardly mobile, young, educated, white people. Altogether, these findings point to a continuation of housing insecurity and residential segregation within Columbus. While income and educational attainment have increased in Franklinton, the reality of the situation is that poverty has been spatially redistributed to other areas, suggesting that impoverished people are being placed and gentrification has occurred.

However, the changes ongoing in the neighborhood are complex and multifaceted, and one could argue it would be a disservice to describe Franklinton's changes with any simple measure. The use of local research on gentrification through exploratory research and various variables illuminates just how neighborhoods change. Furthermore, without a single agreed-upon definition or way to measure gentrification, local and contextually appropriate research on neighborhoods and cities is necessary to fully understand how neighborhoods change over time (Brown-Saracino 2017; Finio 2022).

As such, it is important to use quantitative methods in conjunction in qualitative and community-based methods (Brown-Saracino 2017), like DuBois' study of Philadelphia (DuBois 1899). In conjunction, these methods work together to illuminate observed and experienced changes. As shown in previous chapters of this dissertation, there are very real experiences of gentrification that would not be examined by solely observing quantitative data.

Undoubtedly, there are limitations to this quantitative research. For one, this study is largely descriptive and does not conduct analyses using statistical significance, yet because of the relatively small sample size and geographic scope of this study, the descriptive statistics are more than adequate in providing a greater understanding of the quantitative spatial exploration of gentrification. In addition, there are data limitations regarding census tract boundaries and Census data that inhibit how granular data analysis could be, which harkens back to the tyranny of census geography, changes brought about by COVID, and the differential privacy policy (Bureau 2021, 2023; Kenny et al. 2021; Sperling 2012). Finally, previous research has pointed out that measuring displacement is like measuring the invisible, since secondary data and social surveys may hide the depth

of the problem (Atkinson 2000a; Wyly et al. 2010). Thus, the problem of displacement in Franklinton could be far worse than the data suggests.

As a result of these limitations and the complexity of data, the qualitative research within this dissertation works in conjunction with the quantitative research to triangulate findings and provide a breadth of understanding gentrification in Franklinton, including what is driving gentrification and how these changes are experienced. The residents of Franklinton are experiencing very real changes to their lives and built environment that should not be overlooked, which is why the qualitative studies of this dissertation are so important, as they provide context for which these quantitative changes take place and are experienced.

Regardless of these limitations and the various data points, this chapter demonstrates how Franklinton has changed dramatically over time, with substantial evidence pointing towards gentrification, and not all of these changes are “without the negative” (The Atlantic 2014). To uncover the origins of these changes and gentrification, I conduct qualitative research that highlights how this trend is likely to continue as “Boomtown Columbus” continues to grow and develop and Franklinton along with it (Cox 2020) via “The Columbus Way” (Rivkin 2015). As explored in further chapters, much of these changes can be traced to New Urban Politics, the Rent Gap, and the increasing role of capital in our cities (Harvey 1973; Marcuse 2015; Pattillo 2013; Smith 1987). As the class divide, the financialization of housing, and the lack of housing development continues, Columbus and Franklinton will continue to gentrify, for better and for worse. Until housing is considered a right and not an investment, this trend will continue within Franklinton, Columbus, and the nation itself.

Chapter 3. The Political Economy of Development in Franklinton

Abstract

Franklinton, Columbus, Ohio's oldest neighborhood, has long been one of the city's most economically disadvantaged areas. However, recent transformations are rapidly reshaping its built environment and demographic composition. Scholars have long debated the forces driving gentrification—whether it emerges organically or is intentionally orchestrated by powerful economic and political actors. To examine these dynamics, I conducted interviews with key stakeholders involved in Franklinton's redevelopment, including developers, government officials, community organizations, and local businesses. My findings suggest that these changes originally stem from a neighborhood regime, which has been increasingly dominated by powerful public and private entities that shapes development in a top-down manner. Respondents consistently framed gentrification through a supply-side housing perspective, downplayed displacement concerns, and endorsed neoliberal, state-sponsored policies that accelerate redevelopment. Many justified these processes through the "Columbus Way," a collaborative but elite-driven approach best understood within the framework of New Urban Politics—the neoliberal restructuring of urban governance to attract investment and spur economic growth. Ethnographic and archival research further corroborated these findings, illustrating how development has become increasingly top-down. This study contributes to broader discussions on neoliberal urban governance, the politics of gentrification, and the contested right to the city.

Introduction

Originally coined by Ruth Glass (1964), gentrification has become a prominent, albeit contentious topic within urban studies. Glass (1964) identified gentrification as the process of the urban gentry of London moving back into the city and transforming working-class neighborhoods. They fundamentally changed the neighborhoods they moved to by increasing property values and displacing long-time, typically lower-income residents. Since this term was first described, work in the field has grown dramatically, with many ways to measure and define gentrification. With rising housing costs across the U.S., an increasingly urbanized population, and a rise in inner-city life, gentrification research is of the utmost importance, in major and less major cities, alike.

Frequently, gentrification research focuses on more of an inevitable or “natural process” spurred by the “creative class”, or artists and creative young professionals, seeking out lower rents (Florida 2003; Workman 2011). However, this naturalization of gentrification ignores the agency of the privileged individuals that choose colonize gentrifying neighborhoods (Kent-Stoll 2020). Furthermore, this oversimplifies how the gentrification process works, including the globalization of capital, different types of urban governance, and specific policy choices affect gentrification (Harvey 1973; Immergluck 2022; Levy et al. 2007; Logan and Molotch 1987; Smith 1987; Stone 1989; Van Gent and Boterman 2019).

Scholars have long researched how cities and neighborhoods are shaped, including political economy and urban regimes, and this research can help us understand the toll of different groups in the process of gentrification (Logan and Molotch 1987;

Stone 1989, 1993; Webb 2013). Logan and Molotch (1987) first described the political economy of cities, including the growth machine model where elites push for development and growth of a city across multiple domains and industries. The political economy can be defined as the collusion of state and capital interests, often at the expense of parts of the population (Parish 2017). On the other hand, Stone (1989, 1993) sought to study the regime politics of urban Atlanta, the relationship between elected officials and their influences from individuals or groups. These urban regimes work together to promote their own interests, often at the expense of others along race and class lines. These regimes perpetuate social and class reproduction via their power, influence, and capital (Harvey 2009).

However, these ideas of urban regimes, governance, and gentrification can be merged to provide a greater understanding of power and decision-making that affects neighborhoods. Cox (2020) has built upon this political economy and urban regime view, called New Urban Politics (NUP). Cox has also utilized this idea for the Columbus area, which is a unique case study for its specific political economy. Within Central Ohio, decisionmakers and members of the political economy have built their own cities, negotiated with the city of Columbus itself, and had significant sway in development via public-private partnerships known as the “Columbus Way” (Rivkin 2015). The Columbus Way, which is made up of billionaires, urban elites, developers, and real estate investors is dominated by several families including the Wexners, Schottensteins, and Wolfes. However, these private interests work together with other public interests (city officials, planners, and related coalitions) to achieve their vision (Cox 2020; Reece and Abou-

Ghalioum 2023; Rivkin 2015). Unlike other cities, these decisions and partnerships are celebrated and encouraged by the city, supporting the efforts and interests of business leaders before residents. While Cox examined the suburbs of Columbus, he did not investigate the development of inner-city communities, particularly Franklinton. In contrast, scholars like Webb (2013) analyzed the structures and coalitions that drove neighborhood development in several inner-city Columbus neighborhoods. Their work significantly influenced the questions explored in this chapter.

Other scholars have researched inner-city gentrification and political economy. Most recently, Immergluck (2022) explored the history of race and development in Atlanta, and the “playground” for the rich that has emerged in places like Ponce City Market. While previous research on urban governance has recognized the role of top-down development processes, processes driven by larger government and private entities, many gentrification research articles have neglected the role of the state in gentrification via the financialization and commodification of housing. As such, some have suggested that the state is now actively involved in gentrification processes, where the state incentivizes private investment to eliminate “problem areas” of the city with financial efforts (Aalbers 2019; Morisson and Bevilacqua 2019; Uitermark and Bosker 2014; Van Gent and Boterman 2019) .

To better understand these relationships, my work, drawing on 33 interviews of various actors within the political economy and urban governance within Franklinton and Columbus, highlights how the state and elites play an increasingly disproportionate and influential role in the development and gentrification of Franklinton. Furthermore, I

demonstrate the complexity within urban governance in Franklinton and the relationships between different actors and sectors within the development sphere of Franklinton, including the emergence of a neighborhood regime and its shift towards a top-down development process driven by the city and private interests. Interviews also highlighted the rationale and logic upholding the decisions these actors make about gentrification and development, providing evidence for The Columbus Way and NUP. Finally, I explore the emerging political economy of development within Franklinton and Columbus, focused on prioritizing developers and development.

Literature and Background

Gentrification

Gentrification is a contentious topic within the social sciences with no agreed-upon definition (Brown-Saracino 2017; Finio 2022; Freeman 2006). Most typically, it revolves around the changing characteristics, built environment, and demographics of a neighborhood located near the central city via rising rent values and displacement of long-time residents by wealthier residents (Smith 1987; Zukin 1987). This chapter aims to uncover the role of urban governance in the development and flux taking place within Franklinton and how decisionmakers influence and make sense of this change.

Urban Governance

To provide an understanding of the intricate web of actors and influences shaping urban governance, Logan and Molotch's (1987) concept of urban growth machines and local political economies laid the groundwork of the study of urban governance by highlighting the collaborative efforts of powerful coalitions, often prioritizing growth

over other considerations. In doing so, they heavily criticized the urban ecology view of development that focused too much on the linear evolution of space (Park and Burgess 1925). However, this framework has been built upon and challenged by other scholars, citing the complexity of urban governance and power dynamics (Shearmur 2008).

Stone (1989, 1993) emphasized the role of local elites in Atlanta in urban regime theory, arguing that their interests and priorities significantly influence development trajectories (Stone 1989). Stone argued that the growth machine model had significant limitations that ignored how diffuse power was in a city, including how other coalitions of businesses, political organizations, politicians, and community organizations form, disperse, and reform again to create policy. Yet, these regime allies often held conflicting views, suggesting that elite domination, as suggested by growth machines is not an accurate representation of urban governance. Similarly, Patterson and Silverman (2013) emphasized the role of the third sector, non-profits and nongovernmental organizations, including universities, hospitals, and how other institutions influence power relations and alter the physical shaping of cities. This work on urban regimes underscores the need to consider not just the decisions made by powerful private and public actors, but also the ways in which urban governance is influenced by the third sector. In an even more pluralistic approach, Giddens' (1979) structuration theory argued that social structures and individuals' actions are constantly intertwined, shaping and being shaped by each other (Giddens 1979). This perspective encourages theories of urban governance to move beyond simplistic notions of top-down power structures and acknowledge the agency of

various actors within the urban realm, including residents, community organizations, and social movements, in shaping the development of their cities.

This battle between more pluralistic and top-down approaches to urban governance continues to rage, but they do not have to be entirely separate. Cox's (1991, 2020) *New Urban Politics* has emphasized the ways that developers and private interest use persuasive strategies to garner public support, highlighting how urban governance is moving in a neoliberal direction where city officials and policy work for developers in a global capitalist economy. Cox used this framework to examine the development of Columbus' suburbs, namely Easton and New Albany. This neo-Marxist approach fits well within Critical Urban Theory and the economic foundations of capitalism that build cities (Brenner et al. 2012; Harvey 1973; Harvey and Chatterjee 1974; Marcuse 2009). Similarly, Immergluck's (2022) case study of Atlanta utilized a similar framework, where the city incentivized developers and pushed gentrification. These new cases of capital-driven growth on a city-wide scale call into question how this capital-driven growth operates on a neighborhood-level.

Each of these models of urban governance have utility, but they are each limited by time and space. To build a truly nuanced interpretation of the interplay between power, interests, and discourses in urban governance, researchers can combine these diverse top-down and pluralistic perspectives and study how they operate within space. In combining these theoretical approaches, one can understand the complex interplay of cooperative and competitive interests within different cities, neighborhoods, and various other geographic scales over space and time, which can be incredibly useful in studying

gentrification. However, before studying the urban governance that produces gentrification within Franklinton, one must reckon with its history as “The Bottoms.”

A Brief History of Franklinton

Long before Columbus boomed on the east side of the Scioto River, Franklinton, on the west bank, was the first European settlement in Franklin County. It was founded in 1797 by Lucas Sullivant, and it thrived for a period of time. However, Columbus, which was built on higher ground and thus less prone to flooding, eventually surpassed its neighbor. By 1870, Columbus officially annexed Franklinton. With its susceptibility to flooding and low economic standing, Franklinton was given the nickname “The Bottoms.” Following two major floods in 1913 and 1959, the neighborhood experienced population decline, disinvestment, and vacancy. In 1983, it was declared a flood zone, and construction was prohibited, further pushing disinvestment and population loss. After decades of decline, the Army Corps of Engineers constructed a floodwall in 2004. Within walking distance of downtown Columbus and the Ohio statehouse, the neighborhood is strategically located and has seen massive investment in recent years. The neighborhood has changed dramatically since then, and a new flood of development is upon the neighborhood that threatens to wash away long-time residents.

Gentrification in Columbus and Franklinton

Columbus neighborhoods and Franklinton itself have been the subject of previous gentrification research. Gentrification research within Columbus dates back to Mergler (1984), and has included research on German Village, Victorian Village, Italian Village, Old Towne East, Weinland Park, and the Shorth North (Bryant 2005; Fusch 1980;

Hansan 2005; Meibers 2022; Mergler 1984; Webb 2013). Each of these studies utilized various methods of defining, identifying, and researching gentrification including qualitative and quantitative methods.

The earliest work on gentrification in Columbus studied German Village and Victorian Village, formerly referred to as the “Near North Side” (Fusch 1980). This work described the German Village Society, founded in 1960, and how it lobbied against urban renewal and for preservation in the neighborhood, which slowed gentrification in the neighborhood. Meanwhile in the Near North Side, there were too many institutional actors for the Victorian Village Commission to fight against, which pushed gentrification and displacement in the neighborhood rather than promoting stability and diversity. This qualitative study described the roles that residents and institutions played in the process of gentrification.

In a mainly quantitative study of the same neighborhoods, Mergler (1984) studied gentrification as a contagion effect within Columbus. Mergler found that German Village and Italian Village experienced gentrification via increases in property values, higher education, white collar workers, per capita income, and younger residents. Additionally, Mergler noted the importance of the German Village Commission as a neighborhood regime and the role private and public investment played in gentrifying the neighborhoods. Likewise, these commissions have been instrumental in preventing the construction of homeless shelters across the city (Mair 1986; McNee and Pojani 2022).

Short North, on the other hand, has many similarities to Franklinton. As outlined by Hansan (2005), Short North was full of artists, music, and had become somewhat of a

cultural district in Columbus. However, there was an era when most people avoided High Street in the Short North because of its association with crime, low-income families, and abandoned buildings. Using Census Data, Hansan told the story of the Short North, from its prosperity before World War II, its demise due to suburbanization and white flight, and its influx of artists, and finally the migration of middle-class residents. Hansan described the gentrification of the neighborhood as an organic process without much government involvement, driven primarily by individuals, yet this rationale excludes the role of government and private institutions (Immergluck 2022; Logan and Molotch 1987). Today, Short North would be practically unrecognizable compared to 2005, with many decisionmakers and members of the political economy playing a pivotal role.

Unlike the other neighborhoods studied in Columbus, Old Towne East is a predominantly a black neighborhood. It was the focus of a documentary, *Flag Wars*, (Bryant 2005) that highlighted the plight of lower-income Black residents in their ability to remain in their homes. Many new white residents, many of whom were LGBTQ, invested in homes, created their own civic associations, and used city code enforcement to push their black neighbors away. The documentary highlights the complex interplay and tensions between race, class, power, and capitalist agency in gentrification (Rucks-Ahidiana 2021, 2022).

Although there has been notable research on the gentrification of various neighborhoods in Columbus, the research that most closely aligns with the questions I seek to answer comes from Webb (2013). Webb sought to study qualitatively how different models of urban governance could explain the gentrification of Weinland Park,

King-Lincoln, and Old Towne East, all of which are predominantly black neighborhoods. Using interviews, Webb found that neighborhood regimes and institutional actors played a significant role in how each neighborhood gentrified—or revitalized depending on the definition of gentrification.

Within Franklinton itself, there have been several research studies on gentrification, specifically on the role of the arts. Sweeney (2014), through quantitative analysis and interviews, argued that Franklinton's art scene and development is trying to be intentional with its growth to avoid displacement, like in the case of the Short North neighborhood. Like the Short North, Franklinton's growth can be tied to its arts scene, yet Sweeney argued that arts alone cannot be blamed for gentrification since private interests and developers that seek to maximize land value and profit are what ultimately pushes people out. Meanwhile, Carlsten (2019) investigated the role of language in the gentrification of Franklinton, finding that the language utilized by city planning documents and articles on Franklinton downplay the displacement and gentrification of the neighborhood. This previous research suggests that capitalist, colonialist, and market-driven perspectives on development in Franklinton are rampant and treated as normal development processes. However, most of the research on gentrification in Franklinton (and Columbus) does not examine the role of the city and larger economic interests and their role in development and gentrification. They do not critique the idea that gentrification is a natural process. In telling the story of Franklinton, it is important to examine the local neighborhood and city context for which institutions create an environment for development and gentrification.

Current Study

The study of the development of cities and neighborhoods can be incredibly complex, often based on a local economy, history, government coalitions, the housing market, economic change, and global markets. The current study builds off the previous work on gentrification both within and outside of Columbus, providing a new context and lens to understand how gentrification can occur in a neighborhood, the political economy behind it, the pressures on such neighborhoods, and why local context still matters in gentrification research. Since gentrification is on a neighborhood-level basis, it is useful to study political dynamics to understand how these power structures create gentrification. To study these local dynamics and political economy of gentrification, I present a case study of the Franklinton neighborhood of Columbus, Ohio using interviews and ethnography. Furthermore, the current study conducts in-depth research on powerful groups and stakeholders, originating from within and outside of Franklinton. To study the political economy of gentrification the current study asks: 1) What is the power structure of the political economy of development in Franklinton and Columbus? and 2) What role does this power structure play in the changes that Franklinton has experienced?

Methods

Interviews

Data collection took place between August 2023 through March 2024, mainly in the form of in-depth, semi-structured interviews. Interviews were conducted with the members of the political economy and neighborhood/urban regime of Columbus and

Franklinton (N=33). Logan and Molotch (1987) argued that members of the political economy of place and growth machine include developers, local politicians, arts organizations, universities, real estate financiers, and others that serve to benefit from maximizing the profit from land. However, Stone (1989) argued that other groups also play a role in decision making surrounding how a city develops, including neighborhood organizations, businesses, and public actors. As such, I chose to include multiple groups to paint a larger picture to describe the political economy of place within Franklinton and to gauge the degree to which development occurred in a top-down manner or not.

All of the participants were involved in or affected by development within the Franklinton neighborhood in some shape or form. Participants were identified through attending public neighborhood meetings, reading news articles, researching city websites and planning documents, and through personal recommendations from other participants. To reach a diverse sample, I utilized purposive sampling techniques to identify information-rich participants that were knowledgeable about city development and neighborhood change and to decide when saturation was reached (Kemper 2003). While I originally set a goal of 20 interviews of people in the political economy, I continued collecting data after that threshold because these various groups who played a role in the development of Franklinton, adding richness, diversity, and depth to the sample of participants. Furthermore, consistent with Kemper (2003), the goal of the study was to collect meaningful content and answers rather than to achieve a specific number of interviews (Hennink and Kaiser 2022; Saunders et al. 2018).

To recruit participants, I approached them at public meetings, emailed them, posted on social media groups, and posted flyers around the neighborhood at bus stops, coffee shops, and on telephone poles. Respondents most often reached via email. As an incentive, participants were offered a \$20 gift card, but many turned down the gift card, especially government officials. To gain entrée with the members of the political economy, I leveraged my education at Ohio State and my connections from other interviews that I conducted, as many interviewees attended or knew someone that attended Ohio State at one point in time. To my surprise, I was met with little skepticism, and I was frequently left shocked with how open and willing people were to meet and talk with me. Upon agreeing to an interview, participants were asked questions from an IRB-approved interview guide.

The interview guide was constructed based on the reading of city planning documents and articles related to development in Columbus and Franklinton, and attending Area Commission, Development Commission, and City Council meetings. Afterwards, I consulted with several faculty members to help shape the interview guide. It asked questions related to a participant's background and involvement in Franklinton, their general opinions on Franklinton, incentives and challenges to development, logic and rationale behind development, interactions with different political economy groups, concerns about displacement, and expectations for the future of the neighborhood (Appendix A). Frequently, participants were given follow-up and guiding questions based on their responses, and conversations often drifted towards discussions of participants' lives, including many that were also residents of Franklinton. During the interview, I took

detailed notes about important topics, quotes, and emotional displays from the participants.

Interviews typically lasted between 60 and 90 minutes, but they went as long as 3 hours. Interviews were conducted either in-person, over zoom, or over the phone, with the majority occurring in-person at libraries, coffee shops, office spaces, and participants' homes. Upon completion of the interviews, participants were asked to complete a brief demographic survey that included questions on race, age, gender, sexuality, education, and information about their position and tenure at an organization.

Out of the total sample of 33 participants, there were: 7 developers, 7 government officials, 7 civic association members, 6 community organizations/businesses, 2 educators, 2 real estate brokers, 1 reporter, and 1 urban planner. (Table 10) The developer group included private for-profit developers (3); private non-profit developers (2); and public non-profit developers (2), with several that embodied multiple categories. The government official group included agencies from the city and county level involved in housing, development, and zoning. The community organizations and businesses included health and housing agencies, private businesses, and an arts agency. Table 11 describes the demographics of the participants interviewed. Racially, the interviews were rather homogeneous, with only one Black person and one Latino person and the other 31 interviews were with Non-Hispanic White persons. Being a predominately White neighborhood, this was not surprising; however, it is a limitation of the data. In terms of gender, the political economy group included 18 men and 15 women, suggesting a fair

balance. Broken down by education, 30 participants held a Bachelor's degree or more, 1 attended Some College or held an Associate's, and 2 held a High School Diploma/GED.

To accurately capture the information, each interview was audio recorded. Then, it was transcribed and checked for errors by four undergraduate research assistants and the author. Afterwards, the identities of the participants were anonymized, as were their transcriptions, and they were given pseudonyms. Participants were ensured that interviews would be completely confidential in order to receive honest answers and to avoid repercussion from anything that they might have said during the interview. Then, transcriptions were downloaded as word documents and uploaded to NVivo. To further understand how governmental decisions surrounding development occur, I attended public governmental and civic association meetings that make decisions on development and read over government documents.

Job and/or Sector	N
Developer	7
Government Official	7
Civic Association	7
Reporter	1
Community Organization/Business	6
Education	2
Real Estate	2
Planner	1

Table 10. Sectors/Job Descriptions of the Political Economy

Characteristic	N
White	31
Black	2
Latino/a	2
Men	18
Women	15
College or More	30
Some College	1
HS or GED	2
LGBTQIA	2

Table 11. Demographics of the Political Economy

Ethnography and Archival Research

I attended various government meetings throughout the City of Columbus, including the Franklinton Area Commission, Columbus Downtown Development Corporation, the Columbus City Council, East Franklinton Review Board, and city-wide ZoneIn/Rezoning Initiatives. I attended these meetings in-person and virtually leading to approximately 20 hours of ethnography of these meetings and 10 of these meetings in addition to countless hours spent in the neighborhood itself. These meetings provided key information about the government decisions and how they are made. Similarly to the interviews, I anonymized and took notes during these meetings. Field notes were later uploaded and coded in NVivo.

Furthermore, I read reviewed historical city-planning documents dating back to 2000 to further understand the role that city planning has played in developing Franklinton. These documents were publicly available on the City of Columbus' website

through various departments, including Zoning, Development, Housing and Planning. I read over these documents, took notes, and utilized this information to put the development of Franklinton in context of larger city-wide planning initiatives.

Analysis

After transcription and writing field notes, I utilized two rounds of NVivo coding to analyze interviews and field notes using grounded theoretical coding (Charmaz 2014; Glaser and Strauss 1967). The coding process began with an initial read-through of each interview and field notes. Afterwards, I utilized open coding, carefully reading each interview and field note to identify broad themes and codes. Afterwards, I read through again, with an eye for previously identified to determine subcodes. Furthermore, being that qualitative data analysis is an iterative process, in which one moves back and forth from research questions to raw data to ensure the inductively derived codes are grounded in theoretical framing (Lareau 2021). This inductive process allowed for critical themes and patterns to arise, enabled flexibility with new themes as they emerged throughout the interviews, and provided much needed nuance within the complex and often contradictory statements made by participants (Morse 2015; Patton 1999). From these codes, several broad trends emerged: The Columbus Way, Politics of Development, Logic and Rationale for Development, and a New City-Wide Political Economy of Development.

Results

The Columbus Way: A Model of City-Wide Urban Governance

Throughout interviews, participants referred to “The Columbus Way,” a term altogether unfamiliar to me prior to beginning the project. The original term came about as a result of a *Columbus Dispatch* article in 2012, but later gained popularity over the past decade after its use in a Harvard Business Journal Report (Fischer 2012; Rivkin 2015). The Columbus Way can be defined as the collaboration of civic, government, business, and community organizers to achieve common goals. Supposedly, these sectors put their selfish interests aside for the community good (Yost 2014). Part of the collaboration includes the Columbus Partnership, a non-profit organization that includes the heads of various successful businesses, that achieves policy goals and encourages economic development within Central Ohio. Beau, an affordable housing advocate, discussed how the Columbus Way has played a role in development with a less-polished version of its effects throughout the city:

There's a paragraph in [The Harvard Review Article] that says in [Elite Businessman 1's] meeting with [Elite Businessman 2]... ‘How would you like to decide on who was mayor and where the roads are built in Columbus?’...And that's why we as activists and others say, ‘This is the Columbus Way.’ This is how things are done is the Columbus Way—good or bad. And this just tells you that they make the decisions on who's mayor, who's elected office basically, and how, why we decide on how things are done. And you know, if you look at the 80 members of the Columbus Partnership, they're all the big corporations and a lot of the developers. (Beau, Affordable Housing Advocate)

Beau's understanding of the Columbus Way is that private sector held substantially more power in Columbus' than in other cities, for they chose the politicians and what infrastructure gets built. While this line of business-driven development is consistent with

other growth machine theorizations of neoliberal urban governance, Columbus stands out. Scholars have noted that within Columbus, government officials lean into the Columbus Way and that private interests play an outsized role compared to other similar cities, including deciding on the mayor, neighborhood revitalization, moving the interstate, developing their own suburbs, and steering public money towards private projects (Bush 2024b; Cox 2020). This indicates a heavy role of the political economy in driving development (Logan and Molotch 1987). Certainly, this is subjective, but respondents believed in its importance, albeit with some contestation.

However, the Columbus Way has changed over time, as it used to be dominated by a select few corporate elites. As these corporate titans aged, the sway the Columbus Partnership has changed over time, as described by Paul, a government official:

I think we rely on that tagline a little too much. I do think at a time, particularly when I started public service, the public and private sectors worked collaboratively to find solutions. I think that has shifted away, and now the private is dictating them a little bit more than the public. Part of that is really lost our corporate titans and [Executive Businessman 2]. Yes, [they're] still around, but not as visible and doesn't have a good conduit to kind of partner with. So, we have the Columbus Partnership playing an important role. I couldn't tell you who the leaders of the Columbus partnership are anymore, and I'm pretty plugged in. I'm not used to it. They just don't have that vision because I don't think they're from here, like [Executive Businessman] is. And so you know, take the Peninsula, that is 100% a [Executive Businessman 1]. This is what I think this could become and [Executive Businessman 2] signed off on it back in the day with the tradeoff for the [Executive Businessman 2] to get the Arena District and kinda develop some of that out. I just don't see that leadership [anymore]. So, while we continue to hear a Columbus Way, I don't think it's being executed the way it used to be. Again, I think we're missing that corporate leadership kind of the titans. Maybe they had too much influence and power, but they also were executing a vision. You still have corporate leaders, but I'm not sure what vision they're executing. (Paul, Government Official)

As a government official, he had a front-row seat to seeing these actions and policy decisions in real-time. Paul viewed the Columbus Way as a collaborative process that pushed for mutually beneficial change. However, Paul showed concern about the way the private sector has begun to dictate more power in Columbus, showcasing how the elites essentially created their own suburbs and neighborhoods and held significant power in Columbus' government. Even as the power has become more diffused within the private sector, he still believed that power was accumulating within it.

While the Columbus Way appears unique to some, Cameron, a journalist, said that the Columbus Way and development is not really all that different from other cities and what it capable of accomplishing:

They see what Columbus is doing as this sort of amazing, unique thing where the public sector is working with the private sector and it's like unique, and I think that they overstate how unique Columbus is... I think there are certain things that Columbus has done, like removing the dam downtown and creating the green space downtown. That's a pretty cool project that happened by you know, public and private interests kind of getting together...but on the other hand, it's not like they've, you know, solved poverty. You know, they haven't, they haven't figured out how to get on top, you know, they haven't done anything that is really like, sort of unique in the country when it comes to how we do development.
(Cameron, Journalist, 2023)

Altogether, the Columbus Way appeared to play a role in how members of the political economy viewed the ways development was pursued within Columbus, largely coming from developers and private interest, and occurring in a top-down fashion, like growth machine (Logan and Molotch 1987). However, evidence pointed towards the Columbus Way being larger and more complex than local coalitions working together to develop the city. To better understand the Columbus Way, we must move beyond the growth machine model. In the Columbus Way, private interests play an outsized role

compared to government and civil sectors, as highlighted by New Urban Politics (1991, 2020). This neo-Marxist theory describes this phenomenon effectively, showing how the Columbus Way and private interest, are reshaping Columbus under neoliberalist via access to global capital. Additionally, NUP recognizes global economic pressures that impact local coalitions. This moves beyond the simple idea of local actors and growth coalitions to the implication of global economic forces affecting the local neighborhood context.

Certainly, private interests have historically played a role in developing Columbus, like many other cities. However, under new global economic trends, these developers derive their wealth from a global scale, and use global capital to drive development in Columbus, which is better understood by New Urban Politics. This has shaped neighborhoods and development across Franklinton and Central Ohio. Within Franklinton itself, this has been shown by the development of private neighborhoods by billionaires and global corporations, the new presence of global consulting firms in Franklinton, and the use of global capital to extract resources, land, and rent. Nevertheless, local coalitions continue to matter, especially when examining the historical context of a neighborhood like Franklinton.

Urban Governance, Political Economy, and Gentrification

According to previous gentrification research in Columbus' other neighborhoods, neighborhood regimes and other actors were pivotal in developing neighborhoods (Fusch 1980; Webb 2013). To better understand this, one must understand the trajectory of Franklinton. Throughout Franklinton's history, it has experienced persistent flooding,

most recently in 1959. In 1983, the Federal Emergency Management Agency (FEMA) declared Franklinton a flood plain, thus largely prohibiting new development and rehabilitation of existing buildings in the neighborhood. This federal government decision set Franklinton on a downward trajectory, leading to a massive population and economic decline. This was part of the neighborhood disinvestment that would set the stage for its later gentrification (Moskowitz 2018). However, in the 1990s, city officials and the Army Corps of Engineers decided to build the Franklinton Flood Wall, through the Columbus Way, which was completed in 2004. These sorts of developments that have been termed “green gentrification”, which make way for the sustainable and creative classes (Gould and Lewis 2018). However, development did not instantly rush into the neighborhood after the flood wall was built, as some expected. Lawrence, a member of a neighborhood organization, described this:

The flood wall got done in '03. Around '05/'06, I'm like where is all this development that was gonna come rushing across the river? It wasn't happening. Best I could tell people still didn't think the neighborhood was safe enough to develop. The Bottoms wasn't... you know was scaring people. They nobody would? I mean, we had people sitting on large pieces of land and not moving... people sitting on small pieces of land and not moving, and I think we are campaign to change the story turned the tide. (Lawrence, Neighborhood Organization)

Starting with smaller pieces of land Lawrence's organization built affordable homes and apartments, and it continues to do so. To change the neighborhood though, Lawrence needed to change the narrative around Franklinton as a low-income, downtrodden area, but he also needed support from more powerful actors, including the city and Mayor Coleman. Lawrence described his meeting with Mayor Coleman and introducing the idea of creating an arts district for Franklinton:

My point to the mayor that day was I brought the map [of vacant land] and I'm like, look, look at these huge pieces. What if this guy talked to this guy to this guy to this guy? What if you brought them all in here together and said, 'Hey everybody, let's work together and make something new, a new brand of neighborhood. An arts district that can have housing and commercial, retail, and jobs. We can work on economic development and community engagement. We can do all this stuff together because we control everything, and I'm the mayor and I can help.'" And so I pitched that at him, and he loved ran with it. (Lawrence, Neighborhood Organization)

Though it took some convincing, Lawrence, a notable person involved in the development of Franklinton, emphasized the role that the mayor could play in the gentrification of Franklinton. The Franklinton Arts District was created in 2008, and then pieces began to fall into place. Within a couple years, the arts district drew attention of private developers, like Urban Smart Growth, the developers behind the massive 400 W. Rich arts studios created in 2011. Once the art space took off, the rest of East Franklinton began to also, attracting more attention from the mayor and the city to develop the area and demolish several public housing complexes, including Riverside-Bradley, Sunshine Terrace, and Sunshine Annex, as described by Rick, a public, non-profit developer remembered this:

At some point, they built a flood wall around there, and so then all of a sudden...we start getting calls left and right. And so we did a [Request for Proposal] RFP for co-developer for the site, and the mayor was involved. This is Mayor Coleman was involved and he's basically like "You're redeveloping this. We're gonna do it, blah, blah. I'm going to give you money, you're going to keep some of the units as affordable, whatever." (Rick, Housing Developer)

Since the construction of the flood wall, many have treated the neighborhood as a blank slate ripe for development and change, despite the demolition of homes and projects, including the city which has published various plans for the neighborhood, including the

Franklinton Target Area Plan, West Franklinton Plan, East Franklinton Creative Community District Plan, and various other plans for the Scioto Peninsula, which is technically a part of Downtown Columbus. These plans suggested attracting more of the creative community to bring about gentrification but that the “gentrification should be gentle [to accomplish this] the colonizing settlers convert old, underutilized industrial structures into live/work spaces” (City of Columbus 2012:14). The goal was to establish a creative arts community and maintain affordability for artists and residents alike. However, the plans lacked any real substance to maintaining the affordability and simply stated that private interests should try not to “lose sight of the creative worker.” As shown, the city took a strong interest in the neighborhood, but these plans have often been shortsighted and somewhat ignorant to how private interests continue to seek capital at the expense of residents.

As such, since Franklinton has continued to garner more attention, these civic organizations that pushed for “humane development,” as described by Lawrence, have been pushed aside as powerful developers entered the neighborhood. These developers now have been given an outsized role in how Franklinton develops—probably best illustrated by Lawrence:

[The] flood of development is coming” ... “[the city]...they're basically riding in the hip of the developers. The city staff used to have some fucking backbone. They used to have balls and ideas. Now they're just like, you know, Thrive (a developer) wants, more like better sidewalks around Souder Avenue. They'll find a way to make to Thrive happy. (Lawrence, Civic Sector).

Overall, evidence suggests that the development of Franklinton in the late-2000s and 2010s occurred through a neighborhood regime, a largely information coalition of

different sectors, but it has transitioned towards being more top-down from the state and private interests under New Urban Politics and the Columbus Way. Notably, there have been several important choices taken by various state actors, private developers, and civic sector groups that have pushed these changes.

As discussed earlier, The Columbus Way, which was initially more about local growth coalitions, has become more about appeasing private interests, which are increasingly governed by global capital and pressures, removing the importance of neighborhood and civic concerns. What began as a neighborhood regime of development is becoming increasingly top-down and complex, and NUP allows us to understand these changes.

Tax abatements

One of the policies that government officials utilized that contributes to gentrification is tax abatements. Columbus has long used property tax abatements to “foster private sector investment to build mixed income neighborhoods”, called community reinvestment areas (CRAs), with strong skepticism and critiques from other scholars (Reece and Abou-Ghalioum 2023). The rationale idea behind these tax abatements is to incentivize developers to build in neighborhoods they might not otherwise, make developing easier, and drive down rents. The logic behind this is that when property owners receive these tax abatements, they may keep rents low, yet there is little evidence this is the case.

Approved and controlled by the Columbus City Council, these 15-year, 100% property tax abatements are incredibly generous and include minimal requirements for

affordable units (Weiker 2023a). Initially, these tax abatements were focused on economically depressed areas like Franklinton and Linden, and had no strings attached for developers to incentivize development. In a 2018 planning document, the City of Columbus identified Franklinton as “Ready for Opportunity” (City of Columbus 2018). This “opportunity” allowed developers to build luxury apartments and investment companies to flip homes with get a 15-year, 100% tax abatements, meanwhile impoverished residents have been left to deal with increases in their property taxes. As of December 2023, these abatements expanded to the entire city, but there are some requirements for affordable units. Still, a lot of damage has already been done. Nevertheless, this process puts more of the burden of property tax on residents rather than developers, taking money away from public schools, and further contributing to displacement of residents on fixed and low incomes.

For the most part, government officials and developers alike supported these policies (Weiker 2023a, 2023b, 2024). Erica, a government official, was quick to demonstrate the need to use and expand tax abatements throughout the city: “We know that this is the way that more creative, dense, affordable projects get done... We have to turn this tool on full blast, or we are going to be under building again at the most critical moment of our trajectory.” Similarly, a private developer discussed how the tax abatements made certain projects possible:

So [Franklinton] is in a less restrictive CRA so Community Reinvestment Area, which has been really like make or break for our projects and probably for others as well. So that's been huge for us. We've done studies where, ‘Okay, let's build this exact same product in a more restrictive CRA,’ and we can't make it work. (Samantha, Private Developer)

Both government officials and developers relied on similar logics for the use of tax abatements in creating housing. These abatements have been controversial because while property owners have had their property taxes increase, developers have received and continue received these massive breaks. Some have showed their skepticism of the real need behind these tax breaks. In Franklinton specifically, Paul, a government official was skeptical that of the supposed need of abatements to complete a project: “Would Gravity 2 have been built as fast? Maybe not, but Gravity was gonna happen one way or the other. Maybe it wouldn't have been Gravity. You could have found a different developer. But as the city had the tract of land and a great location to get back in Franklinton.”

Regardless of the skepticism of tax abatements, Paul described how tax abatements, despite their controversy, were certainly a part of the city's pro-development policy... “So, I do think we have a tax abatement problem, but it remains the number one economic tool. It's the one everyone asks for, and we're competing with other parts of our region that if you don't offer it, people say they'll go somewhere else.” This quote exemplifies NUP since governments often adopt these kinds of neoliberal strategies, via the use of tax abatements, to compete with other cities in attracting global capital. As Ohio's only growing city, Columbus will likely continue this path.

During community meetings, residents have raised concerns about the increase in their property taxes, some being raised 200% in Franklinton (Meibers 2023). Thus, these tax abatements affect the property taxes of homeowners. Paul continued saying “If you hear an abatement and say you know, ‘You actually don't have to pay your full pie [to a developer].’ That gets passed off to everyone else to make up for that piece... It's

probably pennies. But it's money.” To those on fixed income, even small amounts matter. These abatements are supposed to be there to help the community, but they end up making the ability to stay in their homes more difficult. While new luxury developments and renovations get tax breaks, long-time residents receive no rental support nor any help with rising property taxes. At the same time, Columbus is dealing with its highest rate of eviction in over 20 years (WOSU 2024). Further, these choices pull more money away from the underperforming public school system (Reece and Abou-Ghalioum 2023). While this policy requires no initial capital to invest from the city, which could be seen as a benefit, this is ultimately a misplaced policy that puts money in the pockets of developers instead of struggling residents. Instead, capital continues to usurp people in Columbus in the name of growth.

Logics and Rationale for Development

To understand the rationale for development and tax abatements, developers and government officials alike employed neoliberal and free-market logics and supply-side arguments for housing (Wyly 2022). With the city of Columbus under a housing shortage, some government officials and developers suggested the free-market policies should be adopted to speed up development, which would lessen the supply-demand issue (Weiker 2023a). These policies include reforming the zoning code and eliminating the need for developers to receive community feedback and area commission approval to develop.

They suggest that these policies would ultimately create more housing, thus driving down rents. Mark, a developer, said “I hate saying it this way...supply is going to

bring down rents. Yeah, not the opposite way. Like, it's just a fact. It's supply and demand 101.” This was in line with what Erica said earlier: “We have to turn this tool on full blast, or we are going to be under building again at the most critical moment of our trajectory,” suggesting that building alone could drive down rents. During an Area Commission meeting, Erica used this logic by drawing parallels with Columbus and Austin, implying that being developer-friendly like Austin could help Columbus avoid skyrocketing housing costs. However, these supply-side arguments were not without skepticism. For instance, Beau, a politician in Columbus pushed back on this idea:

I hear the supply and demand. I understand supply and demand needed, but how much density should be permitted and where? That's the only issue I have with density... When is that supply gonna meet demand? 5-10 years from now, at least. And what are you going to do in the meantime? So, every time you build market rate housing, in a neighborhood– like let's say Bronzeville or Franklinton– nearby apartment units that are affordable, are going to start charging higher rents to those people that have been able to live there. So now you're removing affordable housing units from people and so and that's one of the problems is every time you build market rate in a certain gentrifying neighborhood, other renters are going to jack up their price. They know it's desirable. They know they can get it. (Beau, Politician)

Beau held skepticism of supply-side arguments because he believed introducing new housing means that rents will increase for others. Certainly, Columbus is in a housing crunch, but will building anything and everything solve this problem? Previous research is mixed on how building affects rents, and the local context appears to matter drastically in understanding housing costs (Chapple et al. 2023; Damiano and Frenier 2020; Hepburn et al. 2024). Previous notable gentrification scholars have voiced similar concerns about simply building anything and everything, stating that this approach, Yes In My Backyard (YIMBY), is the new frontier of gentrification (Wyly 2022). These

concerns arise from the fact that supply-side arguments for housing rely on trickle-down and filtering theory.

While city officials might be concerned about affordable housing in the city, there was a notable emphasis on downplaying displacement concerns and to turn to other aspects of the housing crisis, as suggested by Erica, a government official: “Choice is what the cure is for exploitation. Choice is the cure to bringing sure that we have opportunities for everyone, right? That is what we want to do, and so I think we get lost sometimes in the conversation of displacement, but what I don't want is I don't want you to lack choice.” While new development might create displacement, Erica believes that building and developing will ultimately create choice in neighborhoods by creating mixed-income neighborhoods. After talking to Erica, she emailed me a recent prominent article that found how gentrification can actually decrease eviction rates (Hepburn et al. 2024). However, this work not without its skeptics as well, for other research has found alternative results (Chum 2015).

Again, the government’s subservience to private interests and capital, and the developers’ insistence on this, can be understood through the Columbus Way and NUP. During these interviews, there was no room to question the economics behind development in Columbus. These development policies and their rationale were treated as fact despite their questionable theoretical underpinnings and evidence. Only Beau, an affordable housing advocate, was willing to question it, and he, along with other community advocates, has a history of being ignored and ostracized. The movement towards minimizing community voice has grown stronger in recent years.

Towards a New Political Economy of Development and Urban Governance in Columbus

Throughout interviews, respondents also discussed the citywide rezoning initiative. In 2021, the City of Columbus hired a third-party to conduct a zoning review. This document highlighted many reasons why housing in Columbus is becoming so unaffordable, the challenges associated with the current zoning code and provided recommendations. The report covered many policies, including parking, transit, restrictive zoning, and redlining. Notably, “the code lacks requirements or incentives for affordable housing, such as inclusionary housing requirements, community benefit programs, or density bonuses” (Lisa Wise Consulting, Inc. 2021: 22). The Central Ohio Regional Housing Strategy highlighted similar findings (Mid-Ohio Regional Planning Commission 2020).

Starting in 2023, the City of Columbus began considering updates to its zoning code, dubbed the ZoneIn Initiative. Many changes to the zoning code included opening up development for denser buildings by eliminating exclusionary zoning along certain corridors, eliminating and decreasing many parking requirements for new developments, and allowing for Bus Rapid Transit (BRT) (Bush 2023; City of Columbus 2023). As such, the City of Columbus is moving towards a new political restructuring regarding development, which could drastically change the built landscape of the city and how land use is governed for better and for worse.

Since the zoning code has not been updated in more than 70 years, many variances are needed when one wants to develop land. When a variance is needed in the zoning code, developers must approach the Area Commissions, made up of groups of

residents of a neighborhood, to seek approval for variances to the zoning code, including asking for fewer parking spaces, bypassing height requirements, and shrinking setbacks. It is the goal of Area Commission meetings that developers and Area Commissioners to “facilitate communication, understanding, and cooperation between neighborhood groups, city officials and developers” (Clintonville Area Commission 2016). Having attended many of these area commission meetings, they are often uneventful but serve as an important soundboard for the community and a place to discuss changes to the neighborhood and the built environment. However, they can also serve as significant barriers to development, costing time and money.

The zoning updates threaten the way that housing and community involvement play a role in development in Columbus by taking away some of the power that Area Commissioners have in working with developers. Now, the zoning code will be streamlined to remove some of the power that Area Commissions have to compromise with developers, approve variances to zoning code, and provide meaningful community feedback. While this will certainly make development more cost-effective and less time-consuming, the new zoning code removes community input. Thus, the political economy of development is shifting more towards a top-down process, pushed largely by public and private sector interests.

Notably, Area Commissions did not fit into the cooperative and collaborative spirit of the Columbus Way, instead often working against developers or requiring changes to their development plans before receiving approval. In interviews and throughout ethnography, developers emphasized their frustration with Area Commissions

for making them jump through hoops, often times nonsensically and without reason by bouncing between committees and red tape:

There's the area commission, and there's a zoning committee within that commission, and the zoning committee will vote no. And then we've gone to the full commission, and they vote yes. So, you've got the zoning chair saying no, but their full commission said yes. And that zoning chair has been the zoning chair for 40 years....We can, we can get approved but at the local level, the local commission level folks have wanted us to make sure the building isn't too high or there's a step-down off the main road, which limits the amount of units we can build. You know, I think we've had conversations about...well do we just do we fight to we can build these 14 more units or 20 more units? Or do we just do what the commission wants us to do? So, it kind of just depends on the situation. But I think now knowing the ZoneIn initiatives gives you that power to say, "Look, this is what's coming. We're not going to build a three-story building. We're going to build a four or five-story building along this corridor because this gives another third party saying that this is okay." (Brittany, Developer)

In many cases, the tensions between these groups were quite palpable. Brittany viewed area commissions as making development time-consuming and ultimately more expensive. She also voiced her support and excitement for the ZoneIn initiative in changing these dynamics in favor of developers. The Zoning Code Review supports her perspective, stating "the result is a time consuming, unpredictable, subjective, expensive, and inequitable process that can be dominated by personal preference rather than objective findings of fact" (Lisa Wise Consulting, Inc. 2021: 38).

However, area commissioners felt differently, citing their position as necessary for providing community feedback and community voice. They saw themselves as advocates for their neighborhoods and standing in the way of private interests operating without oversight. Within Franklinton itself, the Franklinton Area Commission already lost its ability to voice concerns over what occurs within East Franklinton, with the

creation of the East Franklinton Review Board as a part of the Creative Community Plan of 2014 (City of Columbus 2012), as described by J, a civic official:

Now that the flood issues are gone, they cut out into our jurisdiction essentially. Technically, I still get all the demo orders for anywhere in East Franklinton but it's an FYI, you know? Any power I had there, any power that the area commission has, is nonexistent. (J, Civic Official)

By removing Area Commissions from the political economy of development with new zoning regulations, development becomes much easier and does not require any meaningful community input, suggesting that these do not matter to the city. However, city officials have recognized that this perception exists. In an effort to get ahead of this, the city used public dollars to hire a public relations firm to give the impression that the zoning changes were the result of a grassroots movement (Bush 2024a). In reality, the rezoning initiative is another instance of top-down development from the city, like within Franklinton, which operates under the Columbus Way.

Regardless of how different sectors viewed these zoning changes and the altering of urban governance, it appears they all view them as inevitable and arriving quickly. During the summer of 2024, the Columbus City Council approved the new code and implemented it along five major corridors, with more to come, putting more power in the hands of developers and private interests via the Columbus Way (Behrens 2024; City of Columbus 2023). Residents and Area Commissions will have no power to prevent potentially inadequate housing developments.

While these zoning changes could eliminate barriers to development, it may not necessarily bring down rents, and the city may not be equipped to handle the fallout. The

results from these changes remain to be seen, as this policy was just enacted. As such, future research is needed to examine their impacts. Nevertheless, development in Franklinton and Columbus will continue to be dominated by the private interests and the Columbus Way, which can best be understood by NUP.

Conclusion

This work illustrates the inherent tension within the political decisions central to urban life, development, and gentrification and aims to shed light on the use of state-sponsored, neoliberal gentrification policies; the commodification of housing; and the right to the city (Harvey 1973; Pattillo 2013). Specifically, the study explores the impact of the different sectors of the political economy on the urban governance of Columbus and its impact on Franklinton's gentrification. I present several important themes that further our understanding of the impact of the political economy on gentrification.

First, through interviews and ethnographic research, respondents and members of the political economy frequently cited the "Columbus Way" as a key principle guiding development in the city. While some questioned how unique this approach was, given the widespread influence of neoliberal urban governance across the U.S., most political economy members were familiar with the term and believed its influence was particularly strong in Columbus (Harvey and Chatterjee 1974; Lipman 2011; Logan and Molotch 1987; Stone 1989). To fully grasp the Columbus Way, it is necessary to move beyond the growth machine model (Logan and Molotch 1987). Instead, private interests, rather than governmental or civil sectors, play an increasingly dominant role—something better explained by Cox's New Urban Politics (1991, 2020). This neo-Marxist theory captures

how the Columbus Way, driven by private interests, is reshaping the city under neoliberal forces. Rather than focusing solely on local growth coalitions, this approach emphasizes how global economic trends impact local development. For example, wealthy local developers have historically shaped Columbus, as in many cities. However, under new global economic conditions, these developers now draw their wealth from a global scale, leveraging global capital to drive local development. New Urban Politics provides a framework for understanding this shift, which has dramatically impacted neighborhoods like Franklinton throughout Central Ohio. Billionaires and global corporations now develop private neighborhoods, global consulting firms are increasingly visible in Franklinton, and global capital is being used to extract resources and land from the inner city.

Secondly, I demonstrate how a neighborhood regime initially spurred reinvestment in Franklinton. Initially, disinvestment became rampant in the neighborhood due to flooding and the designation of being a flood plain, which set the stage for its later gentrification (Moskowitz 2018). After the construction of the flood wall, arts and neighborhood organizations began investing in the neighborhood again, with some small success. However, once powerful city and private interests, including the Mayor Coleman, were convinced by Lawrence's organization to assist in development, Franklinton truly took off. The mayor convinced other organizations and private interests to invest, and he made important decisions, including selling off public housing developments and the plan to make Franklinton an Arts District. At this point, local organizations have little say in the development of the neighborhood, with the city

putting more power in the hands of developers. Policies that put greater power in the hands of developers included tax abatements and CRAs, which illustrate how public funds are mobilized to stimulate development at the expense of the taxpayer and public schools in neighborhoods like Franklinton (Reece and Abou-Ghalioum 2023). This pattern exemplifies how private interests use public resources to further their goals and profits.

Third, I identify how government officials and private developers alike justify these decisions. To do so, they employ neoliberal and free-market logics. They suggested that simply building more housing, any housing, would be the best policy to drive down rents. They also claimed that governments should subsidize this development, even for for-profit developers. Meanwhile, they also claimed that displacement due to gentrification should not be a concern. Cox's *New Urban Politics* explains how developers have employed persuasive arguments, such as supply-and-demand logic and minimizing concerns about displacement, to secure public support for these zoning changes.

Finally, the study revealed how the Columbus Way is influencing the city's new zoning initiative. Soon, it appears that a new political economy of development, will arrive in Columbus, one that puts more power in the hands of developers and less in the hands of elected officials and local residents, through the ZoneIn initiative. Through this initiative, Area Commissions will lose most of their ability to provide community feedback and negotiate with developers. This top-down initiative could alleviate some of the housing crunch due to outdated zoning code, segregation, and exclusionary zoning,

but it certainly could also threaten the affordability of long-time residents of neighborhoods like Franklinton. The results of these policy choices remain to be seen.

Moving forward, we must recognize that the logics and rationale behind these zoning changes and development schemes oversimplifies the complexities of development and the reasonings behind the affordable housing shortage (Gibson 2005). We must reject this rationale and the dichotomy of supply and demand, for building alone will not stop the housing shortage in Columbus (McElroy and Szeto 2018; Wyly 2022). Furthermore, we must acknowledge that simply increasing the supply of housing and improving the neighborhood housing stock will not alleviate the economic pressures and poverty felt by residents, especially if they are low-income renters (Damiano and Frenier 2020). This neoliberal, trickle-down argument and message from the city misses the mark to accomplish real change and may even usher in more gentrification. There needs to be housing rights and protections, which the city of Columbus lacks almost entirely.

This study is not without its limitations. For instance, the sample of the political economy was not diverse, with only two Black and two Latine interviewees, which partially is due to the lack of diversity of the neighborhood and from members of the political economy. Additionally, the sample only came from people within the city of Columbus. With the growing accumulation of capital, developers and other private interests outside the city could be playing a role in development, but these groups are innumerable. Lastly, because Franklinton is situated in time and space, the generalizability of this study may be called into question. It is just one neighborhood in Columbus, in one city in Ohio, in one state in the country, and in one year. Thus, what

other neighborhoods in Columbus and other areas experience could be vastly different. However, it serves as a strong case study. Additionally, as Franklinton and Columbus continue to develop and grow, further research should examine the impacts on poverty, residents, housing affordability, and displacement, which I do in a following chapter focusing on the lived experience of these policies and gentrification.

Despite its limitations, the study provides a substantial contribution to the literature, as it answers how modern gentrification takes place. Through interviews and ethnography, this research suggests that we cannot exclusively use one or two of the dominant perspectives surrounding urban governance and gentrification. To tell a full story, we need multiple perspectives. In the case of Franklinton, gentrification occurred through the emergence of a neighborhood regime that shifted into top-down, state-sponsored gentrification. It appears that the model of urban governance within Franklinton, as with Columbus as a whole, is moving towards being top-down, private interest-driven, with support from city officials using public dollars that is justified through neoliberal logics. This is the Columbus Way, and while singular elites may play less of a role than they used to, private interests still dominate the decision-making process of urban governance and will for the foreseeable future, and New Urban Politics offers a worthwhile explanation for these development processes and policies (Cox 1991, 2020). As Central Ohio continues to grow rapidly, New Urban Politics suggests that development pressures will become increasingly global, as evidenced by projects like new data centers and the Intel microchip factory. These global economic demands bring with them more powerful private interests, further accelerating the pace of local

development and worsening the affordable housing crisis and gentrification in neighborhoods like Franklinton.

Chapter 4: The Lived Experience of Gentrification

Abstract

Recent transformations within the Franklinton neighborhood of Columbus, Ohio are consistent with indicators of gentrification of cities across the country. While many news outlets, public figures, and developers, support or criticize these widespread changes to the built environment and social fabric Franklinton, few have examined the quantitative changes to the neighborhood nor the perceptions of neighborhood residents. Through 37 interviews with residents and one year of ethnography, this study seeks to tell the complicated story of Franklinton's gentrification and to prioritize the lived experience of neighborhood residents as they encounter these changes on a daily basis. Residents recount deeply personal and familial histories rooted in the neighborhood. They reflect on the area's history of racial tension and social disorganization, which created conditions ripe for gentrification and hastened its progression (Hwang and Sampson 2014). Additionally, they emphasize the profound impacts of displacement and the loss of place. These findings contribute to the literature on gentrification and race, highlighting the importance of neighborhood context and mixed methods work in studying gentrification (Golio 2024; Zukin 1987). Furthermore, these insights can hopefully equip local community organizations and government officials to be able to interact and serve

Franklinton residents, address neighborhood problems, and inform policy solutions related to gentrification.

Introduction

When people think of gentrification, they imagine trendy coffee shops, renovated buildings, luxury apartments, and the displacement of long-time minority residents by younger, highly educated white residents. However, the reality of gentrification is far more nuanced and varies significantly across different places and times (Brown-Saracino 2017; Finio 2022). Initially conceptualized by Glass (1964) as the invasion of working class neighborhoods by the middle class, the definition has changed over time. It has continued to develop to describe neighborhood changes, including new buildings (Davidson and Lees 2010), displacement in rural areas (Pilgeram 2021), and the inclusion of the creative class (Peck 2005). At its core, though, consistent with Glass (1964), gentrification typically involves the displacement of lower socioeconomic groups by wealthier newcomers (Bhavsar, Kumar, and Richman 2020; Finio 2022; Smith 1987; Zukin 1987).

Franklinton, a neighborhood in Columbus, Ohio and the oldest non-Indigenous settlement in Central Ohio, exemplifies this complexity in gentrification. Its history, marred by natural disasters, government neglect, and persistent poverty, showcases the vast challenges it has experienced. Recently, Franklinton has been known for its growth and burgeoning arts scene, with some claiming that the neighborhood's revitalization and gentrification comes without negatives (Carlsten 2019; The Atlantic 2014). However, as Franklinton continues to grow and change, debates surrounding its changes rage on.

Notably, this gentrification and development is all situated within the context of unfettered capitalism working to maximize exchange value and drive up profits in our cities while local autonomy continues to decline (Cox 1991; Harvey 1973; Wyly 2022). Overall, many people have opinions about Franklinton and gentrification, but they do not necessarily represent the residents of Franklinton itself (Meibers 2021; Tierney 2014; Weiker 2023e; Zachariah et al. 2019).

To tell the stories of the actual residents of Franklinton, both new and long-term, I conducted 37 interviews and one year of ethnography in the Franklinton neighborhood by following in the footsteps of urban scholars before me (DuBois 1899; Freeman 2006). Through interviews, ethnography, and photography, I demonstrate that both new and long-term residents of Franklinton hold differing, sometimes contradictory views on gentrification and the changes in their neighborhood, including whether the changes are beneficial. Secondly, I exhibit that social disorganization is incredibly prevalent in the community, as shown by a distrust in police, fear of crime, and high crime rates. Despite this, there are moments during interviews and ethnography that speak to the kindness of strangers and residents. Finally, I demonstrate why Franklinton might be more susceptible to gentrification, including its lack of social organization and the fact that Franklinton is a predominantly poor, white neighborhood. This may have primed it for gentrification compared to other Columbus neighborhoods that have been the focus of gentrification in years past, including Olde Town East and Weinland Park (Bryant 2005; Meibers 2022).

Literature Review

With gentrification being such a contentious topic, exploring the nuances of the phenomenon are key. While analyzing a secondary dataset is important for telling part of the story of Franklinton, other empirical sources are important to investigate. Rather than rely on secondary data analysis alone, other scholars have used qualitative methods like interviews, ethnography, and photography to understand the phenomenon (Finio 2022).

Interviews

Interviews are a key part of qualitative work, with extensive use in the field of urban sociology. Interviewing is, at its core, listening to participants by remaining flexible and open to exploring new ideas, thus allowing for new knowledge creation (Lareau 2021). Within qualitative gentrification research, interviews are one of the preferred methods of conducting analyses (Finio 2022). In previous gentrification scholarship, interviews have been conducted to examine the nuances of gentrification and how residents perceive and understand the phenomenon, often illuminating the hidden costs that might not show up in quantitative data (Atkinson 2000b).

These interviews describe complex challenges for residents living in gentrifying areas, including resistance to displacement and rent hikes (Newman and Wyly 2006). Furthermore, these interviews contextualize quantitative measurement of gentrification but are not meant to be objective estimates of gentrification or displacement. Interviews display emotion, narrative nuance, and the lived experience that would never truly appear in a dataset, which is why they are so important. While datasets might downplay the scale of gentrification or displacement, the residents that experience these changes are very real

and so are their emotions. Even when displacement does not occur, interviews have highlighted how many long-time residents feel a loss of place (Shaw and Hagemans 2015).

Ethnography

Ethnography is a long-standing tradition in the social sciences, namely for sociology, geography, and anthropology. Dating back to W.E.B DuBois' study of the Seventh Ward in Philadelphia (DuBois 1899), ethnography has been widely used by sociologists. DuBois detailed an understanding of the lived experiences and struggles Black people faced in finding and maintaining employment, their salaries, discrimination, and poor living conditions. No statistical methods alone could capture these experiences in the same way. Due to its rich findings and thick description, some scholars have pushed for the expansion of ethnographic methods, especially in housing research (Franklin 1990). While social surveys and statistical analyses are useful, they lack explanations for the decisions people make, which are often based on where they live. Ethnography captures the imagination and puts our theories into perspective via the lived experience of individuals. Ethnography provides a deep, rich understanding of cultures, institutions, and social practices that would be impossible to understand with quantitative methods alone. It also provides a more holistic view of social practices and phenomenon, power dynamics, emotions, and nuance.

Previous ethnographic research, especially in urban settings highlights this. Consider Pattillo (1999) and Whyte (1993) as examples. Pattillo employed ethnographic methods in a Black middle-class community on the South Side of Chicago in the 1990s.

Many might assume that crime and disorder are rampant in this area. However, it is also expected that a middle-class community would have lower rates of crime and disorder. Through her ethnography, Pattillo revealed that strong social ties, which are common in middle-class communities, may sometimes actually increase crime and disorder, demonstrating the existence of disorder within the order of the middle class. Conversely, Whyte (1993) found the opposite. In his study of a lower-class Italian slum in 1930s Boston, presumed to be entirely disorderly, he discovered strong social ties and order. Even within gangs and clubs, there were established rules and boundaries, forming a subculture of order. In more recent work, Venkatesh (2002) demonstrated the social organization of gangs in Chicago. While the class, racial, and generational differences among these studies are notable, they each still highlight the complexity of nuance in everyday urban life.

Matthew Desmond's groundbreaking work, *Evicted*, is a particularly moving example of the power of ethnography in housing research (Desmond 2016). While many quantitative methods might show the prevalence of legal evictions, they do not reveal the lived experiences and detailed interactions between landlords and tenants in the Milwaukee metro area. By gaining lived experience and access, Desmond illustrated the mutual dependence and struggles of these actors (Desmond 2014). He also highlighted the extrajudicial evictions that occur, especially in disadvantaged communities, which are not reflected in eviction data (Desmond 2012). Desmond's work demonstrates the processes that are central to ethnographies (Katz 2010).

Within gentrification research, one of the most notable ethnographies *There Goes the 'Hood*, paints a picture of gentrification with substantial nuance (Freeman 2006). Freeman showed how there were complex and contradictory experiences of residents in two Black New York City neighborhoods. While some welcomed investment, decreases in crime, and new amenities, others felt community loss, complained of the increased cost of living, and felt concern over displacement. Without interviews and ethnography, gentrification would be relegated to little more than relations of numbers alone.

Within gentrification research, ethnography has played a key role, but it has frequently been focused on predominantly Black communities in the largest American cities, including Chicago, New York, and Washington D.C. (Boyd 2008; Freeman 2006; Valli 2015). While this is not necessarily an issue, these ethnographic findings may not be generalizable to other cities and white or non-black neighborhoods. Within Columbus, there has been gentrification research on predominantly white neighborhoods, including Victorian Village and German Village, these studies were not ethnographies (Fusch 1980; Mergler 1984). Meanwhile, within Franklinton, studies of gentrification exist, yet not on ethnography (Carlsten 2019; Neff-Estle 2017; Scully 2019; Sweeney 2014). To my knowledge, only one other ethnography of Franklinton has been conducted (Steigmann-Gall 2020). However, this work focused primarily on the artist community in Franklinton and not on the general resident population of the neighborhood. As such, studying residents through ethnography can describe a complex and contradictory story alongside the quantitative work of other chapters in this dissertation.

Photographs

Just as ethnography captures lived experience in a snapshot within time and space, photography captures the built environment within time and space. Furthermore, just as people feel the neighborhood changing and describe these changes due to gentrification, images demonstrate how the built environment can shape the experience of those changes. The use of photographs in ethnography, also called visual ethnography, treats the field site as the social laboratory, allowing the researcher to ground themselves in the field. Furthermore, it allows for reflexivity in the research process by building data from the point of view of subjects (Harper 1987, 1988). While a camera might be an objective observer, photographs, like interviews and ethnography, require interpretation from a researcher (Pink 2008). As such, it is important to note that an individual's background and experiences inform how they interpret these images, and one must acknowledge these assumptions and biases.

One of the most notable uses of visual sociology stems from Systematic Social Observation (SSO) (Sampson and Raudenbush 1999). Relying on visual cues of social and physical disorder, these Chicago School sociologists measured the level of social disorganization by driving down Chicago blocks, recording, and making observations. This method was groundbreaking and difficult to replicate, but it highlighted the importance of the visual cues and record to understanding the world around us. More recently, urban scholars and sociologists have begun to use photography, including those from Google StreetView®, to exhibit gentrification over time, particularly for the built environment (Hwang and Sampson 2014; Li et al. 2022). However, in combination with

computational sociology, methods have grown more complex, including the use of machine learning to identify and quantify other variables related to gentrification, including signs of social disorder and trash (Hwang et al. 2023; Ilic, Sawada, and Zarzelli 2019; Thackway et al. 2023).

While sociologists often analyze visual cues in urban environments, the perspectives of residents are equally crucial. Sociologists might prioritize certain areas during ethnographic studies, but residents' interpretations of their surroundings offer valuable insights. Recognizing this, Stone (2013) asked residents to photograph spaces they deemed important. The residents highlighted green spaces, historic buildings, art installations, and cafes. This underscores the importance of incorporating residents' perspectives when identifying significant spaces, rather than solely relying on sociologists' interpretations. Within Franklinton, photographs have been used to study gentrification (Scully 2019). Yet, as development continues and the city continues to grow, these images still represent only a small snapshot in time. This is not to say that this previous work is not important. Instead, development can occur so quickly that these images only tell part of the story, which is why new photographic evidence is important to representing current conditions and lived experience in the neighborhood. Additionally, this method of using interviews and photographs together, photo elicitation, highlights the multiple qualitative methods used in this study to highlight the lived experience of gentrification at a given point in time (Harper 2002).

Current Study

Gentrification is an incredibly complex subject that is often hyper-local. The current study builds on previous gentrification research, providing a case study of gentrification in a growing midwestern metropolis that is often ignored in urban studies. Since gentrification is a neighborhood-based phenomenon, focusing on one neighborhood can illuminate themes that make gentrification unique in one neighborhood. As such, I present a case study of gentrification in the Franklinton neighborhood of Columbus, Ohio using interviews and ethnography to highlight how residents experience their experience and perceive gentrification. To research the lived experience associated with gentrification, the current study utilizes the following research questions to guide it: 1) What are the lived experiences of different groups and individuals in Franklinton? 2) How do they make sense of neighborhood changes, gentrification, and their positionality? and 3) What makes Franklinton a gentrifiable neighborhood?

While these were the guiding research questions and open-ended, I had two hypotheses prior to entering fieldwork: 1) long-term, minority residents will view the neighborhood changes with more negative opinions and 2) newer, white, upper-middle class residents will view the changes as mainly positive. These hypotheses were based on work that previous ethnographers had conducted in other American cities (Freeman 2006).

Methods

Interviews

Between August 2023 and March 2024, semi-structured, in-depth interviews were conducted with residents of Franklinton. The participants included both long-term and new residents. Long-term residents were defined as individuals who had lived in Franklinton for 10 years or more, while new residents had moved to the neighborhood within the past 10 years. This 10-year cutoff is a high longevity threshold commonly used in quantitative gentrification research (Bunten et al. 2023; Freeman 2005; Hammel and Wyly 1996).

Interview participants were identified through several means to strengthen the outreach of both snowball and more purposive sampling strategies. Initially, recruitment involved reaching out to specific notable community members via email and telephone. In several instances, I asked residents in-person about their interest to participate. To reach a greater number of potential participants, flyers were printed and posted around the neighborhood on telephone poles, in places of business, and at certain community organizations. Finally, several internet forums and groups, including Reddit and Facebook were used to recruit residents. Residents were also encouraged to share information about the study with people they know. Through these means, a purposive sampling technique was used to focus on a diverse and representative sample of residents (Kemper 2003).

The interviews were conducted in various settings, including coffee shops, offices, residents' homes, and via Zoom. Most interviews lasted approximately 60-90

minutes, with the longest interview lasting just over three hours. In more public settings, every effort was made to provide those being interviewed with as much responsive privacy as the settings allowed. Upon consenting to an interview, participants were asked various questions about their history in Franklinton, their occupation, their neighborhood routines, their connection to the neighborhood, how they feel about neighborhood changes, interactions with developers and government officials, and expectations for the future (Appendix B) based on previous gentrification research as well as specific questions related to Franklinton (Freeman 2006; Newman and Wyly 2003; Sweeney 2014). However, many interviews diverged from the protocol and onto other topics. As time went on, I had more specific questions to ask, as new themes illuminated themselves, including race and crime. In each instance, the questions remained well within the approved parameters of the Interview Guide approved by Institutional Review.

Following the interview, participants were asked to complete a demographic survey, which was formed with the assistance of several faculty members (Appendix C) and took approximately 5 minutes. This survey asked about age, gender, sexuality, race/ethnicity, educational attainment, rent, occupation, household details, housing insecurity, and marital status. After the interview and demographic survey, participants were provided a \$20 gift card, which was distributed via email.

Interviews were audio recorded on a cell phone, uploaded to Otter.ai, and checked for errors by four trained undergraduate research assistants as well as the author. Afterwards, participant identities were anonymized and assigned pseudonyms. Participants were ensured confidentiality as to receive honest answers and to avoid

repercussion. After each interview, the demographic survey data was uploaded to a spreadsheet on a password-protected computer.

The original goal was to interview 20 long-term and 20 new residents of Franklinton. However, as the study progressed, saturation was reached with a total of 37 interviews (Hennink and Kaiser 2022; Hennink, Kaiser, and Marconi 2017; Saunders et al. 2018). These data are presented in Table 12, a detailed breakdown of the interviewees (N=37), categorized by length of residency, race/ethnicity, gender, sexuality, and status as an artist. The participants included 17 long-term residents and 20 new residents. While purposive sampling was used to achieve a representative sample of Franklinton, there were challenges in reaching certain groups, particularly the Latine and Asian populations. This challenge is understandable given that Franklinton is primarily a low-income, white neighborhood, as there were fewer potential Latine and Asian respondents to draw on.

Broken down by race, there were 31 white participants, 6 black participants, one Asian participant, and one Latine participant. By gender, there were 17 male participants, 19 female participants, and one non-binary participant. Regarding sexuality, there were eight LGBT participants. Finally, there were three participants that were artists. Although not located in the table, there are several data points of interest. Four interviewees had been displaced from Franklinton entirely for various reasons, and six interviewees had experienced housing insecurity within the last year.

These data points and demographic surveys were collected to ensure the creation a diverse sample of residents in line with previous gentrification research. Many scholars have highlighted the role of the LGBT community, artists, race, in gentrification, thus I

made sure to interview several members of these groups (Christafore and Leguizamon 2018; Fallon 2021; Goldberg-Miller and Heimlich 2017; Lees 2016; Sweeney 2014).

Characteristic	N
Residents	37
Long	17
New	20
White	31
Black	6
Asian	1
Latine	1
Male	17
Female	19
Non-Binary	1
LGBT	8
Artists	3

Table 12. Demographics of the Residents

Ethnography

To understand more about neighborhood processes, I spent one-year conducting , following in the footsteps of previous ethnographers (DuBois 1899; Price-Spratlen 2022; Venkatesh 2002; Whyte 1993). I utilize a relational ethnographic approach that focuses on fields rather than places (Desmond 2014). While the Franklinton neighborhood was the focus of the study, interviews and ethnography took me around the city and exposed me to many different intersectional groups, including artists, current residents, former residents, and social services.

Fieldwork took place throughout the Franklinton neighborhood between August 2023 and May 2024. During this time, I conducted this ethnography by participating and

observing neighborhood events and generally spending time in the Franklinton neighborhood. Throughout this year, I was on fellowship, which enabled to me to spend a substantial amount of time in the Franklinton neighborhood. Each week, I spent at least 4 hours in the neighborhood, typically taking two trips per week. I spent my time in the neighborhood walking around, riding my bike, attending community events, viewing art spaces, sitting at coffee shops, drinking at bars, and volunteering at a food pantry. During fieldwork, I brought a notebook and took field notes. At other times when more discretion was needed, I took field notes on my phone to avoid unwanted attention. These field notes were then put into word documents on a password protected computer and uploaded to NVivo.

Gaining Entrée

While I had initially intended to live in the neighborhood, I was ultimately unable to due to monetary limitations. Thus, as a non-resident researcher, gaining entrée to the neighborhood and getting people to trust me was a concern. For people to trust me, I decided to spend more time in the neighborhood, especially in West Franklinton. On average, I drove to the neighborhood and spent several hours there two times per week to conduct fieldwork, including community events, art spaces, coffee shops, bars, and a food pantry. In addition, I read up on Franklinton history and Columbus history enough to engage in conversation and understand some of the basic lived experience of residents in the neighborhood. Unlike other ethnographic research of the lower-income neighborhoods, which are typically predominantly black and Latine, Franklinton is majority white (Venkatesh 2002). In this instance, it was beneficial to be a phenotypically

white male, as I was not as obviously seen as an outsider. Additionally, having grown up in a rural, lower-income town in Indiana, I was no stranger to some of the issues ongoing in the community, including poverty and drug use.

After some of the interviews and as a result of spending time in the community, I was invited to bars, community events, volunteer opportunities, and restaurants. These instances allowed me to meet more people, spread the word about the study, recruit more participants, and spend more time in the neighborhood. I knew this was a fruitful effort because at many points throughout the year, I would run into former interviewees while conducting fieldwork, or people would recognize me from community events. It was through these instances that I knew I had gained *entrée*.

Coding and Analysis

Following the documentation of transcriptions and field notes, these documents were uploaded to NVivo for coding and analysis on a password protected computer. Throughout this work, I moved back and forth from research questions to the raw data to inductively derive codes. After initially deriving codes, I then conducted two rounds of NVivo coding to analyze the interviews and field notes based on a grounded coding theoretical framework (Charmaz 2014; Lareau 2021; Maher et al. 2018; Strauss and Glaser 1967). As a part of this, I read through each interview and field note, taking notes on broad themes and codes. For the second round, I read through each interview and field note again, making sure to try and identify subcodes. This grounded, inductive process enabled critical codes to arise. Several broad themes arose from this work, including

Social (Dis)Organization, Space and Place, and Housing Insecurity along with subcodes for each.

Photography

Because this project spans a year, I mainly focus on photographs I took highlight the neighborhood in a certain space and time. My personal photography is only taken to demonstrate what gentrification and the built environment looked like during 2023 and 2024. However, based on fieldwork, and particularly interviews with residents, there are some older photographs gathered of since-demolished buildings. Aside from these photographs, mainly of the now-raised public housing projects in Franklinton, the other photographs were taken by me on my phone. Images remained on a password-protected computer. These images do not show individuals nor addresses, and they mainly highlight the built environment. I took these photos as discretely and as quickly as possible while walking, biking, and driving around the neighborhood during ethnography. These images mainly serve as an aide to the interviews and ethnographic methods that are the focus of the paper.

Results

Race

Throughout interviews, both long-term and new residents discussed historical and contemporary racial tension in the neighborhood. While this might not be shocking in a midwestern city with a history of segregation (Jacobs 1998; Rothstein 2017) and given the prevalence of research on white spaces (Anderson 2015; Massey and Denton 1998), it was not a theme I expected when entering the field. Before beginning ethnography and

interviews, many people told me that many of the residents of Franklinton were from Appalachia or were the descendants of Appalachians, particularly from Southeast Ohio, West Virginia, and Kentucky. This produced complex racial dynamics in the field.

As described by many of the residents, the Appalachian background of the neighborhood runs deep and informs both the culture of the neighborhood and how it developed. “Most of the people that settled here were from Appalachia...it was a different kind of poor. It was a white poor” (Larry, a 34-year-old white male new resident). These connections ran deep, as described by Sally, a 67-year-old white long-term resident: “You never lost touch with anybody in Berea, Kentucky; Harlan County, Kentucky; Jackson, Ohio; Pikesville; Gallipolis.” Residents described this as a unique part of the Franklinton cultural sphere, for better and for worse, especially when it came to race:

When I was a kid, if you were black, you lived on that [north] side of Broad Street...because this was a redneck hillbilly neighborhood. That's the only way I know how to describe it. Most of our folks that lived here had come from West Virginia and Kentucky and the coal mines and had moved north and settled here and really had that mentality, which also made for good hard-working people. Nothing wrong with it, but that's just where it was. (Debra, 71-year-old long-term white resident)

The racial segregation of Franklinton was a surprise to me, but as interviews continued more and more residents discussed the history of racial tension in the neighborhood, both from the perspective of white and black residents. Cindy, a 65-year-old long-term white resident discussed segregated spaces when she was younger, saying “Blacks couldn’t go south of Broad Street and whites couldn’t go north of Broad.” Broad Street, the East-West Corridor that runs through the center of Columbus, also divides

Franklinton by north and south and acted as a natural barrier between white and black people, and there is still substantial racial variation along this boundary. Segregation was also supported by the Columbus Public Schools “I very much so never went to school with black people until I hit Sterling [Middle School].” Cindy also stated that “not many white people could go up in there [Riverside Bradley, a public housing complex].” These large, now demolished public housing complexes in East Franklinton housed many black families.

Cindy also said that her parents limited her interactions with black people, and they supported racist ideologies. “Unless I took somebody, my parents wouldn't let me go to Sunshine [Pool].” Sunshine Pool was next to Sunshine Terrace, another public housing complex with a significant number of black families. To my surprise, Cindy also described her father’s ideology: “My dad and I's quality time...if it wasn't a horse track, it was the KKK in West Jeff....My dad said ‘You have to work with them. You have to go to school with them, but they ain't gotta be at your fucking dinner table or in your bed.’” To Cindy, these beliefs were normal in Franklinton. According to Cindy, these racial tensions sometimes even boiled over. “If a black family rented a house or bought a house where they wasn't supposed to, they woke up with a burning cross,” she said matter-of-factly.

For black residents, they also identified historical and contemporary racial tensions. Wendy, a 68-year-old, long-term black resident of the neighborhood said “When I was growing up, most white people moved out because black people were moving in. We had a neighbor that was white and my father, and the owner of the home

they didn't get along at all. They never spoke.” Between her father and their neighbor, there was racial tension. Wendy continued, saying:

“And so, dad was very, very racist, but his family wasn't...My father was born in the South...But he's carried the same kind of stuff, you know, that he has seen in the south when he would talk about lynchings and cotton fields and duh-duh-duh that was kind of what he based his mentality on.”

Wendy said that these racial tensions were not so important as children, but they were aware of them, and they became more prominent as she grew older.

“My first boyfriend in elementary school was blond haired and blue eyed. And he used to wanna come over and visit me, and I was like, "That's not a good idea," because of my father. Most of us [black and white kids] started in kindergarten together, and then we went to junior high school, it was kind of like the white kids that I grew up with really didn't deal with the black kids that they grew up with. And then by the time we got to high school there was total, you know, separation.”

It is easy to imagine that these kinds of racial tensions were common in the 1960s up through the 1980s when Columbus City Schools desegregated (Jacobs 1998). For over twenty years, Columbus City Schools “got around Brown” and pursued segregation in public schools, thus highlighting the institutional racism and racial animus in Columbus’ recent history. However, for some it is harder to imagine that they persist in some ways. When I interviewed Marcus, 24, a new Black resident of Franklinton, he described feeling out of place in the neighborhood:

When I first moved here, it was kind of strange. And when I was working, I was the only person of color, so it was...it's uncomfortable, but like, obviously I would say ‘Like I know I'm the only person of color here,’ and people acknowledge that, and it was really nice. There's only tension with ...like I feel like there's only tension with certain neighbors because like I would go and like say hi to them or something like that and [they appeared to] give me a cold shoulder. But if it's my [white] partner, they will acknowledge them. So, it's like I don't want to assume but like, how can you not? So, I choose to avoid those situations and those people. Like it's just like the not acknowledging me that bothers me a lot.

Here, Marcus described his younger coworkers as being accepting despite him being the only person of color at his place of work. However, neighbors and older residents would ignore him but not his white partner, which was frustrating. Unfortunately, this was not Marcus' only experience with racism in Franklinton:

We just had a new director... a person of color. We hadn't had a person of color working on that team whatsoever, and she just got a race threat. Like the first week that she worked here. And they sent her letters and stuff like that and told her that she needs to quit.

Marcus described this experience with shock and dismay. It has been these kinds of experiences that made Marcus feel out of place in Franklinton, even at public art events, like Franklinton Fridays:

If you go to Franklinton Fridays, [they are] predominantly white. I think a lot of people of color don't come to those events. When you know you're in a space that's predominantly white as a person of color, you kind of have to think about where you stand and how you can navigate certain areas and you just don't know people. You don't know how people are gonna take you and it's just like, always on the lookout type of thing.

Franklinton's history and these art events, were racialized and led to feelings of exclusion, which is backed up by previous gentrification research (Shaw and Sullivan 2011). To be clear, residents of Franklinton were nothing but kind, cordial, and warm to me, and I would not categorize them all or even most of them as racist. However, the history of race in America is still something that we have yet to reckon with, and it impacts us today. Furthermore, race matters in discussing the trajectory of gentrification in Franklinton as previous research suggests that majority white gentrifying tracts experience increases in white and higher-income residents (Rucks-Ahidiana 2021, 2022). The white, Appalachian background of Franklinton influenced the neighborhood, keeping

it segregated by making it hostile to black people. This kept Franklinton majority white, and this primed Franklinton for gentrification, making gentrification more likely to occur and faster when it began occurring (Hwang and Sampson 2014).

Compared to other neighborhoods in Columbus that are talked about as gentrifying, like Olde Town East, the visual and demographic differences between the neighborhoods are staggering. Olde Town East is still a predominantly black neighborhood and lacks the hotels, five-over-ones, and cafes that have sprouted up in Franklinton. This may be because investors and new residents feel more comfortable moving into a white neighborhood, and the white residents of Franklinton feel more comfortable with more white people moving in. This lack of division may lead to a feeling of complacency among white residents. For most new and long-term residents, they experience little racial threat. While there is a class threat component, it was not something that most residents of Franklinton described. Instead, they saw poverty, crime, and disorder as greater threats to the community.

Social (Dis)Organization

Like many other poor, inner-city neighborhoods in the United States, Franklinton suffers from problems related to drug use, crime, sex work, and other examples of social disorder. This, too, may make it more difficult to push back against gentrification. Social Disorganization Theory, created by Park and Burgess, Sampson, and other Chicago School sociologists described how areas of the city with low social control and collective efficacy lead to more violence, less community trust, and less trust in institutions (Browning et al. 2004, 2017; Park and Burgess 1925; Sampson 2012). Residents of

Franklinton, both long-term and new, explained how the neighborhood suffers from social disorganization, including crime, homelessness, garbage, and mistrust. Through this social disorganization, the lack of collective efficacy and community trust may have made it more difficult to mobilize against gentrification policies and development.

Crime

Crime in Franklinton has garnered significant attention, especially on Sullivant Avenue, due to its violent crime, drug use, and sex work as described by a series of news stories called “Suffering on Sullivant” (Zachariah et al. 2019). Throughout my ethnography, residents warned me about crime in the neighborhood, especially telling me to avoid certain parts of the neighborhood. During interviews, many residents discussed crime as a significant problem in their neighborhood and their lack of trust in the Columbus police. As shown in the quantitative chapter, crime in Franklinton, particularly East Franklinton was incredibly high. Residents associated this crime with the entire neighborhood, but especially with the public housing projects that were torn down in 2012 that were in East Franklinton.

[Riverside Bradley] was like the worst project in Columbus. They're like so old and like people are getting murdered there like every fucking day basically, like it was a mess. You know, they could have built like, new nice projects there, but they didn't. Yeah, because there's like, it's money time. Yeah. I think they're ugly. I think they're overpriced. But it's nice that there's like, a coffee shop there. (Chris, 37-year-old, white long-term resident)

Due to its long history of crime and disinvestment from the city, many long-term residents lacked institutional trust, especially the police. As a result of their lack of trust in police, residents were more willing to take action into their own hands. While volunteering in the community, one resident (Tucker, a middle-aged white man) told me

about an instance where his car was getting broken into at a supermarket in the neighborhood. When he noticed the scene, he released his dog on the culprit and shot them in the leg. Afterwards, he was arrested, questioned, and eventually let go by Columbus Police. Unfortunately, this was far from the only story I heard from residents about this kind of situation.

Chris, a 37-year-old white long-term resident and bar owner, described a situation in his neighborhood bar:

Like, I've had a gun pulled on me in here. And like it was a black lady and she was like, "I'm killing every white dude in here." And even after that I didn't start carrying a gun. I was like, "You're not shooting anybody. Like, no one did anything to you." I just kept walking towards her, and she kept like walking back with a 9mm like in my face. It was like, just got her out the door closed and locked it. Then, she like rampaged in the street for a while, like beating up people as they walked by, and like cops came.

On the other hand, new residents were more likely to feel concerns about crime and more willing to call the police and have some semblance of trust in institutions, as J described, "There's a [police] neighborhood liaison...I was like, 'Dude, what do I do? Like this neighborhood, it's terrifying. Do my wife and I need to move?' He's like, 'It's a great 10-year investment'" (Joshua, 37-year-old white male new resident). These new residents, which came from other parts of the state and the Columbus metropolitan area, have had vastly different experiences with police and were more likely to trust them.

Due to lack of trust in police, long-term residents were more willing to take dangerous situations into their own hands. The lack of trust in community, fear of crime, and lack of trust in government officials and institutions contributes to the social disorganization and lack of collective efficacy in the community. This has likely made it

difficult for residents of Franklinton to push back against gentrification, including private investment and government decisions to demolish and incentivize building in the neighborhood.

Unlike Franklinton, other neighborhoods around the U.S. that have organized resistance to gentrification have a strong community signaling, strong attachments to community places, alliances between residents, and community ownership of land. These communities, unlike Franklinton, also tend to be, or at one point were majority-minority neighborhoods, thus potentially leading to increased community belonging, inclusion, and cultural cohesion. These neighborhoods and cities include Rainier Beach in Seattle, Pilsen in Chicago, and Adams-Morgan in Washington, D.C. among others (King and Lowe 2018; Lloyd 2016; Maharawal and McElroy 2018; Osuntoki and Gross Shader 2020).

Franklinton lacks most of these anti-gentrification measures. There are no substantial groups fighting displacement, few alliances between residents, decreased attachment to community places, and community-owned land. Altogether, the social disorganization of the Franklinton community appears to demobilize individuals and groups, thus making it more likely to gentrify. While there were a handful of instances of the community coming together to push back against gentrification, this was certainly not the norm.

Loss of Place

Through displacement, the change in the built environment, and the renaming of the neighborhood, residents of Franklinton described changes to the community that they

felt as negative, feeling both a sense of loss and of place in the physical and emotional sense. As the neighborhood continues to gentrify and develop, the areas that spurred gentrification, like the art spaces, have begun to become sites of contestation and displacement.

Housing Insecurity and Displacement

During my ethnography in the neighborhood, I could hardly walk a block without seeing construction ongoing, including a new build or a home renovation. When the weather was nice, the air buzzed with the sounds of saws and the thumping of hammers. With the income of the neighborhood so low, much of the capital for these changes had to come from somewhere outside the neighborhood. While new residents and revitalization are not necessarily a bad thing for the neighborhood, it impacts long-term residents of the neighborhood. Time and time again, I heard of people moving out of the neighborhood and social services moving further west to follow these groups, and this was largely due to rising cost of rent and taxes. While many city officials and members of the political economy in Columbus downplayed the prevalence of displacement in Franklinton, residents recognized that it was a common occurrence.

When asked about whether they knew people that had to move out of the neighborhood, Cindy and Tina described the gentrification by saying “Yeah, T and George and Judd...and oh my god, Nick. Chris. Nobody can afford to rent. I mean, everything is going up but my damn check.” Cindy (65, white) and Tina (58, white), life-long friends and residents of Franklinton depicted how they and their friends no longer lived in the neighborhood that they grew up in because of rising costs. They also went on

to describe how people moved to the South side, Circleville, or Hilltop after leaving Franklinton.

Similarly, another new resident described being unable to stay in the neighborhood due to rising costs. When Lloyd's (35-year-old white male new resident) landlord told him that he was going to raise the rent, he was unable to afford it. As a result, "I actually moved into my parents' for a few months. I had to leave Columbus for a few months then I came back. It was tough." When describing the neighborhood, Lloyd continued "There's even whole streets [that] have a significant amount being rehabbed and flipped. They're well out of my affordability now. My girlfriend and I have been looking at houses in the 250 to 350 range, and they're out of my price range, and that's for two people." With the rising costs, even seemingly middle-class residents can often no longer afford to live in Franklinton, as rents rising above \$1300 per month in 2019 in North of Broad. So, if middle-class residents can barely afford to live there, this means that the situation is even more dire for lower-income residents.

Even for those that have not been displaced, they recognized the dangers that gentrification caused for long-term residents and the neighborhood as a whole. Lesley, a 24-year-old non-binary new resident explained:

The closer you get to downtown, the more pricey it gets. Like we're trying to make this area into like this posh place, you know? Either pay or get out. Which is sad because there's always people getting pushed out. I feel that way too, like my area like looks completely different [from when I first moved here]. It looks so like, nice clean, and I've seen the people getting pushed out, and I feel really bad, and it kind of makes me guilty for living there sometimes.

Lesley said they recognized that they were part of the reason for the gentrification, but that the cost-of-living crisis prevented them from living elsewhere. I heard this frequently

during my interviews and time on the street. New residents were aware that they were gentrifiers, but they were often priced out of other areas of the city, leading them to move to Franklinton, where there was still some semblance of affordability for middle-class households. This was highlighted during my ethnography.

During a free, fall-themed community event in an urban garden in Franklinton in the fall of 2023, I observed a striking juxtaposition between new and long-term residents, including the lack of interaction between the two groups. The garden, affiliated with an organization managing multiple plots across the neighborhood, featured three greenhouses, a tree, and a pizza oven. Situated near a historic local school and a community house, the garden was physically accessible to a wide range of residents. As part of the event, attendees were offered free vegetables, vegetarian food from a food truck, pizza, and apple cider. Meanwhile, a small band played Midwestern emo music, adding a unique atmosphere to the gathering.

Despite the event's lively and welcoming nature, it was evident that most attendees were newer residents of the neighborhood, suggesting that this event may not have been entirely socially accessible. This was apparent through both their appearance and conversations with individuals like Lesley. The younger attendees, who could be described as "edgy" or "hipster," wore Carhartt beanies, denim jackets, black t-shirts, and displayed tattoos and nose piercings. In contrast, many long-term residents dressed more casually in hoodies and sweatpants and appeared to be neither volunteers nor employees of the garden. While the event was enjoyable and interesting, the demographic makeup of the attendees underscored the displacement and lack of community cohesion between

new and long-term residents, highlighting the ongoing challenges of gentrification in the area.

Similarly, Karen (30-year-old, white female new resident) described the displacement ongoing in the neighborhood:

People who have lived here a really long time and aren't as wealthy are aging out of being here. And or if they're not owning property, then they're getting rent hiked out of living here, so the poor are being pushed out. I don't think rich but the middle class is moving in. And, obviously, I have mixed emotions about that, because I don't want to be responsible for pushing someone out...I call it Flip City Franklinton... And I feel like the best I can do is like, be a good neighbor, and be a person in this neighborhood who's like, not a jerk and not a racist, because we do have a few.

Karen explained how she viewed the neighborhood with conflicting emotions. While she could not afford to find a home elsewhere in the city with her buying power, she also did not want to feel responsible for causing displacement. At the same time, Karen and Lesley appeared to be engaged, concerned neighbors in Franklinton. While they still moved to Franklinton, they certainly acknowledged the displacement that was ongoing in the neighborhood.

Like the city officials that denied the prevalence of displacement, many urban scholars have been quick to downplay displacement. Citing eviction data, these scholars claim that gentrification actually leads to fewer evictions compared to areas of concentrated poverty (Hepburn et al. 2024; Vigdor et al. 2002). However, there are reasons for this, as eviction data frequently are inaccurate, and many evictions are informal or illegal (Panfil, Zainulbhai, and Robustelli 2021; Zainulbhai and Daly 2022). Furthermore, when long-term residents are displaced during gentrification, they may move out of the neighborhood and will not be evicted in that neighborhood any longer,

simply pushing the problem elsewhere, like Hilltop. Through my interviews and ethnography, most long-term and new residents recognized and showed concern about the displacement and housing insecurity growing in Franklinton. Aside from physical displacement, there were other ways that residents experienced loss of place.

Renaming and Removing

Neighborhoods change over time, as do cities and societies, and this manifests through name changes. Certainly, German Village and Hungarian Village in Columbus are no longer home to those ethnic groups like they once were, yet these names remain. Meanwhile, the name of Franklinton has changed over time and remains highly contested. While the Franklinton neighborhood was founded and named by Lucas Sullivant, the neighborhood has also gone by “The Bottoms”, even within historical sociological research (McKenzie 1921a). Officially, the name of the neighborhood, as defined by the city of Columbus, is Franklinton; however, the boundaries that are drawn have changed, and internal boundaries have given rise to the naming of different parts of the neighborhood. During interviews and ethnography, I had to be careful about what I referred to the neighborhood as and whether I used the term East Franklinton or not, as some residents felt that distinguishing between East and West Franklinton was insensitive.

Older residents of the neighborhood were more likely to call the neighborhood “The Bottoms” or Franklinton without distinguishing between East and West. To them, all of Franklinton, and they did not want to lose connection to the Eastern part of the neighborhood. When referring to the neighborhood as the Bottoms, it serves as a way to

connect with other long-term residents of the neighborhood, as described by Stephen, a 37-year-old, male bi-racial long-term resident)

And nowadays, I still like to call it the Bottoms sometimes because it's a historical thing. You know, I am glad that Franklinton is being built up, but you can almost tell who's not from the West side, if like, they just call it Franklinton because like, I'll talk to people now that I grew up with and be like, Yeah, I bought a house in Franklinton. They're like: "Oh, you're in the Bottoms?"

On the other hand, new residents of the neighborhood did not take offense with this. They called the Eastern part of the neighborhood "East Franklinton" and sometimes created further geographic distinction, calling the area with the COSI Museum the "Scioto Peninsula." Lawrence, a 57-year-old white new resident described his feelings about the geographic distinction colorfully saying "You can't ignore that shit. You have to recognize it. That's when people get like salty about 'Oh, East Franklinton, West Franklinton.' East Franklinton was a thing...in 2002. I read the East Franklinton overlay that the city did. Nobody gave a shit because it was a fucking ghetto shit hole." Lawrence believes that the geographic distinction between East and West Franklinton has existed for over 20 years, was established by the city, and the Eastern area was very different and dangerous. Thus, he believes that people are overexaggerating the importance of now differentiating between East and West.

Meanwhile, private developers have pushed even further geographic distinction, including the renaming the Scioto Peninsula as "Little West", in reference to the area being West of Downtown Columbus; however, this has not gained popularity (Edwards 2023). Stephen, too, felt strongly about this because the investment is both trying to take advantage of the development of Franklinton while also trying to change the name:

And what's sad is like you would think that... you would think people would take more pride in Franklinton because this is the first settlement...But, so that I kind of like, got a little pissed off when I read [about Little West]...Like, don't come and try to like change the name of the neighborhood if you're already trying to say you're in Franklinton anyway, you know?

In spite of these name changes, an old sign and map on Broad Street remains near the railroad tracks that still calls the entire area Franklinton in spite of efforts to rebrand. Like the continual rebranding of the neighborhood, long-term neighborhood residents will likely continue to call the neighborhood “The Bottoms” or simply Franklinton for some time. However, as new residents move in, new investments move in with them, older residents become displaced, and these new terms will likely solidify, contributing to an even further loss of place and creation of a new one. Altogether, this highlights the lack of local autonomy of long-term Franklinton, where new residents and corporations with capital usurp the language used to define neighborhood space (Brahinsky 2020; Cox 1991; Harvey 1973).

Art Spaces

Artists have long been known as part of the “creative class”, people employed in the arts, music, entertainment, and music (Florida 2003). The creative class has been mobilized to gentrify and revitalize areas due to their lower rents, and they view downtrodden areas as hip and full of opportunities (Ocejo 2019). Within Franklinton, especially East Franklinton, artists and art spaces are a large part of the community fabric, with the neighborhood being known as an arts district with a creative community plan (City of Columbus 2012; Steigmann-Gall 2020). When the neighborhood began regaining popularity and development, 400 West Rich, an old factory, became a huge

attraction and is continually at the center of the neighborhood's popularity (The Atlantic 2014). In East Franklinton, murals are on almost every corner, and there are art events frequently, including Franklinton Fridays, Urban Scrawl, and various others. However, these events and the rise of the creative class in Franklinton has negative consequences, including rising rents (Peck 2005).

As the neighborhood continues to gentrify, these art spaces that were originally intended for low income and starving artists, have become sites of contestation and displacement. For instance, the company that owns 400 West Rich, Urban Smart Growth, has dramatic increased in rent, tripling rent in some cases (Downing 2023; Woods 2023). This has led to some artists leaving the neighborhood or moving their art spaces to Old Towne East. Thomas, a 28-year-old male artist, complained that these rising costs have led to Franklinton "los[ing] its freedom...because if rates are increasing for rent, you have to make money to pay that. So, it really forced everyone to sell then, and some of us don't really care to do that." Instead of authenticity in the arts for art's sake, it has become more about consumerism and capitalism. Artists drew parallels to the Shorth North, which had become unaffordable for artists prior to the rise of Franklinton.

However, 400 West Rich is not the only studio undergoing change. The Vanderelli Room, also owned by Urban Smart Growth, was one of the most beloved and treasured art spaces of the neighborhood, has also left due to the landlord raising rent and not renewing a lease (Evans 2023). Throughout many interviews, many mourned the loss of this cultural institution, but they also recognized that capitalism plays a role in these processes of development. One artist, Alicia, described this succinctly, "Let's not forget

that landlords are in the business of renting space for profit, lest you forget what their mission is. They can be kind, and they can be forgiving, and they can be altruistic, but at the end of the day their mission is to rent space for profit” (Alicia, 57-year-old white new resident). While 400 West Rich may have not been in the business of extracting as much profit as possible at the beginning, it certainly has turned that way.

Interviews and ethnography highlighted how displacement occurred, especially for poorer long-term residents. Even for artists and residents that are relatively new to the neighborhood, they too have begun to experience pain from loss of community, and loss of place due to increased development and displacement likely leading to the gentrification of another area where the cycle will surely continue (Smith 1982). They recognized this as a “natural” part of capitalism that seeks to maximize profit based on the exchange values in cities, and their role in the process, as theorized by critical urban sociologists (Brenner et al. 2012; Harvey 1973, 1974; Marcuse 2009; Smith 1987, 2005). Finally, some artists have begun to feel the pains of rising rents in Franklinton, leading them to seek out cheaper rents in studio spaces elsewhere,

Conclusion

The gentrification of Franklinton can perhaps be best explained and viewed through the eyes of those that experience it daily, its residents. Through 37 interviews and one-year of ethnography, this work contributes to the gentrification literature in several ways. First, it provides a unique study of gentrification of a poor, majority-white neighborhood unlike many other qualitative studies that focus on poor, black neighborhoods in major U.S. cities.

Secondly, this work contributes to the understanding of how and why certain neighborhoods may be more likely to gentrify and why their gentrification might occur faster. In Franklinton, historical racial tensions primed the neighborhood for gentrification since white gentrifiers are more likely to move into white neighborhoods (Hwang and Sampson 2014). Thus, when the flood wall was built, its strategic location, affordability, and lack of minority population made it easier to develop. Given its history as a poor neighborhood and heightened social disorganization, this too has made pushing back against gentrification more difficult, as there was a lack of social cohesion and social capital to push back. This can be demonstrated by residents' concern for crime and lack of trust in institutions.

Third, this work contributes to gentrification research by highlighting that in spite of what many quantitative studies on gentrification may find (Hepburn et al. 2024; Vigdor et al. 2002), there are people in Franklinton that have experienced displacement from their homes and loss of place, both of which are worthy of our research, care, and attention. As Franklinton continues to gentrify, artists and residents alike have begun to feel the effects, and many have left the area in search of more affordable rents.

Initially, I expected the long-term minority residents and newer white, upper-middle class residents to be at odds with how they viewed changes in the neighborhood. However, the reality was much more complex. There were commonalities in both groups, including concerns about crime, cost-of-living, and access to amenities. Additionally, given that the majority of the neighborhood has historically been white, new themes emerged that provided a much richer and deeper perspective on the gentrification of

Franklinton, including the role that race and social disorganization have played. Overall, this story defies a simplistic binary of good versus bad gentrification. Instead, gentrification in Franklinton is a nuanced phenomenon, marked by positive outcomes such as reduced crime, improved access to amenities, and the creation of a mixed-income neighborhood, but also accompanied by the negative consequences of displacement and loss of place for longstanding residents.

Despite its contributions, this study is not without its limitations. Regarding interviews, the study lacks a sizable Latine sample despite my attempts to recruit this population. Furthermore, regarding ethnography, while I attempted to live in Franklinton to conduct an ethnography, I was unsuccessful since I could not afford to live alone in the neighborhood. As a result, the ethnography I conducted likely was less rich than if I had lived in the neighborhood. These limitations are important, and further research should consider these and build on them.

In the future, scholars should continue to examine neighborhoods that do not fit within the typical neighborhood study of gentrification, like Franklinton. More qualitative research should focus on gentrifying neighborhoods not in major U.S. cities that also are not majority minority. Furthermore, scholars must confront the reality that gentrification affects people negatively and displaces people, with some people “falling through the cracks” and not in the data (Chum 2015; Hepburn et al. 2024). Additionally, “the normal turnover in gentrifying and other disadvantaged neighborhoods that do not gentrify masks any mobility that may arise due to gentrification” (Freeman et al. 2024 : 341).

Furthermore, research must address whether gentrification should be considered a net

positive or negative when compared to concentrated poverty (Sharkey 2013; Vigdor et al. 2002). Finally, quantitative scholars could examine the role that social disorganization plays in gentrification, especially to study whether it plays a role in preventing organizing against gentrification.

Overall, through interviews and ethnography, this work elevates the lived experience of gentrification of residents and artists in Franklinton amidst unfettered capitalism in American cities (Harvey 1973; Wily 2022). This work substantially contributes to the work of gentrification research, highlighting what primes a neighborhood for gentrification, including racial tension and social disorganization. Furthermore, it addresses that despite what some quantitative scholars might suggest, gentrification still leads to displacement, which matters to the people that experience it firsthand. Finally, it recognizes the ways in which loss of place extends beyond physical displacement where those with capital rename and remove spaces, usurping the local autonomy of lower class, long-term residents of the neighborhood. The lives of Franklinton's residents matter, and they should not be relegated to statistics. Their lives and experiences are rich and significantly contributed to this work. More research like this is needed to understand how we can make our cities more just and provide the right to the city.

Chapter 5: Conclusion

Amid the affordable housing crisis, the rise of neoliberal urban governance, and the financialization of housing, U.S. cities have become key battlegrounds for housing struggles (Newman and Wyly 2003; Song and Chapple 2024; Wyly 2022; Zukin 1987). Grounded in Critical Urban Theory and New Urban Politics, these dynamics reflect growing economic inequality and the consolidation of power by corporations (Cox 1991, 2020; Harvey 1973; Marcuse 2009). As these processes have unfolded, gentrification has emerged as a focal point of scholarly, journalistic, and public concern. While debates persist regarding the prevalence and impact of gentrification, its distinct capacity to displace individuals and families, erode community ties, and exacerbate social harms underscores its importance as a subject of study.

Franklinton, also known as “The Bottoms”, is a neighborhood in Columbus, Ohio that sits in a floodplain that has seen dramatic changes in its history, particularly its development in the past 20 years. This dissertation has examined the processes involved in gentrification by employing a mixed methods approach to study the phenomenon in the Franklinton neighborhood, including a quantitative study of the changes over time, a study of the political economy of Franklinton and the city, known as the “Columbus Way”, and finally a qualitative study of the lives of Franklinton residents. The dissertation argues that there are a multitude of ways to study gentrification, and this can

bridge the divide between qualitative and quantitative gentrification research (Brown-Saracino 2017; Finio 2022). This approach dissertation allowed for a more comprehensive understanding of gentrification.

In the first chapter of the dissertation, I quantitatively examine and explore the changes in the neighborhood across three census tracts in Franklinton since 1970. Given the variety of indices and variables used to study gentrification quantitatively, the choice to examine more rather than less tells a richer story (Barton 2016a; Brown-Saracino 2017; Finio 2022; Immergluck 2009). As such, I detailed the changes in population, race, income, housing, poverty, education, crime across the neighborhood and by census tract via descriptive statistics, tables, maps, and figures. These descriptives demonstrate drastic changes in the neighborhood, especially for education and income in recent years. I then examined three gentrification indices across time and space, which indicate conflicting findings, with some indicating gentrification while others do not, varying by time and space (Freeman 2005; Landis 2016; Vigdor et al. 2002). These varying results emphasize the need for critical quantitative research in gentrification.

Finally, I used proprietary consumer data to identify where residents of Franklinton move to once leaving and where new residents originate from within Franklin County. I find that residents that leave often move further west into Hilltop and West Franklinton, which are more economically disadvantaged census tracts (Data Axle). New residents, on the other hand, originate from more affluent neighborhoods, like Grandview, Hilliard, Upper Arlington, and Downtown, which are more economically advantaged. Findings from this empirical chapter demonstrate the complexity of

gentrification and the many ways that variables indicate whether gentrification occurred or not. To tell an appropriate story of the gentrification of Franklinton, a multitude of methods and variables must be explored. Regardless, quantitative changes appear dramatic over a relatively short period of time, suggesting that Franklinton's social fabric will never be the same. Following chapters examine why and how these shifts occurred.

The second empirical chapter examined how the mechanisms and explanations behind how these changes in Franklinton occurred. To accomplish this, I conducted 33 interviews with key figures in the development of Columbus and Franklinton, including developers, city officials, neighborhood organizations, etc. I also attended various neighborhood and government meetings leading to approximately 20 hours of ethnography from 10 meetings. Finally, I reviewed historical city-planning documents surrounding Columbus' and Franklinton's development, which dated back to 2000.

Interviews, ethnography, and archival research highlighted how local neighborhood organizations attempted to revitalize and rebuild Franklinton through local cooperation and neighborhood regimes (Webb 2013). However, once the neighborhood gained the attention of larger private and public interests, the Columbus Way and neoliberal state-sponsored development processes in Columbus began driving the rapid gentrification of Franklinton (Rivkin 2015). The "Columbus Way" refers to a particular style of public-private partnership that developed in Columbus, Ohio, often touted as a model of civic collaboration. It emphasizes cooperation between business leaders, government officials, and civic organizations to address local issues and drive economic growth. Some argue that this approach has led to significant urban development,

economic expansion, and a high quality of life in the city. However, the Columbus Way prioritizes corporate interests, giving large businesses disproportionate influence over public policy and urban development, which is best understood by New Urban Politics (Cox 1991, 2020).

To justify their decisions about development, respondents, including developers and city officials, employed supply-side arguments for housing and advocated for neoliberal housing policies, including the use of tax incentives, which takes money from the predominantly-Black school system and further contributes to gentrification (Reece and Abou-Ghalioum 2023; Rucks-Ahidiana 2021, 2022). Finally, the rezoning initiative also grants more power to developers and restricts the power of residents and Area Commissions to compromise with developers, thus furthering the Columbus Way and paving the way for more gentrification throughout Franklinton and the rest of Columbus. Altogether, these findings illuminate the role of neighborhood and local power structures in development and gentrification processes in the context of neoliberal urban governance and capitalism (Cox 1991; Harvey 1973; Logan and Molotch 1987; Stone 1989). Additionally, the chapter highlights the unique nature of the neighborhood regime in Franklinton and political economy within Columbus.

While the quantitative chapter offers essential context, the political economy chapter focuses on how urban governance and capitalism contribute to the gentrification of Franklinton. However, these chapters do not fully address the personal experiences of Franklinton residents. The final empirical chapters bridge this gap by exploring the lived experiences of those enduring gentrification, through interviews, ethnography, and

photography. In this chapter, I conducted 37 interviews with both new and long-term residents and carried out a year of ethnographic fieldwork.

The findings suggest several factors have primed the neighborhood for gentrification. First, respondents highlighted historical—and some ongoing—racial tensions that have created deep-rooted distrust among residents. Additionally, they described the effects of social disorganization, such as crime, poverty, and other forms of disorder, on community interactions. The combination of racial tension and social disorganization has weakened collective efficacy and hampered residents' ability to organize against gentrification, making the neighborhood more vulnerable to displacement.

Despite previous scholarly claims and narratives from political economy regarding gentrification and eviction, residents reported direct experiences of displacement and loss of community (Freeman et al. 2024; Hepburn et al. 2024). Residents expressed both positive and negative views on the changes in Franklinton, yet they felt a lack of control over the neighborhood's development. This lack of autonomy is consistent with the dynamics of neoliberal urban governance, as seen in "The Columbus Way" and NUP, where private interests increasingly dictate the future of the neighborhood and the city.

Ultimately, these findings amplify the voices of Franklinton's residents, revealing the conditions that make a neighborhood susceptible to gentrification and the profound sense of loss that extends beyond physical displacement. This chapter illustrates how race, capitalism, and the neoliberal urban policies of Columbus undermine residents'

agency and local control, including both lower income and higher income residents, contributing to the ongoing gentrification of Franklinton.

Findings from the three empirical studies suggest that gentrification is still worthy of study and requires a critical lens to analyze (Brenner et al. 2012; Cox 1991; Harvey 1973; Marcuse 2009). As capitalism continues to rapidly alter the world around us and the affordable housing crisis worsens, gentrification will become a greater threat to our communities. Additionally, there are national and local contexts that impact our findings and theories of gentrification, and our narrow analytical definitions of gentrification potentially have large consequences for policy solutions. Further research is needed to address these gaps, including more local work within neighborhoods and cities that examine city policies and zoning codes.

It is my hope that these findings help contribute to urban sociology theory and studies of gentrification. Moreso, I hope that they help demonstrate why it is important to view housing as a human right rather than a commodity, especially for local policymakers in Columbus (Pattillo 2013). Policymakers at the local and city level should take note of these findings in order to better serve their constituents rather than city or developer pocketbooks. As Columbus grows and develops, there should be greater opportunities for the people of Franklinton to grow with it, including greater opportunities for resident feedback, affordable housing, and rental protections. Without support, Franklinton residents will be pushed to the periphery and contribute to the further concentration of poverty elsewhere. The people of Franklinton are resilient, kind, and caring people that have a right to their community, and this dissertation highlights

their plight due to poverty and gentrification. Across the country, there are neighborhoods like Franklinton and cities like Columbus that are experiencing similar impacts, and these communities should not be relegated to the periphery, and adopting a critical lens to examine gentrification can help address this need.

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Appendix A. Interview Guide for Political Economy

Introduction

Thank you for agreeing to talk with me today. The purpose of this interview is to gather information about how neighborhood change, development, and gentrification of Franklinton has evolved, the decisions you make about the neighborhood, and how you feel about it. I am going to ask you a variety of questions about your experiences and views related to development within Columbus. The interview should take about 60-90 minutes of your time.

If at any point you feel uncomfortable answering a question, you are free to skip it. If you are uncomfortable, you are welcome to stop the interview at any time, and you will still receive the gift card. Before we get started, I want to ask if it is ok for us to audio record this interview. No one will have access to it, and it will not be identified with your information. Is this alright with you? Do you have any questions before we begin?

Background

- What company/agency do you work for? What is your title and role?
- How long have you worked for this company/agency/organization?
- What does a typical day on the job look like for you?
- What kind of property development are you involved in?

Changes in Franklinton

- What are your general thoughts on Franklinton?
 - What role does it play in Columbus?
- What is your role in the community or in the development in Franklinton?
- How long have you been involved in Franklinton?
- What first attracted you to developing in Franklinton?
- What are some reasons that you are developing property in Franklinton?
- Are there any incentives to develop with Franklinton?
- What are some challenges to developing in Franklinton?
- How would you describe the changes ongoing in Franklinton?
 - Revitalization, gentrification?
 - Equitable or not?
- What are some changes you have noticed in the neighborhood?
 - Crime, poverty, race, housing availability
- Are you familiar with the history of development in Franklinton?
- Do you notice certain demographics or neighborhoods being particularly affected?

- Why do you think that is? Is there a strategy or policy or other action that might help change that?
- What is the ultimate goal for Franklinton?

Residential Interaction

- How have your interactions been with residents?
 - Have these interactions varied between new and old residents?
 - Are residents generally accepting of the change?
 - What changes are they supportive of, and what aren't they supportive of?
 - Have you received any pushback from residents?
 - What has been your reaction?
 - How has this changed over time?
- Are there residential groups you interact with?
- Have you noticed rents increasing in the area?
 - Lack of affordable housing?
 - Displacement (eviction, movement out, gentrification)?

Government and PE Interaction

- Do you work with government officials and agencies?
 - If so, who/what agencies?
 - How have your interactions been with government officials and agencies?
- Do you work with other developers or property owners?
 - How does that work?
- Are there tax incentives to developing in Franklinton?
 - Are there other incentives to developing in Franklinton?
- Are there government restrictions that prevent development?
- How has zoning affected development?
- Who/what government agencies do you feel like have more power in decision-making about developments?
 - City? State? Federal?
 - Quasi-Public organizations? Development corporations?
 - How centralized are these decisions?
- Who/what are the big private investors/developers you see within Central Ohio? Who is making decisions about Franklinton?
 - What about other institutions? Ohio State? Mount Carmel?
 - What about Intel? Honda?
- How do you feel the government, developers, and other stakeholders interact to make decisions surrounding the development of Franklinton?
 - Are the combative, collaborative?
 - Is it fragmented? Blended?
- How has this all changed over time?
- How concerned are you about displacement?
- What does affordable housing meant to you?

Expectations for the Future and Closing Questions

- Have there been changes to the residential population of the neighborhood? How so?
 - What about the properties and structures (Built environment)? How so?
- How do you expect the neighborhood to continue changing?
 - Will there be more development?
- What do you expect for the future of development in Franklinton? Columbus? Central Ohio?
 - How are you preparing for this?
- What do you think Franklinton and Central Ohio need in the future?
- In your opinion, what kind of place would the ideal Franklinton be?
- Do you recommend I talk to any developers, community organizations, or government employees?
- Is there anything else you would like to talk about? Is there some topic you want us to return to? Anything else you'd like to share with me today?

Appendix B. Interview Guide for Residents

Introduction

Thank you for agreeing to talk with me today. The purpose of this interview is to gather information about how neighborhood change, development, and gentrification of Franklinton has evolved, the decisions you make about the neighborhood, and how you feel about it. I am going to ask you a variety of questions about your experiences and views related to development within Columbus. The interview should take about 60-90 minutes of your time.

If at any point you feel uncomfortable answering a question, you are free to skip it. If you are uncomfortable, you are welcome to stop the interview at any time, and you will still receive the gift card. Before we get started, I want to ask if it is ok for us to audio record this interview. No one will have access to it, and it will not be identified with your information. Is this alright with you? Do you have any questions before we begin?

Background

- Tell me a little about yourself.
 - Where are you from? What do you do for work?
- What is your history in Franklinton? How long have you lived here?
- Where do you live in Franklinton?
- Can you tell me about your current living situation?
 - Are you satisfied with your living situation? (probes: what neighborhood do you live in, how many people live with you, have you experienced any recent changes in where you live, who you live with, or other changes, etc.)
- What does your routine look like?

Neighborhood Involvement

- Do you feel connected to the neighborhood?
 - In what ways do you or do you not?
- Are there parts of the neighborhood you do not feel connected to?
- Would you consider yourself a part of any neighborhood group?
- Are you involved in the community at all?
 - How so?
 - (Follow up with businesses frequented, community meetings, churches, etc.)

- Do you feel that involvement in the community has become easier? More difficult?
 - How?

Changes in Franklinton

- Are you familiar with the history of development in Franklinton?
- What are your general thoughts on Franklinton?
 - What role does it play in Columbus?
- What first attracted you to living in Franklinton?
 - New vs. Old Residents
- How would you describe the changes ongoing in Franklinton?
 - Revitalization, gentrification?
 - Equitable or not?
- What are some changes you have noticed in the neighborhood?
 - Crime, poverty, race, housing availability
 - Built environment
 - What are some negative changes ongoing?
 - What are some positive changes ongoing?
- Do you notice certain demographics or neighborhoods being particularly affected by the neighborhood change?
 - Why do you think that is? Is there a strategy or policy or other action that might help change that?
- Are residents generally accepting of the change?
 - What changes are they supportive of, and what aren't they supportive of?
 - Has there been any pushback to development from residents?
 - What has been your reaction?
 - How has this changed over time?
- Have you noticed rents increasing in the area?
 - Lack of affordable housing?
 - Displacement (eviction, movement out, gentrification)?
- What are some areas that you see as representing the change in the neighborhood?
- What are some of the most important spaces to you?
- What areas are the most rapidly developing?

Community and Developer Interactions

- How have your interactions been with developers and property managers?
 - What would you say to them if you had the chance?
- How have your interactions been with government officials?
 - What would you say to them if you had the chance?

- How have your interactions been with residents (new/old)?
 - What would you say to them if you had the chance?
- Do you feel that there is a divide between new and old residents?
 - How so? How not?
- What would you describe the average new resident as?
- What would you describe the average old resident as?
- Have you interacted with city/neighborhood officials surrounding development decisions? have your interactions been with court officials and judges?

Expectations for the Future and Closing Questions

- How would you change the neighborhood for the better? What does Franklinton need?
- In your opinion, what kind of place would the ideal Franklinton be?
- What is the biggest issue the neighborhood is facing?
- Do you have any ideas for policy that might help?
- How do you expect the neighborhood to continue changing?
 - Will there be more development?
- What do you expect for the future of development in Franklinton? Columbus? Central Ohio?
 - How are you preparing for this?
- Is there anything else you would like to talk about? Is there some topic you want us to return to? Anything else you'd like to share with me today?

Closing

Thank you very much for taking the time to talk with me today. I appreciate your willingness to share. Thank you again; I appreciate you and your time. You are always welcome to reach out to me by phone or email.

Appendix C: Demographic Survey

For all respondents:

1. What is your age? _____
2. Please choose one or more races that you consider yourself to be: (check all that apply)
 - a. American Indian or Alaska Native
 - b. Native Hawaiian or Pacific Islander
 - c. Black or African American
 - d. White
 - e. Asian (East Asian, South Asian, Middle Eastern)
 - f. Other: _____
3. What is your gender identity?
 - a. Male
 - b. Female
 - c. Non-binary
 - d. Other
4. What do you think of yourself?
 - a. Straight
 - b. Gay
 - c. Bisexual
 - d. Lesbian
 - e. Queer
 - f. Pansexual
 - g. Asexual
 - h. Other: _____

5. Are you Latino/a/x/e, or Hispanic?
 - a. Yes
 - b. No
6. Were you born in the United States?
 - a. Yes
 - b. No
7. What is the highest grade of school you have completed?
 - a. 0-11th grade
 - b. High school graduate or GED
 - c. Some college or Associate degree
 - d. College graduate or more

For Political Economy (Government Officials, Workers, Developers, etc.):

8. Organizational Affiliation and Position Title: _____
9. How long have you worked at this organization or business? _____
10. How long have you served in this position? _____
11. What neighborhood do you live in? _____
12. How long have you lived there? _____

For Residents of Franklinton:

13. How much is your monthly rent? _____
14. How long have you lived in Franklinton? _____
15. How many people live in your household? _____
16. How many children do you have? _____
17. How would you describe your employment situation (check all that apply):
 - a. Employed and looking for additional work or increased hours
 - b. Day labor
 - c. Disabled and unable to work

- d. Full-time (more than 25 hours)
- e. Part-time (25 hours or less)
- f. Seasonal
- g. Temporary
- h. Unemployed; actively looking for work
- i. Unemployed; not actively looking for work
- j. Retired

18. In the past 12 months have you experienced any of the following (check all that apply):

- a. Been unable to pay or underpaid your rent or mortgage
- b. Have been late paying a rent or mortgage
- c. Been unable to pay or underpaid a utility bill
- d. Have lived with others beyond the expected capacity of your house or apartment
- e. Have been evicted
- f. Have had to stay in a hostile environment because you had no other place to live
- g. Been unsure of where you were going to sleep at night
- h. Had to move
- i. None

19. What is your household income?

- a. Below \$10k
- b. \$10k to \$50k
- c. \$50k to \$100k
- d. \$100k to \$150k
- e. Over \$150k

20. How would you describe your marital status?

- a. Single
- b. Married
- c. Divorced
- d. Widowed
- e. Partnered